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Introduction: Optimistic Africa

What if optimism was a measurable asset and not just a frame of mind?

Optimism is not naïve hope, nor is it a sentimental attachment to possibility. It is a forward-looking assessment that the future can be better than the present . In economic terms, optimism shapes expectations, lowers the perceived risks of investment and unlocks capital and skills. In political terms, it sustains legitimacy by building confidence, hope and trust. In social terms, it influences whether citizens choose to stay in a nation, build social capital and be included.

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Nations rise not only on the strength of their resources, but on the strength of their expectations. Where people believe progress is possible, they start businesses, educate their children, innovate and collaborate. Where investors perceive upward trajectories, they allocate capital. Where institutions signal stability and reform, markets respond.

Optimism, therefore, is not decorative — it is developmental. It is both a leading indicator and a reinforcing driver of growth. Optimism is essential for a nation's progress as it enlarges growth boundaries, encourages and rewards effective risk taking, harnesses and leverages creativity, and embodies confidence and a forward-looking outlook.

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Yet Africa is too often analysed through a deficit lens: fragility, conflict, debt, instability. The cost of media bias is estimated by Africa No Filter at £3.2 billion in inflated interest payments on sovereign debt. It drives risk perceptions that inflate the cost of borrowing money from international institutions. [1]

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These additional cost burdens are at the expense of millions of children who could be educated and immunised against diseases or provide populations in Africa with access to clean drinking water. [2]

The Think Tank Gap Minder has developed a misconception index, which, based on surveys, outlines the extent to which citizens globally have misconceptions about a country's progress on a range of variables. It measures the gap between perception and actual progress based on hard data. On this, 39 African countries have a perception gap of more than 50%, in other words, a situation where progress is underestimated by more than half.

In business terms, the cost of borrowing money for development and projects in Africa is higher than it should be by two to four times based on perceptions of the risk of doing business in Africa. This is driven in part by international ratings agencies, which have been criticized for pricing in an unrealistic risk premium, and historical risk trends on the continent also play a role. Financial and economic institutions on the continent have put the issue on the front burner in their engagement with their international counterparts.

[1] Africa No Filter, The Cost of Media Stereotypes to Africa, 2024.
[2] Kimeu C, Negative stereotypes in the international media cost Africa $3.2bn a year, The Guardian, 17 October, 2024.

A study conducted by Africa No Filer in partnership with the University of Bath, entitled *Stereotypes About Africa in Britain and the United States: A Social Psychological Study of Their Impact on Engagement with Africa*, examined the cost of perception to Africa.

Researchers surveyed 1,126 participants in the UK and the US to examine how perceptions influence engagement with African goods, tourism and culture. A second phase involving 863 US participants tested whether exposure to more accurate and balanced information could change attitudes.

The results show that many respondents continue to associate Africa primarily with poverty, corruption, conflict and underdevelopment. Europe, on the other hand, was more frequently linked to prosperity, modern infrastructure and political stability.

Nearly 58% of responses about Africa focused on animals and nature, compared with less than 17% for Europe.

These perceptions have economic implications. The study found that negative assumptions about governance, economic development and living conditions were associated with lower interest in purchasing African products or engaging with African cultural industries, even though the tourism sector may benefit from wildlife linkages.

In effect, perceptions can become a form of market distortion. They influence consumer behaviour, shape investment decisions and may contribute to higher perceived risks than economic fundamentals justify.

This is why it is so important and urgent to dispel such myths. African leaders such as former South African president Thabo Mbeki and Nelson Mandela as well as former head of the UN Kofi Annan, among many others, have set the stage with their calls for global recognition of a new, more confident and progressive Africa. They have averred that there is no time to waste on pessimism.

Resilience, fortitude, hope and, yes, optimism, are present across the continent, but these do not shape dramatic headlines or get Africa onto the screens and pages of people watching and reading about the world.

Motivational speakers in Africa often say that those who see only Africa's challenges miss its story; they miss the chance to recognise the opportunities and possibilities and the chance to help shape its future.

So, this book takes a different approach. ~~It asks not whether challenges exist - they do- but whether the structural conditions for long-term optimism are strengthening.~~ It looks at whether the fundamentals, capabilities, reforms and outcomes across African nations justify a rational, evidence-based confidence in the continent's trajectory.

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To answer this, we have developed the "Funnel of Optimism" — a framework that organises optimism ~~not as rhetoric, but~~ as structure. At the base of the funnel are the Foundations: peace, governance, and solidarity. These are threshold conditions. Without relative stability, institutional reform, and regional cooperation, sustained optimism cannot take root.

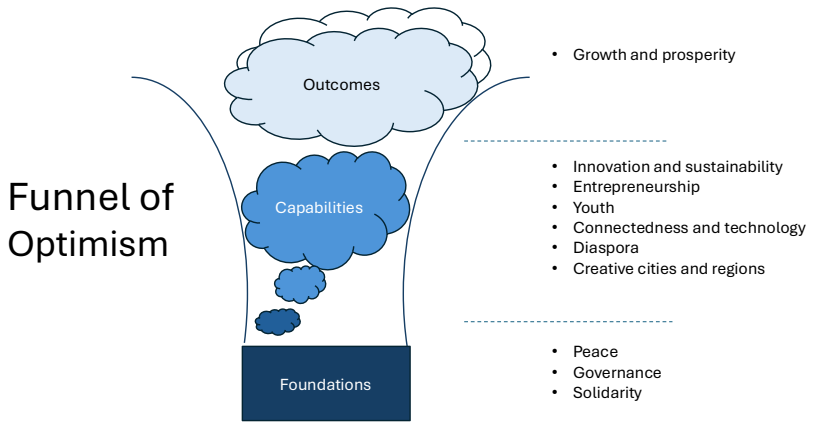
These foundations do not need to be perfect - ~~—~~but they must show credible progress. Across the continent, improvements in conflict resolution, democratic transitions, institutional strengthening, and regional integration form the bedrock upon which future gains can be built.

The second tier comprises Capabilities — the enduring assets, created and harnessed, that generate competitive advantage. Here, Africa's profile is distinctive: A young and rapidly urbanising population; a generation of entrepreneurs building in constrained environments; expanding digital connectivity; a globally influential diaspora; accelerating innovation in climate adaptation and sustainability; and emerging creative cities and cultural industries that are starting to shape global narratives. These capabilities are not abstract. They are productive forces that compound over time.

At the top of the funnel are Outcomes: higher growth rates, rising incomes, poverty reduction, improved life expectancy, expanding middle classes, and measurable social progress. Outcomes both validate and reinforce optimism. They signal that foundations and capabilities are translating into lived improvements in people's lives.

The logic of the funnel is cumulative. Foundations enable capabilities. Capabilities generate outcomes. Outcomes strengthen optimism, which in turn fuels further investment, reform, and innovation.

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General

~~This book does not argue for blind optimism~~The book ~~.~~ ~~It~~ argues for disciplined optimism — grounded in data, comparative analysis, and structural trends. It seeks to demonstrate that when assessed holistically, many African nations are not stories of stagnation, but of momentum. And momentum, when recognised and reinforced, becomes self-sustaining.

To read this book, then, is to reconsider the lens through which Africa is viewed — by investors, policymakers, citizens, and the diaspora. If optimism is indeed a powerful indicator of development potential, then measuring and understanding it is not optional. It is strategic.

The book contains much data for African and non- African countries. Brazil, India, China, France, United Kingdom (UK) and the United States (US) are used as benchmark countries. They represent developed nations as well as the rising giants of the Global South, offering a variety of benchmarks against which to compare the performance of African nations. They also provide broad geographical coverage across the globe.

Given the high number of African countries, the charts that follow capture top performers in the categories measured, rather than every single one. Commentary captures some of the best and worst performers and reasons for their rankings, while also noting that indices are regularly updated meaning some changes are inevitable over time.

The 11 chapters that follow unpack each layer of the Funnel of Optimism in depth — from peace, governance and solidarity to innovation and sustainability, entrepreneurship, youth, diaspora engagement and prosperity — building a structured case for why optimism in Africa today is not merely emotional. It is rational. And it matters.

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Chapter One: Peace

There Is More Peace Than You Think

Africa is far more peaceful than the headlines suggest. The dominant story is not unending conflict but steady, deliberate progress toward peace. Optimism about Africa rests not on denying conflict where it exists, but on recognising how many countries are already at peace and how much has been achieved to ensure and maintain peace as a driver of economic development and growth.

The data tells a consistent story: a large share of African countries are already peaceful by global standards, and the trend over the last decade has been one of deliberate improvement rather than perpetual crisis. According to the 2026 Global Peace Index (GPI), 21 African countries sit among the world's top 100 most peaceful, and 35 African countries score better than the United States. The top 25 African countries are presented here in Table 1 arranged according to 2025 data.

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Peace in much of Africa is not an aspiration; it must be understood as a reality that compares favourably with large, high-income democracies. Mauritius, for example, was 18th ~~th~~ globally in 2026, ahead of the UK (39th) and far ahead of the US (134th8). This is a helpful anchor for the reader.

When we say, "there is more peace than you think," we mean that on well-established comparative metrics, many African countries outperform global peers that rarely carry a "conflict-prone" label. But the question is whether anyone is listening. Has the negative narrative driven by coverage of the continent over many decades become so embedded that good news gets people looking for more dramatic news about Africa rather than focusing on positive trends?

The evidence: Peace by the numbers

The data reveals a continent that has, over 10 years, maintained and deepened a peaceful state of affairs in many of its regions. Countries such as Mauritius, Botswana, and Namibia have sustained decades of stability, while others such as The Gambia and, Rwanda, have demonstrated striking upward movement, not just by avoiding conflict, but by actively embedding peace into governance, reconciliation, and daily life. These gains show that Africa is not simply warding off instability; it is deliberately deepening a peaceful landscape that has become the backdrop for economic growth, social progress, and institution-building.

The picture is nuanced. Some states (not shown in the table) have slipped in their rankings such as Senegal and Malawi, reminding us that peace is a process requiring constant renewal. But across the continent, the balance tips toward improvement: more than 20 countries advanced in the past decade, and several did so by wide margins. Even where violence persists, as in South Sudan, Mali, or the eastern Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), there are visible strategies at work, from continental mediation to grassroots innovations, showing that peace is being pursued, practised and experienced daily.

Additionally, this decade of results disturbs the familiar headline of "conflict engulfing Africa". Instead, it reveals peace as the prevailing condition, a socio-political and economic indicator that has underpinned Africa's progress in health, education, investment, and governance as several chapters in this book show. The story of the last 10 years is, therefore, not one of survival

against the odds, but of societies intentionally shaping peace as a foundation for the future. With this in mind, an optimistic lens reflects the reality that Africa's peaceful landscape has been strengthening, even as it continues to evolve.

A continental mosaic: The geography of peace

The table below highlights the rankings and scores (out of five, where a lower number is better) on the Global Peace Index for 2026 and the year before. Included are the top 20 African countries and a range of benchmark countries from other regions. The results include the following observations:

- Mauritius is the best placed African country
- 12 African countries are in the top 50% of peaceful countries globally
- There is evidence of clustering, especially around rankings in the 70s and 80s
- Mauritius and Equatorial Guinea rank higher than all the benchmark (non-African) countries
- 21 African countries are ranked better than France, 28 better than China, 32 better than Brazil, 34 better than India, and 38 better than the US

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The index measures a wide range of factors including the following: perceptions of criminality, police rate (number of internal security officers and police per 100,000 people), homicide rate, incarceration rate; access to small arms; intensity of internal conflict; tendency for violent demonstrations and violent crime; political instability; weapons imports; military expenditure; UN peacekeeping funding; nuclear and heavy weapons; weapons exports; refugees and IDPs; and issues related to internal and external conflicts.

Many countries have improved their rankings, in addition to Mauritius. These include Equatorial Guinea +20, Senegal +12, Tunisia +19, Angola +11, Sierra Leone +9, Tunisia +19; Lesotho +27, Liberia +17, Zimbabwe +10, and Gabon +17. A number of these are overlooked in discussions about improvements in peace in Africa.

The biggest drop in rankings was for Tanzania, which went down 20 places as a result of ~~serious~~ election and post-election violence that took place in late 2025, and Malawi, down 18 places due to a rise in violent crime in the country.

Table 1: Global Peace Index – Comparison between 2025 and 2026 (Out of 163 countries, Scores out of 5)

Country	Rank 2026	Score 2026	Rank 2025	Score 2025	Change in rank
Mauritius	18	1.586	29	1.642	+11
Equatorial Guinea	38	1.729	58	1.834	+20
Botswana	50	1.823	46	1.778	-4
The Gambia	56	1.837	61	1.841	+5
Madagascar	59	1.849	63	1.848	+4
Namibia	63	1.872	62	1.843	-1
Morocco	65	1.887	68	1.888	+3
Sierra Leone	74	1.937	83	1.961	+9
Senegal	75	1.939	87	1.973	+12
Ghana	76	1.943	74	1.909	-2
Tunisia	77	1.947	96	2.049	+19

Country	Rank 2026	Score 2026	Rank 2025	Score 2025	Change in rank
Angola	78	1.955	89	1.98	+11
Zambia	82	1.992	80	1.953	-2
Malawi	83	1.994	65	1.866	-18
Guinea-Bissau	85	2.012	92	2.034	+7
Lesotho	86	2.016	113	2.142	+27
Liberia	87	2.024	104	2.083	+17
Zimbabwe	90	2.051	100	2.069	+10
Algeria	91	2.053	86	1.969	-5
Côte D'Ivoire	93	2.061	84	1.962	-9
Tanzania	98	2.08	78	1.938	-20
Gabon	100	2.086	117	2.218	+17
Eswatini	104	2.095	110	2.123	+6
Djibouti	105	2.098	111	2.132	+6
Mauritania	112	2.184	114	2.173	+2
UK	39	1.73	32	1.679	-7
France	99	2.083	102	2.073	+3
China	118	2.231	107	2.113	-11
Brazil	124	2.333	125	2.341	+1
India	127	2.409	124	2.34	-3
US	134	2.535	130	2.438	-4

Source: Institute for Peace

Seven African countries are ranked among the world's top 70, with Mauritius (18th), Botswana (50th), and Namibia (63rd) consistently demonstrating decades of stability. The Gambia (56th) and Sierra Leone (74th) — both countries with histories of intense conflict — now sit in the same tier as long-established democracies in other regions.

The statistics communicates a practical takeaway to the reader: if you are used to thinking of 'peaceful' as being synonymous with rich, non-African states, your bias is showing. The GPI scores from 2025 show that several African countries sit both in the same performance band and in some cases, in a stronger performance band, than some European and Asian economies.

The top 10 most peaceful countries in Africa identified in the chart above are highlighted in the map below.

Map 1: Top 10 Most Peaceful Countries in Africa 2026



Source: Peace Index 2026

What makes these numbers powerful is that they do not stand in isolation. They reflect deliberate improvements over time. Between 2015 and 2025, 22 African countries improved their peace rankings, led by Rwanda (+48), the Gambia (+44), and Egypt (+30). Guinea-Bissau (+19) and Libya (+18).

This decade of data tells a nuanced story: peace is not simply being preserved in already stable states but is being actively deepened in societies that once confronted phases of grave conflict, whilst in countries like Botswana, the decade of data shows that peace is embedded within the overall functioning of the society through strong governance and robust institutions including rule of law, transparency and accountability.

This combination of stability and improvement is the strongest evidence of a continent-wide condition of peace. Stability is reflected in countries like Mauritius, Botswana, and Namibia, which have maintained high rankings year after year. Improvement is reflected in countries like Rwanda and The Gambia, where peacebuilding policies and reconciliation efforts have reshaped their trajectories.

And resilience is reflected in countries like Liberia and Sierra Leone, which have sustained peace for nearly two decades after devastating civil wars.

Liberia is often regarded as one of Africa's notable post-conflict success stories. After enduring two devastating civil wars between 1989 and 2003 in which an estimated 250,000 people died and many more were displaced, the country has largely avoided a return to large-scale violence.

Its peace has not been perfect, but it has proven remarkably durable for a range of reasons, including a lengthy international peacekeeping presence and successful demobilisation efforts, as well as community-driven peace-making initiatives similar to those in Sierra Leone and

Rwanda. It has enjoyed political stability and three peaceful handovers of power since the early 2000s.

It may be surprising to see that East Africa is hardly reflected on the rankings, given the perception that it is mostly a peaceful region. This is not because the region lacks success stories or that countries in the region have not made significant progress in stability and development.

The GPI measures a combination of factors—including internal conflict, militarisation, political instability, terrorism, and relations with neighbouring states—and several countries in the region score poorly on one or more of these indicators.

The Horn of Africa, notably Somalia, Ethiopia, Sudan and South Sudan, affect the overall peace of this region although countries such as Kenya, Tanzania and Uganda remain attractive for investors and headquarters for international organisations and the UN, for example. The region is also a successful regional trade and investment bloc, with eight member states belonging to the East African Community. This lends stability as nations work together for their own and mutual economic benefit.

Peace is no accident

The results from Table 1 show that comparative anchors and decade-long shifts sit alongside a qualitative reality that helps to explain why progress has held in many places. Peace across the continent is not accidental. It has been built by intentional choices: strengthened democratic governance; grievance-handling in community courts and reconciliation forums; civic rituals and memorials that foster shared narratives; street-level arts initiatives that normalise cooperation; and school curricula that embed civic identity.

The data also matters because it demonstrates that peace in Africa is not only a political condition but also an institutional and policy choice.

Where peace has improved, it is because governments and communities made it a priority while at a continental level, the African Union has in place its flagship initiative, Silencing the Guns, which aims to end wars, and prevent or manage civil conflicts, violent extremism and political violence across Africa.

While media headlines reflect peace-making efforts at national and even regional levels, many of the anchors of peace lie in community-based efforts. And there are many examples of these. The best known is possibly the work done by Rwanda's *gacaca* courts, traditional village gatherings that met regularly across the country to address issues following the genocide in the country, which took place from April to July 1994. More than one million people were killed and tens of thousands more were implicated.

The courts operated mainly from 2001–2012, dealing at community level with genocide-related cases and allegations against alleged perpetrators of the killings. The courts did not erase the tragedy but drove it out into the open and forced victims, collaborators and others to face it, and process it, to allow the healing to begin. Respected community members drove the process, which, through tough engagements, accelerated closure and enabled peaceful co-existence to resume.

The Rwanda example was driven by the government, leveraging a strong community model that was already in place, to ensure the sustainability of peace efforts.

In the once war-torn West African nation of Sierra Leone, where many thousands of people were killed and millions were displaced in an 11-year civil war, the process was bottom up, driven by communities themselves. It focused on complementing national efforts to target and punish perpetrators of the violence by rebuilding trust and resolving tensions at a local level. Local peace committees made up of traditional chiefs, religious leaders and other stakeholders, rebuilt trust one conversation, one dispute and one relationship at a time.

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These quiet stories may not have had anything like the exposure in international media that the events that led to them did, but they highlight what it means to treat peace as a deliberate project rather than a patchwork response to violence. It also explains why improvements show up both in everyday safety and in cross-country indices. Institutions and communities have been investing in the routines that make stability stick.

Peace as a binary narrative

The GPI is useful in providing evidence that allows the reframing of how peace should be understood. Too often, the issue is treated as a binary — it is either present or absent. The GPI results add another dimension: not only is peace widespread, but in many cases, it is growing stronger and becoming m

ore embedded in the fabric of nations. Peace in Africa is therefore best understood as a condition that is broad, deliberate, and resilient.

Where challenges remain, they are being met with strategies to improve. And where stability has taken hold, it has created the conditions for sustained development. This reminds us that peacefulness in Africa is not a single story but a nuanced landscape.

It is marked both by countries that have recovered from conflict and steadily improved their peace rankings, and by those that have maintained long-lasting stability for decades. Together, these experiences show that peace in Africa is not fleeting; it has proved that it can be deepened, sustained, and deliberately maintained over time.

The ACLED lens

A second lens comes from the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED), which is a widely used source of real-time data on political violence, conflict, protests, riots, and security events. The US-based project was founded in 2005 and collects detailed information on where, when, and how conflict-related events occur around the world, with particularly strong coverage of Africa.

In its records for 2024, ACLED defines a "violent event" as a specific, verifiable incident of political violence or protest activity. This can range from armed clashes and explosions to targeted attacks, riots, or demonstrations. Each event is logged individually, so the data captures not vague perceptions of instability but actual, counted episodes of unrest.

The chart below captures the number of events from the end of June 2025 to the end of May 2026. Boxes in red refer to countries with less than 100 events, boxes in blue to countries between 100 to 1,000 events and purple boxes to countries with more than 1,000 events.

It shows that 41 countries had fewer than 1,000 events in the past year, while 20 had fewer than 100. Several countries, namely Botswana, Rwanda, The Gambia, Eritrea, Republic of Congo, Lesotho, São Tomé and Principe, Djibouti, Seychelles and Equatorial Guinea had fewer than 20 events.

All African countries had fewer violent events than the US, India and Brazil. All had fewer events than France, except Nigeria and Somalia

Just five countries — Nigeria, Somalia, Cameroon, DRC and Sudan — comprised about 53% of the continent's measured events. This highlights the fact that the notion that the whole of Africa is beset by conflict, turmoil and lack of peace is unfounded.

The localised nature of ACLED's data illustrates that violence affects a relatively few people. Nigeria, for example, only 7% of people were exposed to violent events, with these mostly localised in areas in the strongholds of Islamic insurgency group, Boko Haram in the northern states, banditry in the north-west and farmer-pastoralist clashes in the Middle Belt.

All other African states sit below 3%, demonstrating that even severe national crises often remain highly localised within specific areas rather than being spread across the entire country. This reinforces the reality that Africa is mostly peaceful.

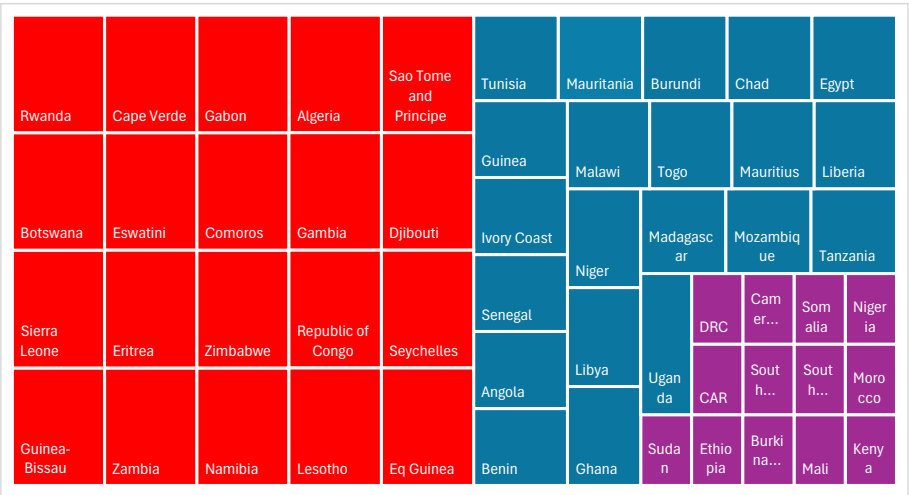
Similarly, just 11 countries out of 54 had more than 1,000 fatalities. These were Nigeria, Somalia, Cameroon, DRC, Sudan, Kenya, Ethiopia, Mali, South Sudan, Burkina Faso and Niger.

When translated into lived experience, these numbers reflect that most people are able to live normal lives, going to school during scheduled terms, experiencing reliable commutes, and shopping in functioning markets. They describe the everyday rhythms of societies that are broadly peaceful.

In the chart below, boxes in red refer to countries with less than 100 events, boxes in blue to countries between 100 and 1,000 and purple boxes to countries with more than 1,000 events.

Chart 1: ACLED Conflict Database - Events Between end-June 2025 and end-May 2026

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Source: ACLED

But the real signal is in the contrast. While a handful of hotspots generate high event counts, most African states consistently record very low levels of violence.

The fact that some of the high levels of violence are in a few of the biggest economies such as Nigeria means events in these countries are often headline news in Africa.

But seen together, these two facts do not contradict each other but are complementary — they explain why headlines so often focus on conflict and why those headlines miss the wider reality of peace.

This distribution strengthens the chapter's golden thread: peace in Africa is not the exception but the prevailing condition, with challenges concentrated in a few regions. The optimism lies in recognising that most African societies are not engulfed by violence, and that even in the hotspots, deliberate efforts brought peace back to formerly war-torn nations such as Sierra Leone.

So far, we have unsettled the assumption that Africa is defined by conflict. The evidence confirms it: peace in Africa is measurable, widespread, and strengthening.

Botswana's enduring peace architecture

"Peace is not just the absence of war — it's the presence of fairness. That's why our democracy works." Naledi P, a civil servant in Gaborone.

Since independence from Britain in 1966, Botswana has stood out as one of Africa's most politically stable and peaceful nations. In a region where many countries have faced coups, civil wars, or prolonged unrest, Botswana has avoided major internal conflict for nearly six decades. This record matters: it demonstrates that peace in Africa is not only possible in Africa but can also be a durable condition that underwrites prosperity across generations.

From the outset, Botswana's leaders prioritised inclusive governance, the rule of law, and prudent economic management as pillars of stability. When diamonds were discovered soon after independence, they resisted the "resource curse" that has fuelled conflict elsewhere. Instead, the government set up a unique 50–50 joint venture with South Africa's giant mining company De Beers, forming Debswana, which ensured that most diamond revenues went into national development rather than private pockets, giving citizens visible dividends from national resources.

The result has been political calm that has underpinned decades of sustained economic growth, allowing Botswana to transform from one of the world's poorest countries at independence in 1966, with a per capita GDP of about $80, to an upper middle-income economy today with a per capita GDP of over $7,000.

By pairing transparent resource management with democratic institutions and integrating traditional leadership into modern governance, Botswana has embedded peace in both politics

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and the economy. This has created an attractive environment for tourism and foreign investment, particularly in the wildlife and mining sectors.

This long arc of stability shows how peace, when sustained, becomes a generational asset, compounding gains in wealth, education, and governance. When citizens can see and feel the benefits of shared national wealth, peace becomes not just a political goal but a lived reality.

This chapter provides evidence that peace in Africa is a widespread and measurable reality. It appears both in countries that have sustained stability for decades, such as Botswana, and in those that have rebuilt it after conflict, like Rwanda and Sierra Leone. This demonstrates that peacefulness in Africa is a prevailing condition that has been strengthened and maintained by deliberate choices.

The question then becomes: how was this achieved? To answer that, we turn to the processes and institutions that have built and maintained this architecture of peace.

Peace as a deliberate project

It's important here to reflect on the processes that have made this widespread peace possible, how we got here, and what that means for understanding peace as a signal for optimism in Africa.

Earlier in this chapter, we revealed evidence from ACLED showing that in the last year, many countries had strikingly low numbers of violent events, while the Global Peace Index highlighted the fact that 22 countries improved their peace rankings over the past decade. These outcomes reflect an extensive architecture of peace built across the continent.

This section will discuss the whole-of-society architecture upon which the condition of peacefulness in Africa has been built.

At the continental level, African institutions have created frameworks to embed stability into political life. The African Union's Peace and Security Council, established in 2004, has become the central platform for conflict prevention, mediation, and democracy support. Its *Silencing the Guns* initiative, although ambitious, reflects a collective determination to end wars on African soil.

The initiative emerged from the AU's long-term development blueprint, Agenda 2063, which envisions a continent that is peaceful, secure, and free from armed conflict. Critics believe the organisation has not done enough to address conflicts that have arisen, but it has nevertheless kept peace and security high on the agenda in its organs and member states; strengthened conflict-monitoring mechanisms; and created a framework linking peace, governance and development.

The AU's Post-Conflict Reconstruction and Development (PCRD) framework goes further, tying peace to the delivery of healthcare, jobs, and education. When we see that countries such as Mauritius, Equatorial Guinea and Botswana consistently rank in the top 50 of the Global Peace Index, and that The Gambia has climbed 44 places in a decade, we can trace part of this success to the scaffolding created by continental institutions that normalise peace as an expectation rather than an exception.

Africa's regional blocs have peace and conflict prevention processes embedded in their structures. Some have the mandate to send troops into conflict zones.

In West Africa, the Economic Commission of West African States (ECOWAS) has invested in conflict prevention and electoral monitoring, containing crises before they destabilise entire regions.

ECOWAS has decisively tackled some of the most challenging conflicts, including the civil war in Liberia. There, it helped to contain the conflict and protect civilians, facilitated peace negotiations between warring factions, supported a series of peace agreements and laid the groundwork for later international efforts.

Another success for the regional bloc was in The Gambia after the 2016 election when President Yahya Jammeh refused to accept electoral defeat to Adama Barrow. ECOWAS applied intense diplomatic pressure, mobilising a regional military force to enforce the election result. Faced with regional pressure and the credible threat of intervention, Jammeh stepped down and went into exile. A potentially violent political crisis was resolved with minimal bloodshed.

In the ~~volatil~~e Horn of Africa in East Africa, peace efforts have been led by the Intergovernmental Authority on Development (IGAD), which has been instrumental in mediating long-standing conflicts, most notably in Sudan and South Sudan. It uses an elaborate Conflict Early Warning and Response Mechanism to prevent violence across its member states. IGAD relies on diplomatic mediation rather than military intervention.

A key success story was its mediation of the 2005 Comprehensive Peace Agreement, which ended Sudan's 22-year second civil war and paved the way for the independence of South Sudan in 2011, although both nations have since seen conflict resurface over the years.

The Southern African Development Community (SADC) has a dedicated organ on Politics, Defence, and Security Cooperation. It has led various mediation initiatives and deployed missions to stabilise countries in the region, including Lesotho, the DRC and Mozambique. One success was preventing a coup d'état in Lesotho by sending in regional troops to stabilise the situation. It also helped to combat a violent Islamist insurgency in Mozambique.

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These deliberate steps explain why more countries advanced than declined in the peace index between 2015 and 2025.

At the national level, governments have translated this continental agenda into domestic reforms. Rwanda, once at the bottom of the peace rankings, jumped nearly 50 places in 10 years through a combination of community led peace efforts, security reforms, and national reconciliation. Liberia embedded women's peace movements into post-war governance, helping secure stability after decades of violence.

At the community level, African societies have innovated by drawing on local traditions to reinforce peace from the ground up. As noted earlier in this chapter, Rwanda's *gacaca* courts processed millions of genocide-related cases, making justice both restorative and participatory. Sierra Leone's *Fambul Tok* brought neighbours together around bonfires to tell stories, confess, and forgive — stitching back trust at the community level. Ethiopia's *Gadaa* system has long organised political transitions and consensus-building, showing how institutionalised rotation of leadership can diffuse tensions before they escalate.

What unites these examples is that they link peace to social trust and belonging, ensuring that stability is not only recorded in statistics but experienced in the routines of daily life.

Altogether, these initiatives reveal an infrastructure of peace that reaches down from a continental level to communities. This architecture explains why Africa's peace index rankings are improving, why most countries record few violent incidents, and why optimism is not misplaced. It is a system that integrates institutions, policies, and traditions into a shared pursuit of stability — one that makes peace both durable and developmental.

Why it matters

Peace is not simply the absence of war. It is the enabling condition that allows societies to flourish, economies to expand, and citizens to trust in the future. In Africa, peace has become a powerful socio-economic indicator: it signals stability to investors, reduces the fiscal burden on governments, and gives families the confidence to plan for tomorrow.

Conflict, by contrast, is ruinously expensive. It destroys infrastructure, drains public funds into security spending, and frightens away domestic and foreign investment. In 2024, the global economic impact of violence was nearly $20 trillion — 11.6% of global GDP, according to the Institute of Economics and Peace.

Yet Sub-Saharan Africa, often miscast as being perpetually unstable, recorded the lowest regional economic cost of violence in the world. This statistic is not just counter intuitive; it is evidence that peace has taken root in many African societies and is already yielding dividends. These countries spend less on conflict and more on development priorities such as health, education, and infrastructure.

The benefits of peace are tangible. When Sierra Leone transitioned from civil war to peace, foreign investment returned and small-scale agriculture revived, restoring livelihoods. In Somalia's third largest city, Galkayo, market reconstruction and vocational training became both peacebuilding tools and engines of local commerce. Once divided by clan violence, the city has become a model of social cohesion and economic recovery, bolstered by infrastructure investment from the African Development Bank and others.

In Northern Kenya's Mandera and Marsabit counties, investments in livestock production and modern farming have reduced competition over scarce resources, directly addressing the causes of inter-communal clashes. These examples illustrate that peace and economic development reinforce each other: when stability increases, opportunities multiply, and when opportunities grow, incentives for peace deepen.

Policies matter too. Countries that deliberately embed peacebuilding into governance — through community dialogues, local justice mechanisms, and trauma recovery initiatives — experience stronger and more inclusive economic outcomes. Investors follow stability, and citizens invest in their futures when they feel safe. Governments that prioritise peace are not just keeping the guns quiet; they are unlocking the long-term growth that stability makes possible.

Nowhere is this more visible than Rwanda. Once globally defined by genocide, Rwanda has deliberately transformed reconciliation into an economic strategy. Tourism now contributes more than 10% of GDP, foreign investment has surged, and initiatives linked to reconciliation have helped to drive a 40% drop in extreme poverty in targeted communities.

Rwanda demonstrates the essence of this chapter's golden thread: optimism about Africa does not rest on the absence of violence alone, but on the reality that peace is being deepened into a sustainable condition that is unlocking growth and development. This is the economic imperative of peace, and it is what allows us to move from statistics to lived experience.

Rwanda – Giving peace a chance

"Peace begins when people see fairness in their daily lives. When the harvest is good, when children can walk to school, when the clinic has medicine — that is when trust grows again." Community leader in Butare Province, Rwanda. Field interview, 2024.

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In 1994, Rwanda emerged from one of the darkest episodes of violence in modern history. Nearly 800,000 people were killed in just 100 days, the economy collapsed, and the country's social fabric was shredded. Yet 30 years later, Rwanda is widely cited as being one of Africa's most stable and fastest-growing economies. This transformation matters because it demonstrates that peace is not only possible after extreme violence, but that it can be deliberately structured into the foundations of political and economic life.

Post-genocide Rwanda faced a triple crisis: rebuilding trust among traumatised communities, restoring basic governance, and creating economic opportunities to prevent a relapse into conflict. Land scarcity, ethnic division, and mass displacement compounded these challenges. The risk of renewed violence was real, with armed groups operating from neighbouring DRC well into the late 1990s.

The government, led by the Rwandan Patriotic Front, pursued a multi-pronged peace-building strategy. Culturally embedded transitional justice mechanisms such as the gacaca courts were revived to handle over a million genocide-related cases at the community level, linking justice to reconciliation. Security Sector Reform and Disarmament, Demobilisation, and Reintegration programmes dismantled militias and integrated ex-combatants, while decentralisation reforms gave citizens a greater role in local governance.

Rwanda also embedded peace into its economic planning. Vision 2020 (and later Vision 2050) aligned national development with peace goals: building inclusive growth, redistributing resources, and reducing structural inequalities, which had fuelled past violence. Investment in agriculture, irrigation, and terracing projects restored degraded land, while human capital programmes expanded education, health, and social protection.

Crucially, Rwanda leveraged external resources strategically, challenging the stereotype of post-conflict states as perpetual aid recipients. It has used aid to drive national transformation, demonstrating agency rather than dependency. World Bank financing and technical support were absorbed into nationally owned plans rather than donor-driven projects, ensuring coherence with domestic peace-building priorities.

A key insight from the Rwanda case is that when peace is deliberately woven into a coherent political, social, and economic strategy, it becomes self-reinforcing, transforming survival into prosperity and making stability the foundation for national ambition.

Peace as an operational asset

Africa's peace story is present, widespread, and deliberately sustained. It spans both endurance and renewal: some states have sustained stability across generations, while others have rebuilt it after conflict and are now reaping its dividends.

What matters most is that peace has become a condition Africans actively shape — through institutions, policies, and community innovations — rather than something fragile or accidental.

This shift has profound implications. It explains why economies have expanded, why education and health outcomes continue to improve, and why Africa's next generation has grounds for optimism about the future. Peace, in this sense, is not only an outcome but an enabler: it is the platform on which ambition, investment, and innovation rest.

The golden thread running throughout is clear: there is enough peace in Africa to be optimistic. More than that, peace is Africa's competitive advantage — a foundation already carrying the weight of transformation, and one that will shape the continent's trajectory for decades to come.

The media

The key, going forward, is to get the media to understand this process and to see peace as an enabler, a driver of optimism, and a bedrock for future peace and prosperity rather than focusing on conflict as a norm in Africa, unduly perpetuating negative stereotypes.

Changing the narrative requires active engagement with the traditional media, both in Africa and internationally where soundbites and easy stereotypes have long dominated coverage of news about the continent. These include famine, disease, poverty, corruption and war, or conflict.

This is understandably a response to audience demand and is particularly the case when audiences are unfamiliar with issues in Africa, and the geography of the continent. While it is important for the media to cover disasters and negative events, the issue is more about a lack of balance.

The reports that do make the media may be accurate, but the same media outlets often fail to report positive trends, or they focus minutely on isolated success stories rather than on new and growing trends that reflect modernisation and development.

International media tend to be present during a crisis and leave once it has passed, do not stay around to see how countries rebuild afterwards. For example, many people know about the civil wars in Liberia and Sierra Leone, but far fewer know about their subsequent democratic transitions and peacebuilding achievements.

Relatively little is reported about the significant strides many countries are making in finding ways to be economically self sufficient and build economic and trade agency in an increasingly fragmented world with international aid in retreat. This leaves the narrative of poverty, disease and informal economies as Africa's main condition unchecked.

This is not unique to Africa, but because Africa receives less overall coverage than many other regions, negative stories can disproportionately shape perceptions.

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The rising dominance of social media has several dimensions. The platforms enable Africans to assert their agency and profile developments in their countries that are often ignored by traditional media.

Africans are able to flag successful local entrepreneurs and cultural colour from their everyday lives. Many longstanding challenges and the search for solutions are being discussed in real time on social media platforms. These mediums enable Africans themselves to challenge negative stereotypes as they emerge and highlight the realities of a modernising continent without turning to sensationalist headlines and outdated narratives to do so.

Commented [MM15]: Seems patronising and unrelated to peace…?

For much of the post-Cold War period, international discussion about Africa was dominated by development, humanitarian assistance and conflict. Today, investors are increasingly discussing Africa in terms of investment and economic opportunity as non-traditional investors are challenged by their counterparts from China, the Middle East and other regions. Rather than aid and poverty, discussions are now more focused on technology, trade, energy and consumer markets and logistics corridors than aid, disaster and poverty.

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And it is glib to assume it is just international media outlets that have conformed to the stereotypes in covering Africa; continental and national media have had a similar response, also informed by the same need to attract audiences.

But there is evidence that narrative is slowly starting to shift, especially as pan-African efforts to build prosperity gain traction, through the efforts of some governments but also of respected institutions such as the African Development Bank and African Continental Free Trade Area Secretariat.

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Chapter Two: Governance

Defining Governance — and Recognising It

Governance in Africa is stronger than many assume. The record of the last decade shows steady gains in a meaningful number of countries: institutions have been refined, oversight has improved, and public services are more reliably delivered. This does not paper over conflict, corruption, or democratic reversals. It does, however, correct a common misreading.

Commented [MM18]: Can we define what we mean by governance somewhere upfront

Across the continent, governance is being reformed, defended, and improved by citizens, civil servants, courts, and reforming leaders. The following chapter sets out what governance means in this context, why it matters, what the data shows from 2015–2025, how progress has been achieved, and how it looks in practice and ending with practical reasons for optimism.

We adopt a citizen-centred understanding of governance: the capacity and duty of the state to provide political, social, economic, and environmental goods that people have a right to expect. In operational terms, this spans four pillars often tracked together: rule of law and security; participation, rights, and inclusion; foundations for economic opportunity; and human development.

Commented [MM19]: think we need to broaden the introduction to governance. Most readers, particularly in the Africa context, will instinctively think of governance as transparency, accountability and corruption. That's too narrow for the way we're using it in this book. We mean governance in its broader sense: how well a country is governed and whether it creates the conditions for people and businesses to thrive. This includes effective institutions, the rule of law, security, public services, economic management, participation and accountability. It would be helpful to define this upfront so readers understand why governance sits at the foundation of the Funnel of Optimism.

Treating governance in this way keeps the focus on lived outcomes rather than labels. It also brings Africa's story into clearer view: not a single trajectory narrative, but a wide lens showing clusters of improvement that can be explained and learned from.

Why it matters

Governance is not symbolic. Where rules are predictable and agencies are competent, investment rises, services reach more people, and growth is less fragile. The recent empirical record in Africa confirms this link. Studies using continent-wide panels find that improvements in governance are associated with higher and more durable growth.

The mechanisms are familiar, and visible on the ground: credible budgets and procurement reduce waste; anti-corruption enforcement redirects resources to priority sectors; fair courts and independent regulators anchor confidence for firms and households alike. In short, governance converts political will into everyday results.

A large body of research links governance to growth and welfare. Cross-country results show, for example, that a 1% improvement in governance raises economic growth by 1%.[3] Recent World Bank and IMF studies on Sub-Saharan Africa strengthen the inference: improvements in political stability, rule of law, and accountability are associated with faster growth and better social outcomes. In practical terms, credible budgets, cleaner procurement and enforceable contracts reduce uncertainty, lift investment, and help public spending reach citizens.

The Mo Ibrahim Index has been one of the longest-standing indicators of governance in Africa. It was established in 2007 by the Mo Ibrahim Foundation, founded by Sudanese-born entrepreneur and philanthropist Mo Ibrahim. The index has been published continuously since then as a tool to measure governance performance across African countries.

It comprises an overall index, and sub-indices of Security and Rule of Law, Participation Rights and Inclusion, as well as Foundations for Economic Opportunity. All 54 African countries are included.

The heat map classifies countries according to their position in the rankings. Green refers to countries ranked between one and 20 — the leading economies in the region. Countries in yellow are ranked between 21 and 30. The countries in both green and yellow, the leading nations on the rankings, demonstrate that there is considerable cause for optimism on the continent.

As can be seen on the map below, the top 20 countries are reasonably scattered across the continent, apart from Central Africa, meaning that strong governance is not concentrated in specific regions. To the extent that there is any clustering, the southern and eastern regions predominate.

The top 20 countries are also found across various types of geography, population and economic size. Strong performance in terms of governance is not the preserve of larger economies, for example.

In order, Seychelles, Mauritius, Cabo Verde, South Africa and Botswana are the top five nations in Africa by rank. Each of these countries has an overall score of more than 65 out of 100 with Seychelles as high as 75.3. All the top 20 countries have scores of more than 50.

Importantly, has been a change in scores over the last decade. This reflects the dynamism of these nations in relation to governance. Of the top 20 nations, 14 countries improved their

[3] Mahran H. The impact of governance on economic growth: A spatial econometric approach. Review of Economics and Political Science 2023 8(1), pp 37-53.

scores between 2014 and 2023. For most of the countries, therefore, there has been continuous improvement in terms of governance.

The 14 countries out of the top 20 that have improved their scores are diverse geographically. They are Seychelles, Cabo Verde, Ghana, Morocco, Kenya, Sâo Tomé and Principe, Benin, Rwanda, Tanzania, Cote D'Ivoire, Zambia, Algeria, Malawi and The Gambia.

The largest gains have been in the Seychelles, Morocco, Benin, The Gambia, Côte D'Ivoire, and Zambia.

In terms of the shifts in rankings, The Gambia has improved by the most over the decade by about eight places.

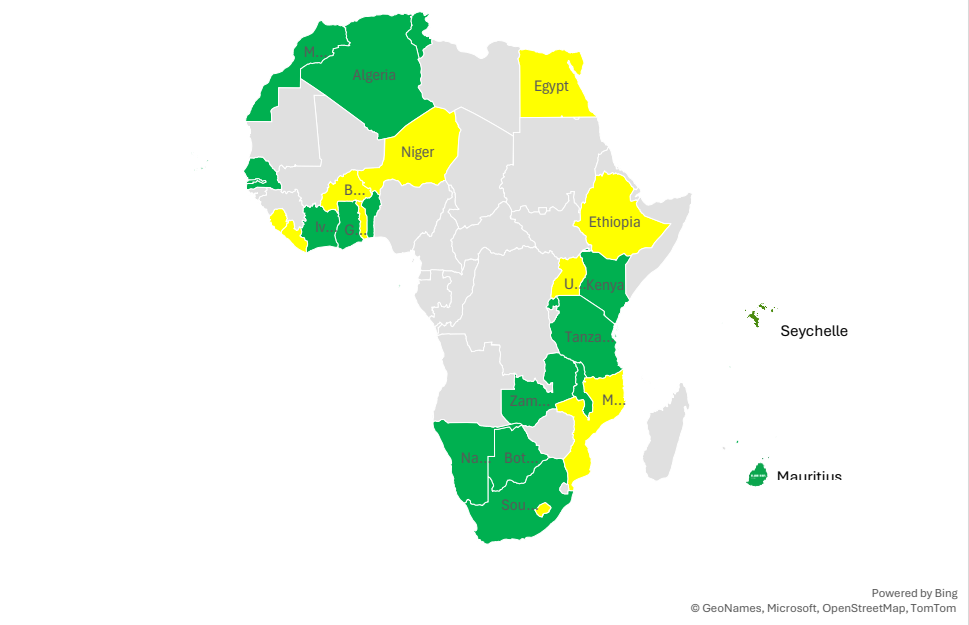
The successful democratic transition from the 22-year authoritarian regime of Yahya Jammeh to the presidency of his elected successor, Adam Barrow, has driven the dramatic improvements in peace and governance, highlighting the impact poor leadership can have on a country's fortunes in countries where institutions and accountability are weak. The change paved the way for sweeping media reforms, restored civil liberties, and institutional overhauls.

Morocco is also a high scorer. Constitutional changes implemented from 2011 by King Mohammed VI after the Arab Spring uprising decentralised power, reinforced judicial independence, and created frameworks for participative democracy and open government. This was backed by private sector reforms that have made Morocco the leading industrial country in Africa.

Côte D'Ivoire was also highly placed and of the countries in yellow, placed between 21 and 30, Liberia and Sierra Leone have improved the most.

Map 1: Governance in Africa - Strong Performers 2023

(Green shows countries ranked between 1-20; yellow between 21 and 30)



Source: Ibrahim Index of African Governance, with author adaptations

The evidence

The World Governance Indicators (WGI) produced by the World Bank is a comprehensive set of data, which scores all countries out of 100 on the criteria of Voice and Accountability, Political Stability, Government Effectiveness, Regulatory Quality, Rule of Law and Control of Corruption. Together these indicators measure the main determinants and drivers of governance.

The chart below describes a star-based approach. Countries that have scores of more than 50 out of 100 on all the six criteria are described as six-star economies, those with scores of more than 50 on five criteria as five-star economies and so on.

As can be seen in the chart, Botswana, Cabo Verde, Mauritius, Namibia and Senegal lead the field with six stars, putting them on a par with the US, UK and France. The next group comprises the five-star countries — Ghana, Rwanda and India. Four-star nations are Morocco, São Tomé and Principe and South Africa, while three-star nations are Benin, The Gambia, Malawi and the benchmark nations of Brazil and China.

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The full table of all African countries is available as Appendix Two at the end of the book.

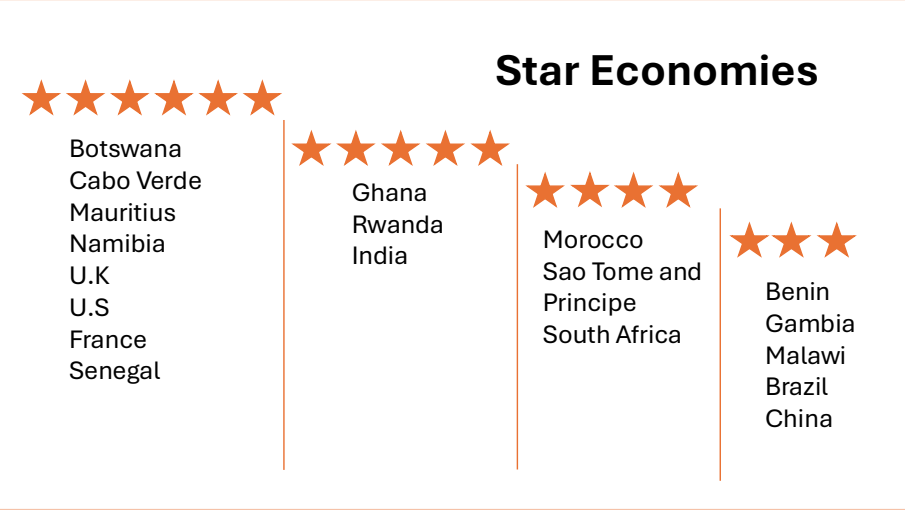
What the data demonstrates is that good governance is not the exclusive domain of advanced Western economies. While they are six-star rated, it is also the case that African nations rightfully belong in this group even though there is significant variation in actual scores.

Five-star economies are on a par with India. It is instructive to note that most of the African countries that are part of the star-rating schema are better placed than China and Brazil.

Botswana, Cabo Verde and Morocco are the best placed of the African countries in actual score terms. Botswana has a high score of 83 in the political stability category. Cabo Verde scores more than 70 in the voice and accountability as well as the political stability pillars, while the political stability score for Mauritius is nudging 80.

The strong data for political stability also underscores that peace is part and parcel of the African reality as we saw in the Peace Chapter. Senegal and Namibia are also highly placed.

The data from the table in the Appendix does point to "pockets of excellence" among countries that are not star rated. Comoros, Congo, Equatorial Guinea, Gabon, Guinea Bissau, Madagascar, Malawi, Sierra Leone, Tanzania, Togo, Tunisia and Zambia all score more than 50 on political stability.



One of the clearest drivers of good governance is the absence or reduction of graft. Corruption is corrosive in terms of distorting resource allocation in an economy, exacerbating inequality, weakening public morale, and contributing to investor uncertainty, among other things. It has also long been pervasive in Africa across both large and small economies, but many nations are tackling it, recognizing that development is impossible without efforts being made to eradicate it.

Drawing on data from the Corruptions Perception Index, below, on the horizontal axis is the corruption index rank for 2025, with a lower number being better. On the vertical axis is the change in score between 2015 and 2025.

The data shows that there are four leading economies: Seychelles; Cabo Verde; Botswana and Rwanda which are ranked inside the top 50 countries in the world out of 182 measured, and exhibiting significant improvements in scores between 2015-2025.

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These are countries that are both doing well and improving due to strong anti-corruption policies and reforms. These include strengthening institutions, prosecuting corruption and digitalising services. This is important for attracting investment and economic activity, providing demonstration effects for other countries through peer mechanisms, and anchoring regional governance norms.

The second group of countries is clustered in the top right-hand corner of the chart. They are ranked lower than those above but have improved their scores over time. These include Côte D'Ivoire, Benin and Tanzania.

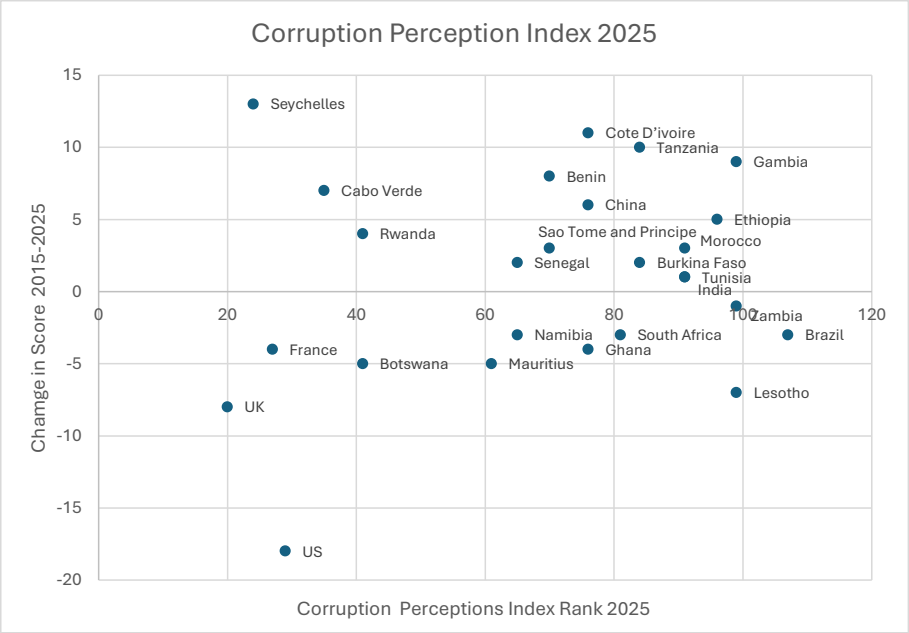
A third group of countries — Namibia, South Africa and Ghana — are inside the top 50% of ranked countries, but their scores have declined over the past 10 years. These countries are still well placed but require ongoing attention.

In South Africa's case, the hollowing out of its commercial capital, Johannesburg, by corruption is one factor in its declining score. The huge city, which accounts for 16% of the country's GDP, was heading for bankruptcy in 2026, a situation fuelled by lack of investment in infrastructure and services, but also by pervasive and unchecked corruption and financial mismanagement, an example of how destructive graft can be.

At least 42 countries have anti-corruption agencies. Although their effectiveness varies enormously depending on political independence, prosecutorial powers, funding and the willingness of governments to allow politically sensitive prosecutions, their existence is nevertheless testament to the commitment to reform among African nations.

Looking at the data in a global context shows that the governance story is not one of catching up to the West. Several more advanced economies such as the US, UK and France have all exhibited declining scores over the past 10 years. In particular, the US score has shrunk by 18 points in 10 years.

The narrative is an optimistic one, overall, for Africa despite the fact that progress has been slow in many cases and success has been relatively patchy.



Source: Transparency International Corruption Perceptions Index and author adaptations. The lower the score, the better.

Press freedom

Press freedom is a key element of strong governance. It helps to drive openness, transparency and accountability for those in power. It reflects the ability of a society to question authority, bring abuses of power to light and to conduct a civil discourse in the public interest. It is a critical connector between governments and the people.

The Press Freedom Index undertaken annually by the agency Reporters Without Borders comprises five distinct categories of indicators: political, legal framework, economic context, sociocultural context, and safety. Africa fares quite well on the index, which is a reason to be optimistic about the positive trajectory of African governance.

While recognising that progress is patchy and uneven, and that most governments could do better given the scale of their challenges, there are some very important bright spots, which are hardly acknowledged, a fact that feeds the broader negative narratives about Africa.

As shown in the table below, in 2025 11 African countries were in the top third of the rankings out of 180 countries worldwide. These were South Africa, Namibia, Seychelles, Ghana and Cabo Verde.

Twelve countries fared better than the US on the index, a country perceived to be the gold standard in terms of press freedom, with 11 performing better than Brazil.

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It is also instructive to note that South Africa and Namibia are ranked in the 20s along with the UK (18th) and France (25th). All the top 20 African countries are significantly stronger than India and China, which lag near the bottom of the rankings.

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A number of countries, notably Mauritania, Liberia, Sierra Leone, The Gambia, and Côte D'Ivoire, perform solidly with scores in the 60s.

The table below shows the changes in press freedom rankings by Reporters Without Borders between 2025 and 2026. It highlights significant improvement in rankings over the period for countries such as Seychelles, Ghana, The Gambia, Lesotho and Botswana.

It has listed countries at the lower reaches of the rankings (not shown in the table) that have demonstrated significant gains since 2025. These include Togo +24, Uganda +12, Kenya +11 and Equatorial Guinea +24.

However, this is a case where such indices use metrics that do not always indicate the reality on the ground.

While countries under military rule such as Niger in West Africa, and unstable governments such as that in Central African Republic, appear at the high end of the rankings, so do countries long regarded as being politically stable democracies such as Botswana, Senegal and Malawi.

Botswana's press freedom ranking has declined due to state-sponsored media control, in part through a pullback of state advertising revenues for cash-strapped independent outlets, and aggressive state surveillance and harassment, which have fostered widespread self-censorship among journalists, according to Afrobarometer.

The country fell from 40th out of 180 countries in 2013 to 81 in 2025 and 63 in 2026, as indicated in the chart below.

Uganda, which improved its rankings considerable between 2025 and 2026, has seen a dramatic reversal. The country is nominally democratic although the president, Yoweri Museveni, has been in power for more than 40 years and was voted in for a seventh term in 2026.

In June 2026, his son, who is the Chief of the Defence Force, ordered the country's largest independent media company, the Nation Media Group, to be shut down overnight, saying he does not believe in a free press.

Equatorial Guinea is another country that does hold elections, but democracy remains elusive, with the current president, Teodoro Obiang Nguema Mbasogo, in power for nearly 47 years. Despite the rankings produced by Reporters Without Borders showing an improvement of 24 places over the period captured below, both political opposition and the media are heavily restricted.

The state, as in many neo-authoritarian countries, including Zimbabwe, dominates television and radio stations, allowing them almost unchallenged reach into rural areas where a large part of the electorate lives.

But overall, the future of democracies is in a sound position, driven by countries in Africa of different sizes and locations, which enjoy considerable press freedom and freedom of expression. This highlights the fact that press freedom is not a bastion of Western democracies.

The data also points to hubs of press freedom in West Africa and South Africa as well as Island States. This may assist in helping journalists to collaborate regionally and undertake important cross-border journalistic investigations.

Table 1: Press Freedom Index 2026 – African Countries (out of 180 globally)

Country	Rank 2026	Score 2026	Rank 2025	Score 2025	Change
South Africa	21	77.95	27	75.71	+6
Namibia	23	76.97	28	75.35	+5
Seychelles	35	73.04	45	68.56	+10
Ghana	39	72.20	52	67.13	+13
Cabo Verde	40	71.98	30	74.98	-10
Mauritius	42	70.92	51	67.31	+9
Gabon	43	70.57	41	70.65	-2
Gambia	46	69.42	58	65.486	+12
Côte d'Ivoire	54	66.27	64	63.69	+10
Liberia	58	64.54	54	66.61	-4
Mauritania	61	63.36	50	67.52	-11
Botswana	63	62.89	81	57.64	+18
Rep of Congo	68	61.21	71	60.58	+3
Malawi	69	60.96	76	59.20	+7
Comoros	72	60.23	75	59.27	+3
Zambia	77	58.58	82	57.33	+5
Senegal	78	58.11	74	59.43	-4
Sierra Leone	79	57.06	56	66.36	-23
CAR	81	56.73	72	60.15	-9
Lesotho	89	54.37	107	52.07	+18
Eswatini	101	51.94	98	52.86	-3
Benin	113	47.39	92	54.60	-21
Tanzania	117	46.22	95	53.68	-22
Niger	120	46.02	83	57.05	-37
UK	18	79.45	20	78.89	+2
France	25	76.68	25	76.62	0
Brazil	52	66.37	63	63.80	+11
U.S	64	62.61	57	65.487	-7
India	157	31.96	151	32.96	-6
China	178	13.85	178	14.80	0

Source: Reporters Without Borders, World Press Freedom Index 2026.

Progress in governance: How we got here

Progress in governance in many African countries has not been accidental. It is the product of deliberate choices, repeated in different settings and refined over time.

First came the institutional housekeeping. Ministries of finance tightened budgets so that plans matched cash, strengthened treasury operations, and followed audits with action. During COVID-19, for example, Botswana, Ghana, and Mauritius set up emergency funds within their budget-law frameworks and paired them with real-time compliance audits by their supreme

audit institutions — a practical combination that protected budget credibility while speeding up execution.

Sierra Leone's audit office used agile, 'real-time' audits to track Ebola virus infections and later COVID-19 spending, reducing leakages and forcing faster corrective action.

On the data side, many governments expanded digital delivery — business registrations, licensing, and civil services moved online — with evidence that e-government adoption improves integrity and spending effectiveness when sequenced well.

Rwanda stands out as a case where governance reforms supported stronger domestic revenue performance, illustrating how administrative upgrades can translate into macro results. These quiet upgrades shaved hours off routine interactions and lowered costs for citizens and firms alike.

Kenya is one example of digital improvements to economic efficiency. The government has digitised both national and municipal revenue collection. The Kenya Revenue Authority (KRA) uses an online tax system to centralise services and issue digital IDs for all citizens. Ghana has launched the Ghana.gov portal, a unified platform that processes all public service fees, taxes, and vendor payments.

South Africa's tax collection body, the South African Revenue Service (SARS), has an advanced digital revenue network that uses automated risk-profiling, AI, and e-filing systems to optimise domestic taxation.

The country is increasingly turning to digital immigration services to tackle inefficiency and corruption in its key Home Affairs ministry. Its partnership with the country's large private sector banking groups to allow bank branches to process passports and ID cards has been a big success story, cutting long queues and slow processing at government offices.

Integrity has been enforced. Anti-corruption agencies received clearer mandates and the authority to use them in many countries, and asset-declaration and procurement rules were tightened. Where oversight bodies and courts had the tools, early, visible cases reset expectations. The IMF highlights African examples (Botswana, Rwanda, Seychelles) where transparency of economic policy and criminalisation of corruption have become core pillars of reform, rather than slogans.

In parallel, governments that digitised revenue collection and published spending built practical checks on discretion, with cross-country evidence of a negative association between digital adoption and perceived corruption among tax officials. Early, well-publicised prosecutions and audit follow-up made it clear that impunity was no longer guaranteed.

The Open Budget Index identifies government budget transparency and is based on three parameters: public participation, which is the opportunity for the public to meaningfully engage with budgets throughout the process; budget oversight, which is the role and effectiveness of formal oversight institutions; and transparency, which is public access to budget information.

The Index is produced by the International Budget Partnership, a global civil society organization that advocates for open, inclusive, and accountable public budget systems.

An open budget process is a critical aspect of governance, which prevents executive over-reach and ensures that public and oversight institutions can see how money is raised and spent.

Higher levels of transparency are linked to better creditworthiness, reduced corruption and increased investment.

According to the base data, and the author's calculations, there are some strong performers in Africa. For example, out of 125 countries, Egypt is ranked at number eight on public participation in the budget, South Africa is 10th, Kenya and Benin in West Africa 15th.

In terms of budget oversight, Uganda is ranked 27th and South Africa 19th, while for transparency Benin is ranked 9th and South Africa a very impressive 4th in the world. These are all important signs of commitment to, and reform of, budget processes and accountability.

Courts have played their part. By asserting review powers in politically sensitive moments, judiciaries have raised the cost of shortcuts and affirmed a simple principle: the rules apply to everyone. The recent record includes Ghana and Kenya, where courts have stood against attempts to bend electoral rules, reinforcing democratic procedures under pressure. That stance has become a stabiliser when pressure mounts.

Multiparty politics has also played a role. In South Africa in 2025, political partners in the multiparty Government of National Unity (GNU) went to court to force the country's finance minister, a member of the ruling ANC, to withdraw his proposal to introduce a two percentage-point hike in value-added tax to raise revenues to fund the budget. The minister, faced with mounting legal and political challenges, backed down on the hike, leaving the standard VAT rate at 15%.

Peer pressure has also been a factor in ensuring fairness and transparency in budgetary processes. Continental and regional frameworks, including peer reviews, democracy charters, and election observation have encouraged convergence towards better practice and provided ready-made templates for reformers to adapt.

Senegal's steady gains in democratic accountability and public-goods delivery under reform programmes in the 2010s illustrate how regional democratic norms and domestic reform coalitions can reinforce each other over time.

Finally, macroeconomic prudence has anchored credibility. Regulators have aligned with international standards, and oversight of state-owned enterprises has improved. Kenya is a useful case in point. It registered one of the largest improvements in state capacity among its peers (a 15-point rise over 2000–2019 as measured by the Bertelsmann Transformation Index), even as the region wrestled with debt dynamics. It marked the strongest improvement in state administration and public service delivery in the Sub-Saharan region.

This is a reminder that strengthening fiscal institutions and transparency must go hand in hand with sustainable financing strategies. Where governance reforms bite — from procurement integrity to credible audits — countries reap measurable macro dividends; Rwanda is again a case in point for domestic revenue gains linked to governance upgrades.

Countries that have combined these strands tended to advance faster and more durably.

Continental initiatives reinforce national reform. The African Governance Architecture (AGA), established in 2010, provides an AU-level forum for coordination on democracy and governance. The African Peer Review Mechanism (APRM) creates a voluntary platform for mutual assessment, diffusion of good practice and joint problem-solving.

These provide an important framework for individual country initiatives. They also allow for benchmarking, competitive pressure to improve and collaboration opportunities for nations to jointly tackle issues.

Concrete country examples show how this translates into action:

- Rwanda's Irembo and Ghana's digital services and payments have modernised service delivery
- Côte d'Ivoire expanded performance audits to strengthen integrity
- Botswana's Pula Fund codifies prudent natural-resource governance
- Seychelles' Action Plan 2023–2025 advances a National Integrity Coalition that brings state and civil society together; and
- Ghana's 2016 constitutional reforms deepened separation of powers and devolved authority in health.

These choices—administrative, legal, and fiscal—are the practical engines of the gains described in the chapter.

The past decade presents a careful but encouraging conclusion. Governance in Africa is uneven, and at times fragile, yet the balance of evidence shows real improvements in a significant set of countries. These gains were not luck. They were made by courts that held their ground; by auditors and prosecutors who did their jobs; by finance ministries that tightened systems; by political parties that blocked ruling party excesses, and by citizens who demanded better.

Optimism, ~~then, is not naïve.~~. It is conditional and grounded. The next steps are clear: protect judicial independence; expand transparent budgeting and procurement; publish comprehensive information on state-owned enterprises; and keep building professional, merit-based administrations.

Where these steps are taken, the payoff is visible in higher investment, steadier growth, and services that reach more people. That is the meaning of governance in this book: ~~not an abstract score, but~~ a practical architecture that Africans are already building, one credible rule and one capable institution at a time.

Chapter Three: Solidarity

Africa's Helping Hands

Across countries in Africa, solidarity is both a principle and a practice. It is a living ethic that shapes how many Africans relate to one another, how communities organise themselves and how societies respond when people are in need.

Commented [MM21]: I wonder whether we should rename this chapter "African" Philanthropy and Solidarity. For many international readers, solidarity can feel like development jargon and very much associated with Africa already. Philanthropy is a more familiar entry point and not often associated with africa - so no one feels optimistic about it….. but I'd like us to define it in its broadest sense. It isnt only the formal charitable giving by wealthy individuals or foundations, but the wider African tradition of giving, mutual support, remittances, volunteering, community action and collective responsibility. In other words, philanthropy is the expression of Africa's culture of solidarity. I think this framing will be more accessible to readers while still capturing the broader concept we want to convey.

Solidarity is a major foundational element of optimism in Africa. This is because it is part and parcel of practical giving based on needs, of collective strength among communities, of community resilience and an ability to weather crises.

While it is often explained through Ubuntu, a philosophy rooted in the belief that a person's humanity is shaped through others, solidarity shows up in many forms in Africa's diverse linguistic and cultural landscape.

Commented [MM22]: We should also define solidarity as we use it often and never say what it actually means

It is found in the spirit of *harambee* in Kenya, the communal labour systems in Ethiopia, the *stokvels* of South Africa, and the rotating savings groups of West Africa.

Harambee is a deep Kenyan tradition, that essentially means putting the group ahead of the individual to help those in need. The word means "all pull together" in Kiswahili, the national language. It is the nation's official motto and even appears on the national coat of arms.

In South Africa, stokvels are a traditional form of saving for communities where members pool fixed amounts of money on a regular basis. Although stokvels are informal savings and investment pools, they represent a multimillion-dollar industry and benefit millions of people across South Africa. They started as burial societies and groups for basic savings but have expanded to include investment in homes and financial products.

The groups rely on mutual trust and financial discipline but also on the concept of Ubuntu. This is an old African philosophy rooted in Bantu languages that is broadly similar to harambee in Kenya. Roughly translated it means "I am because we are", embodying a belief that an individual's well being is intrinsically tied to the well being of a community.

In South Africa there is another informal support mechanism loosely known as the "black tax" — a responsibility felt by black professionals to support extended family members through paying school fees, rent or medical bills, and addressing historical economic exclusion. It is an expression of Ubuntu translated into solidarity, family duty and communal care.

Commented [MM23]: While South Africans have coined the phrase the practice is common across(many african countries. Relatives educating cousins and siblings.. Where often only one or two members of a family are deemed to be successful enough to take on financial responsibilities of the broader family,

Each tradition rests on collective responsibility and shared wellbeing.

This understanding of solidarity informs how generosity is practised. Africans express generosity in ways that resemble what the rest of the world calls philanthropy, although the pathways, scale and motivations often look different. In a global sense, philanthropy refers to the organised or intentional use of resources to improve social wellbeing. In many countries, it is associated with large foundations, high-net-worth donors and institutional grant making.

Commented [MM24]: This feels a little patronising, perhaps evidence shows that many africans…..

Generosity across the continent ~~African generosity~~ fits within this global definition, but it expands it in important ways. Firstly, philanthropy is not confined to formal institutions but is expressed through both structured initiatives and everyday systems of mutual support. These acts may be small in monetary terms, yet they are significant in impact.

A family contributes to a neighbour's medical costs; a group of women pool savings to help one another raise capital for small businesses; relatives abroad send remittances that cover a child's school fees or support household food security. These flows of generosity, thus, become embedded in the social fabric as regular, dependable practices that form part of Africa's social infrastructure.

Remittances from Africans living in other countries or regions have become a lifeline for African people and the economies in which recipients live. These inflows are significant, reaching $104

billion in 2024, according to the World Bank, and outpacing foreign investment and official development assistance.

The number is dependent on the fortunes and access of Africans seeking opportunities in other countries, but generally it has been growing rapidly over the years, particularly in intra-African remittances, dominated by South Africa. In Sub-Saharan Africa, the countries with the highest inflows include Nigeria, Ghana, Kenya and Senegal while North African nations are also major recipients.

Most of the funds sent in as remittances are used for essential consumer needs and bills, while quite often people use it to build houses and make small investments, signalling how these revenue streams boost poor households and stimulate broader economic activity.

Several African governments and continental institutions have established funds and financial vehicles to channel diaspora remittances into infrastructure and national development. Pan-African institution Afreximbank has, for example, set up a remittance-backed financing facility to mobilise diaspora remittances, allowing governments and central banks to use these inflows as collateral to raise foreign currency for large-scale infrastructure and trade-related products. This enables them to raise money without incurring high borrowing costs in the traditional Eurobond markets and offset foreign exchange pressures and budget constraints.

Commented [MM25]: Can we get some data from Africa Diaspora network - they are driving use of diaspora funds strategically to bolster the importance of this section and it would be good to have a visual graphic of remittance - there is quite a bit

A number of countries, such as Nigeria, Kenya and Ghana, have issued or announced Diaspora Bonds with a similar aim.

Solidarity is also visible in how communities build new economic and social arrangements that prioritise shared benefit. Social enterprises embed community uplift into their business models. Youth cooperatives create collective ventures so members can learn skills, share risks and earn incomes together. Ethical and equal trade initiatives channel profits back into local development.

In moments of difficulty, from health emergencies to floods or conflict, communities mobilise resources and networks long before formal institutions can respond.

Women sit at the heart of many of these systems. Their leadership in savings groups, rotating credit associations, care networks and community projects anchors the entire ecosystem of mutual support. These practices give life to the idea that solidarity is not a lofty concept. It is a set of habits and structures that keep households, villages and cities functioning, especially where formal services are overstretched.

Taken together, these expressions of generosity, philanthropy and women's leadership offer a picture of solidarity that is deeply rooted and constantly evolving. These are the stories missed by the media coverage of the continent, but which create a safe place for the majority of its citizens.

The purpose of this chapter is to look at what solidarity means, why it matters and how it has shaped Africa's social, political and economic systems. We examine data that measures generosity and giving, and we explore case studies that reveal how solidarity is built in practice across countries and communities.

Why solidarity matters

Commented [MM26]: Define or see my note above re renaming it… don't really like this word., then perhaps link it to solidarity...

In many African countries, solidarity fills gaps left by unequal markets, overstretched governments and fragile, or non-existent, safety nets. It is one of the continent's most powerful

engines of resilience. Families survive prolonged droughts, job losses and health crises because communities rally around them. Migrant workers keep entire households and even villages afloat through remittances.

Solidarity also builds trust. In societies with diverse ethnic, linguistic and religious groups, maintaining social cohesion is essential. Mutual aid traditions help to tie people together across social divides. When individuals believe others will stand with them, they are more willing to participate in civic life, invest in their communities and support one another through times of uncertainty.

Economically, solidarity lowers barriers for those excluded from formal finance. Savings groups, chamas and stokvels allow people without collateral to access credit.

Women, in particular, benefit. Many can start small farms, restaurants or shops because other women back them financially. These micro-enterprises may appear modest to those outside the system, yet they often create jobs and reduce poverty for entire families.

At the national level, solidarity influences public policy and philanthropy. African foundations, diaspora networks and women leaders channel resources into education, health and entrepreneurship programmes that governments cannot fund alone. When solidarity is strong, development becomes shared work rather than a task left to the state or to foreign donors.

Binding social and economic life

In our analysis of giving practices, community efforts to uplift and protect each other, we became aware of three things.

Firstly, solidarity is a concrete system of support that strengthens social cohesion, especially in moments when economic or political pressures threaten stability. Secondly, communities across the continent, and within the diaspora, consistently step in to protect one another from shocks that range from inflation to conflict to climate disasters.

Lastly, acts of support must be understood as proactive efforts to ensure that opportunity circulates and that the success of one person becomes a shared success for many. The story of remittances from the African diaspora is an example of this, with revenue streams running into billions of dollars per year, distributed across many countries, as earlier mentioned.

This shows the financial power of solidarity, which then translates into economic power for families, and boosts economies at the same time as the money trickles down into the system.

Zimbabwe is an example of an economy that has survived extreme hardship due to remittances. The South Africa-Zimbabwe remittance corridor is the busiest in Africa, but Zimbabweans also have extensive networks in the UK and other regions, which are lucrative sources of income back home.

Remittances from Zimbabweans living abroad rose about 14% year on year to reach $2.45 billion in 2025. Remittances now rank alongside exports and mining receipts as one of the country's most reliable sources of hard currency.

While this steady income stream remains significant for Zimbabweans themselves and the broader economy, it became a lifeline during the hyperinflation crisis that peaked in 2008 when local salaries and incomes in Zimbabwe dollars became worthless within hours of being paid,

and savings disappeared overnight. The inflows of stable hard currencies prevented not just a humanitarian crisis but staved off the total collapse of the economy at the time.

A big corporate success story that came from the economic and political turbulence of Zimbabwe is that of Econet Wireless Zimbabwe, which provided online payment options for Zimbabweans, including mobile wallets, to counter significant and ongoing cash shortages. It now dominates the space and is central to the remittances business as well. Outside Zimbabwe, it has become a major global corporation under various corporate brands.

Remittances also saved Somalia, providing a critical financial lifeline during decades of civil war and the collapse of the central government in the early 1990s. One outcome of the political turbulence was the lack of a functioning formal banking system. Traditional money transfer operators, known as *hawalas,* quickly spotted the opportunity and began moving money across borders into the country from many parts of the globe.

The system was the backbone of the growth of local mobile money providers, which stepped in to create apps and other products for this huge movement of money. The biggest of these is Hormuud Telecom, which dominates south and central Somalia, including the capital of Mogadishu. It received the first mobile money licence awarded by the country's central bank. Golis Telecom in the northern region of Puntland is another big company that emerged out of the dysfunction of formal financial systems.

An estimated $1.3 billion to $2 billion is sent home annually by Somalis abroad and these revenue streams can account for up to 30% of GDP.

The success of remittances in Africa has spawned many other large players, driving a significant fintech industry across the continent. While historically, most of them were foreign companies, increasingly African-owned fintechs are coming to the fore such as Makuru in Zimbabwe, Nala in East Africa, Flutterwave and Onafrique in West Africa, as well as Mama Money and telecoms giant MTN's MoMo.

When we study the evidence, we see a pattern that repeats itself in different countries and communities. Africans volunteer in large numbers, they donate frequently, they mobilise resources quickly and they build informal and formal institutions that prioritise collective wellbeing.

As noted above, diaspora networks sustain entire families and even towns and underpin the growth of African companies. Women's groups reinforce the social fabric through systems of shared savings, mutual assistance and local leadership. Philanthropy, whether through small community contributions or large-scale foundations, reflects a commitment to shared upliftment rather than individual gain.

A buffer in an unequal world

African countries are often navigating economic pressures that many wealthier regions do not experience. ~~Weak institutions~~, currency volatility, climate shocks, youth unemployment and unequal global trade systems all place a heavy strain on households and governments. Yet rather than eroding social cohesion, these pressures often strengthen the instinct to support one another.

Data from the Charities Aid Foundation (CAF), based in the UK, reinforces this story of collective wellbeing in action. It highlights the fact that Africa sits well above global averages on every major indicator of generosity.

The World Giving Report, done by CAF and the African Philanthropy Forum, uses insights from more than 60,000 people to explore giving across 105 countries.

The indicators used are: total donors as a percentage of population, which measures the spread of donor activity across society; total donations as a percentage of income which measures the monetary contribution of donors; volunteers as a percentage of the population, which measures the volume of people involved in volunteering activity; and average volunteer hours per person which reflects the amount of time spent volunteering.

The 10 most generous countries are in Africa and Asia.

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It found that people in Africa give an average of 1.6% of their income, compared to 0.6% in Europe.

Nigeria is the world's most generous country, where people give an average of 2.8% of their income to charities, churches or to people in need. Studies show that a high 89% of Nigerians donate money, and citizens give away an average of 2.83% of their personal income

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Africans score higher than all other regions on the total number of donors as a percentage of the population, total donations as a percentage of income, volunteers as a percentage of population and average volunteer hours per person. These are remarkable findings.

Even with some of the lowest average incomes globally, African countries donate more than twice as much of their income compared to Europe and are placed well ahead of regions with far greater wealth, including North America.

The data shows that Africans do not wait for prosperity before giving. Generosity is seen as a shared duty and part of what keeps communities stable when resources are stretched.

The depth of this ethic becomes clearer when we look more closely at the country-level comparisons. Table 1 in this chapter compares 23 African countries with selected nations across the world, and the results are striking. Sixteen African countries record donor participation above 70%. Ghana, Egypt and Malawi exceed 80%, while Nigeria sits on the edge of 90%.

Apart from Mozambique, every African country in the table outperforms France. Nineteen of the 23 countries surpass the US, while 11 outperform the United Kingdom. These patterns confirm that the instinct to support others is widespread, consistent and not confined to richer or more stable states.

In fact, the acts of generosity are probably more essential in poorer countries, despite the seeming contradiction that the incomes and livelihoods tend to be much lower than those in countries that have higher average living standards.

Table 1: World Giving Report 2024 (sorted by higher to lower according to total donors as a percentage of population)

Country	Total Donors % of population	Total Donations % income	Volunteers % pop	Average volunteer hours per person
Nigeria	89%	2.83%	35%	13.6
Kenya	86%	2.13%	48%	20.6
Egypt	83%	2.45%	31%	9.4
Malawi	83%	1.80%	44%	21.6
Ghana	82%	2.19%	34%	11.2
South Africa	79%	1.33%	36%	13.1
Uganda	79%	2.04%	44%	16.6
Tanzania	78%	1.69%	35%	14.4
Zambia	78%	1.62%	43%	18.1
Rwanda	75%	1.56%	43%	26.6
Botswana	74%	1.48%	35%	13.6
Morocco	72%	1.32%	37%	12.3
Sierra Leone	72%	1.67%	32%	10.9
Algeria	71%	1.43%	30%	6.8
Tunisia	71%	1.12%	37%	7.6
Namibia	70%	1.04%	43%	15.5
Côte D'Ivoire	68%	1.67%	41%	23.3
Ethiopia	67%	1.51%	29%	8.7
Senegal	62%	0.91%	34%	10.9
Cameroon	61%	1.37%	47%	18.4
Brazil	61%	0.93%	22%	8.0
China	76%	2.19%	36%	12.6
France	46%	0.45%	20%	8.2

Country	Total Donors % of population	Total Donations % income	Volunteers % pop	Average volunteer hours per person
India	84%	1.92%	24%	7.3
UK	73%	0.75%	18%	7.9
US	61%	0.97%	20%	7.6
Global Average	64%	1.04%	26%	8.9
Africa average	72%	1.54%	39%	14.6

Source: Charities Aid Foundation World Giving Report and Database.

The financial commitment is equally noteworthy. Many African nations donate at levels that exceed those of advanced economies by significant margins. As a proportion of income, 20 African countries give more than 1% of their earnings, while five countries - Egypt, Ghana, Kenya, Uganda and Nigeria - consistently give above 2%. Nigeria itself is close to 3%, as shown in Table 1. When placed alongside global benchmarks, these figures are extraordinary.

Countries donating above 2% outpace Japan by more than a factor of 10 (not shown in the table), and exceed the proportional giving of France, UK and the US.

Solidarity is expressed not only in money but in time and labour. Africans volunteer at some of the highest rates in the world. Almost all countries record volunteer participation above 30%, and Sudan stands out with a remarkable 57% of its population volunteering. This means more than half the country is actively involved in helping others.

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The intensity of that contribution is visible in the volunteer hours too. In 2024, people in Rwanda volunteered more than a full day per person on average with Côte d'Ivoire, Kenya and Malawi close behind. These hours represent real commitments to community health, education, safety and social support.

This is not luck or statistical anomaly. It reflects a deeply rooted ethic that sees the wellbeing of others as linked to one's own, as exemplified by some of the examples given earlier in this chapter.

The Giving Report captures this spirit well when it notes that Nigeria, despite having over 300 ethnic groups, consistently unites in moments of crisis because of a shared belief that prosperity cannot exist in isolation and that the wellbeing of individuals is inseparable from the wellbeing of the community.

It is worth noting that this trend may also be linked to poor service delivery and unstable governance or official neglect of citizens that prevails in many African nations, forcing citizens to both pay for government services and pay again for these to be delivered by private companies to supplement official service delivery dysfunction.

But overall, these patterns reveal something important. Solidarity in Africa does not emerge from abundance. It emerges from commitment. It is a deliberate choice to support one another in the face of structural difficulties, and it remains one of the continent's most reliable engines of resilience, stability and hope.

The many pathways of giving

Africa's generosity also manifests itself in structured forms that mirror global philanthropy, while remaining deeply rooted in community. Households give regularly to religious institutions, neighbourhood welfare groups, school development funds and local charities. Taken together, Africans contribute nearly $2 billion annually through formal charitable channels.

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What makes African philanthropy distinct is its blend of formal and informal systems. Wealthier families establish foundations; community-based organisations raise small but consistent contributions from neighbours; digital platforms enable online fundraisers for urgent needs; while social enterprises operate with business models tied to social impact. This ecosystem reflects a culture where giving is a shared duty, not an occasional act.

Women's empowerment as a key driver

Women's empowerment drives solidarity. When women gain access to credit, land, political voice and training opportunities, they bring entire communities with them. Their progress stabilises households, strengthens schools and expands opportunities for others. This is solidarity not only as a cultural value, but as a strategic force shaping Africa's long-term social and economic transformation.

Women embody and institutionalise the idea and ideal of co-operation that is essential for solidarity. Across the continent, they anchor many of the systems that translate solidarity into real social outcomes. Their leadership in mutual aid groups, rotating savings networks, market cooperatives and community organisations makes them central pillars of collective wellbeing.

They form businesses that link up across countries and borders, creating economic interdependence and they use their collective voice to bring about political reforms. Technologically savvy women also promote solidarity through ubiquitous technology usage and diffusion, connecting with other women and broader communities.

Evidence shows that solidarity grows stronger where women are empowered. The World Economic Forum's Gender Gap Index offers a clear window into this trend. The table below shows the rankings and scores for 2025, out of 148 countries globally, for the top 20 African nations and comparator countries.

The scoring is straightforward. A score of .811 for Namibia, for example, means that the country has closed 81.1% of the gap between men and women across the four pillars of the index. The higher the score, the less inequality between men and women, highlighting economic participation and opportunity, educational attainment, health and survival and political empowerment.

Table 2: Gender Gap 2025	**Out of 148 countries**	
	Rank 2025	**Score 2025**

UK	4	0.838
Namibia	8	0.811
Cabo Verde	30	0.769
South Africa	33	0.767
France	35	0.765
Rwanda	39	0.762
Liberia	40	0.76
US	42	0.756
Burundi	44	0.756
Eswatini	46	0.748
Zimbabwe	49	0.747
Mozambique	53	0.738
Tanzania	55	0.736
Madagascar	58	0.734
Botswana	60	0.731
Brazil	72	0.720
Ethiopia	75	0.71
Zambia	79	0.707
Uganda	80	0.707
Ghana	88	0.703
Gabon	91	0.699
Cameroon	93	0.697
Kenya	98	0.689
Lesotho	99	0.688
China	103	0.686
India	131	0.644

Source: World Economic Forum Gender Gap Report 2025.

A powerful picture emerges from an examination of Africa's performance. Namibia has closed 81.1% of its gender gap. Eighteen countries on the continent have closed more than 70% of their gaps, while every African country with available data has closed more than 50%.

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The numbers also show that Namibia, South Africa, Rwanda, Cabo Verde and Liberia all score higher than the US on the overall index, and Burundi sits on par in score terms. In total, 21 African nations outperform China and 34 (not shown) outperform India.

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These comparisons do not suggest that service quality or institutional capacity are identical across countries. Rather, they show how African governments have narrowed gender disparities at a faster pace than many larger economies, often with far fewer resources.

As the World Economic Forum notes in its 2025 Gender Gap Report, "While resources matter, it is not richer countries alone that can afford to invest in gender parity and economies can integrate parity into their growth strategies at all levels of development.

"Historically, those who have done well at developing and integrating their full human capital tend to have more sustainable and prosperous economies as a result. Leveraging the full base of talent and diverse ideas in an economy can unlock creativity and drive innovation, growth and productivity."

Namibia sits impressively at 8th in the world, well ahead of the next highest ranked country, Cabo Verde. Twelve African countries appear in the top half of the global rankings.

According to the Mastercard Foundation, Namibia achieved the fastest growth in young women's contribution to GDP between 2017 and 2022 (from 40% to 42%) by enacting laws on property rights, investing over 25% of the national budget in education and mandatory gender balance among teachers and decision makers to ensure diverse role models."[4]

There is also a notable gap between Namibia and the next highest performer, Cabo Verde, which stands at 30th.

The spread of empowerment rankings is wide, highlighting both the progress achieved and the work that remains. Cameroon, Kenya and Lesotho only feature low down in the rankings, at 93, 98 and 99 respectively.

While Lesotho achieves near gender parity in health and education, it has a major disparity in terms of leadership and incomes. According to the World Bank, women participation in the labour market has decreased since the 1990s. The country's labour-force participation rate is 48% among women and 67% among men, and just a quarter of parliamentarians are women.

Movement from 2024 to 2025 is also telling (not shown in the table). Various African countries improved their rankings over the past year. Rwanda, Sierra Leone, Burkina Faso and Morocco maintained their positions. Madagascar, Zambia and Benin recorded among the greatest gains, while some countries experienced reversals, reminding us that gender equality progress is rarely linear.

These shifts matter because stronger gender parity supports stronger social and economic cohesion. Rwanda illustrates this clearly. With more than 60% of parliamentary seats held by

[4] Mastercard Foundation, Youth Employment Outlook 2026.

women, and nearly half of cabinet positions filled by women leaders, the country has seen tangible improvements in public health, education and community service delivery. Greater representation has made maternal health, nutrition, early childhood development and community healthcare core national priorities.

Financial inclusion initiatives reflect a similar trend. The African Development Bank's Affirmative Finance Action for Women in Africa has mobilised more than $2 billion in loans for women-led enterprises across more than 40 countries. These investments do more than expand businesses. They enable women to employ neighbours, support extended families, pay school fees and buy agricultural inputs.

The impact of these interventions is communal rather than individual, strengthening local economies and deepening resilience.

How we got here: The roots and builders of African solidarity

Solidarity in Africa has survived because it is constantly renewed. It evolves while drawing on long-standing traditions. Several forces have shaped the modern landscape of solidarity.

Practices such as *harambee* in Kenya and *stokvels* in South Africa have existed for generations. Today they interact with digital tools. Mobile money platforms like M-Pesa, Airtel Money and Orange Money allow people to send contributions quickly. Crowdfunding platforms help communities respond rapidly to illnesses, funerals, or school fees. What was once organised through village meetings is now supplemented by WhatsApp groups and online appeals.

Kenya offers a vivid example. With between 300,000 and one million community investment and savings groups (*chamas*) operating nationwide, roughly 65% of Kenyans participate in at least three groups. These groups collectively manage assets worth more than $2 billion. They fund everything from business start-ups to school fees to community water projects. This is solidarity updated for the digital age.

The rise of African philanthropy

Commented [MM27]: This should be renamed the rise of US style philanthropy in Africa

The continent's philanthropic landscape has expanded significantly in recent years, with African billionaire entrepreneurs and industrialists stepping up to fund foundations that reach deep into areas such as health and nutrition, skills development, education, environmental issues and disaster relief across regions and countries. They include Aliko Dangote and Tony Elumelu from Nigeria, Strive Masiyiwa from Zimbabwe, Patrice Motsepe and Nicky Oppenheimer from South Africa and Mo Ibrahim, who hails from Sudan.

Dangote's foundation, in partnership with the Gates Foundation, helped Nigeria eradicate wild polio by improving immunisation systems and building health infrastructure. Elumelu's entrepreneurship programme has supported more than 18,000 businesses across Africa, providing training and seed capital. These efforts do more than create jobs. They signal a shift towards African-led solutions and local agency.

Recent research shows that more non-African philanthropic organisations are directing large grants to locally led African NGOs. The Mastercard Foundation and the Gates Foundation, for example, have changed their strategies to work more directly with African partners. In 2022 and 2023, more than half of large grants from these funders went to African organisations, reversing a decade-long trend of these revenues being routed through external intermediaries.

This shift increases trust, builds local capacity and keeps decision-making closer to communities. It also strengthens solidarity by ensuring that development is guided by those who understand local realities.

Women at the heart of solidarity

Throughout the continent, women's leadership in solidarity networks is reshaping development. Women's savings groups support widows, single mothers, and young entrepreneurs. Young women are at the forefront of digital crowdfunding for education and health. Organisations such as the African Women's Development Fund channel resources directly to women's rights groups, enabling them to run shelters, launch microfinance programmes and mentor youth.

Government policies are also playing a role. In Namibia, gender-responsive budgeting and targeted entrepreneurship programmes such as EntreprenHER have helped more than a thousand women grow their businesses. Rwanda's nationwide reforms have created a political environment in which women's voices shape national priorities.

These examples demonstrate how female empowerment and solidarity reinforce one another. When women rise, communities rise with them.

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The embedded role of religion

Africa is generally regarded as one of the most religious regions in the world, not just through the strong foundations of Christianity, Islam, and traditional African belief systems, but also many modern variants and charismatic movements.

Africa has some of the biggest churches in the world, many of them in Nigeria such as Winners Chapel, Deeper Christian Life Ministry and Redeemed Christian Church of God while South Africa is home to the giant Zion Christian Church. The shift to religion has been driven by rapid urbanisation, large youth populations, the franchise models of big churches which go across borders, and the newer charismatic style of worship that attracts mass participation.

All place a strong emphasis on helping others. Christians are encouraged to practice charity and stewardship, while Islam makes charitable giving a religious obligation through *zakat* and encourages voluntary giving through *sadaqah*. Many religious organisations operate schools, hospitals, clinics, orphanages, and development projects and donate in other ways.

~~Solidarity in Africa is a daily practice that moves through homes, villages, cities and institutions. It is expressed through community fundraising, remittances, philanthropy, social enterprises and national policies that protect and uplift women.~~

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The data confirms what many Africans have always known. The continent is one of the most generous regions in the world. People give even when they have little. They volunteer even when time is scarce. They stand with each other in hardship and in progress.

Women's empowerment and philanthropy is a key driver of this optimistic story. They show how solidarity can be organised, scaled and sustained. They demonstrate that when Africans invest in one another, the returns are felt across generations. Communities become stronger, institutions become more responsive and opportunities are more widely shared.

As Africa moves through a century defined by innovation, demographic change and shifting global dynamics, solidarity remains one of its most dependable strengths. It is a reminder that

the continent's future will not only be shaped by markets or governments, but also by the everyday decisions people make to care for one another.

Chapter Four: Innovation

The Technology Revolution

Walk through the varied and colourful landscapes in African countries, be it a market in Lagos, a village in Rwanda, or a tech hub in Nairobi, and you will see it. Innovation is everywhere in Africa, often in places where the rest of the world is not looking.

Far from being a continent defined only by raw material extraction for advanced economies, African nations are home to startling and original innovations that are reshaping daily life and long-term development.

These innovations span many sectors, technologies and applications. Farmers are using precision agriculture tools and mobile apps to access real-time information about weather, prices, and equipment. Health workers are tracking medicine inventories through blockchain to match supply and demand more accurately, while drones deliver essential medical supplies to remote communities.

New education products, services and delivery channels are emerging through edtech. Researchers are building capabilities in the space sector. Artists, designers and storytellers are experimenting with multimedia, cultural, and creative innovations. Entrepreneurs are testing renewable and distributed energy solutions, and fintech is giving rise to new and improved financial products and services, including micro insurance. These are only a few examples among many.

The spread of and appetite for innovation in Africa gives great room for optimism. For example, there are more than 700 technology and innovation hubs on the continent now compared to fewer than 20 just 15 years ago. There are now multiple unicorns in Africa — privately held startup companies that are worth more than $1 billion.

Flutterwave, started in Nigeria, is one of them. It has become a household name in Africa. By 2026, it operated in more than 35 African countries and supported international payment corridors connecting to North America and Europe. The company serves over 900,000 businesses globally and supports over 150 currencies.

Venture capital has risen tenfold in five years as new ideas, products, process and services come to market.

Yet the innovation story on the continent is multifaceted, nuanced and overlapping. This demonstrates the dynamism, diversity and optimism of innovation in Africa. There is no one type of innovator.

Some are frugal or improvising entrepreneurs who solve practical, real-world problems and challenges at the grass roots level in a low cost, functional manner and innovate to address challenges related to sectors such as energy, infrastructure or resources. Many fill gaps left by the state or formal markets, tapping into local knowledge and social networks.

One example is innovation in the sanitation sector, often in informal areas in cities but also in rural areas, providing eco-toilets that do not require sewer systems, community managed water systems and micro hygiene solutions. Waste collection and disposal in areas where municipalities do not reach is another.

In farming areas, people have created local systems to store post-harvest crops, transport syndicates to enable affordable transport to market, building apps to provide climate services to farmers and building digital hubs for rural education.

There are social innovators who target broader solutions in health, education, energy or gender equality, often found in the not-for-profit sector. Some of these are linked to the above.

There are corporate innovators, including early-stage technology firms, who deploy new and improved technology to develop, build and expand markets for goods and services; and those who undertake complex, large-scale formal research and development work in fields such as biotechnology, nanotechnology, space exploration, climate science, and artificial intelligence, addressing long-term issues confronting humankind.

Increasingly, large companies are turning to entrepreneurs and vibrant start ups to bring innovation to their traditional models, sometimes acquiring these smaller companies and often insourcing them.

Technology innovations are being rolled out across sectors, with fintech in the lead. As noted earlier, some of Africa's fastest-growing companies started from scratch. Nigeria has a number of startups that have become global companies.

In addition to Flutterwave, mentioned above, valued at more than $3 billion; Interswitch, a $1 billion payment switching and processing company that powers Nigeria's digital banking rails; Moniepoint, a $1 billion company that provides payment processing and business banking; and Paystack, which was given a hefty boost from startup status by a $200m acquisition by global payments company Stripe in 2020.

South Africa also has many success stories, such as Tyme Bank, a hybrid digital bank valued at $1.5bn, and Yoco, a company focused on SME payment processing, that has become a household name, spawning digital processing machines and systems across the country.

Innovation and sustainability

The link between innovation and sustainability is especially important in the African context. Innovative practices, technologies and capabilities are vital to manage the environment, support new forms of energy and respond to climate change. African nations are not large greenhouse gas emitters by world standards, yet they bear a significant share of the impact of climate change driven largely by more advanced economies.

At the same time, constraints on resources and the need to manage them sustainably create strong incentives to innovate. This is at the heart of frugal innovation, where people find ways to make progress with limited resources and design solutions around real constraints. Innovation and sustainability are thus deeply intertwined.

This relationship can be seen in data that shows a positive correlation between innovation, as measured by the Global Innovation Index (GII), and sustainability, as measured by the Environmental Performance Index (EPI). In simple terms, countries that invest in innovation capabilities are often better placed to protect their environment and manage long-term

ecological risks (see graphic below). Later sections of this chapter return to that link in more detail.

Figure 1: Relationship between innovation and environmental performance



Source: Author adaptation from World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO) Global Innovation Index 2025 (GII) and Yale Center for Law Environmental Performance Index (EPI) 2024.

What innovation means in Africa

To understand what is happening across the continent, it is useful to start with a broad definition of innovation. The Oslo Manual describes it as follows: "Innovation is a new or improved product or process (or combination of the two) that differs significantly from the unit's previous product or process and that has been made available to potential users (product) or brought into use by the unit (process).

Commented [MM30]: We should define innovation upfront

This definition captures the dynamic and multifaceted nature of innovation. It includes technical activities such as research and development, and non-technical changes such as new business models, ways of organising work or engaging customers.

For Africa, it is important to extend this idea and explicitly include innovation that provides solutions to complex economic, social, and environmental challenges. Many of the most meaningful innovations on the continent are not only about new technology. They are about finding better ways to feed families, clean up cities, create jobs, protect ecosystems and navigate climate shocks.

Innovation in many African countries is therefore nuanced. The usual global metrics such as patents, research and development expenditure, and scientific publications are useful, but they do not fully capture the extent of innovation taking place.

As a recent article in academic website *The Conversation* notes[5], African economies are dominated by informal firms, grassroots inventiveness and frugal solutions that often arise out of necessity. Many of the most effective innovations happen "under the radar" in farms, markets, workshops and neighbourhoods. These activities are not easily measured by traditional indicators, yet they change how people live and work.

These under the radar innovations are often localised, small scale and highly cost effective. They are specific to a need or social challenge, immediately practical, and they draw on local capabilities and, in many cases, traditional knowledge.

Consider a few examples.

In Nigeria, Wecyclers runs bicycle powered waste collection services that help low-income households exchange recyclable waste for rewards, reducing urban waste, creating jobs and changing behaviour.

- In Kenya, EcoPost transforms plastic waste into durable fencing posts, replacing timber and reducing pressure on forests while cleaning up plastic pollution.
- In Rwanda, EarthEnable uses local clay to create earthen floors that replace more expensive cement floors, improving health outcomes in homes that would otherwise have dusty or unsanitary surfaces.
- In Mozambique, *Fabrica de Herois* uses waste metals and wood to produce low-cost tools and machinery, turning discarded materials into productive assets.
- In Uganda, students have developed solar tents, which fold into backpacks, as portable housing to offer safe shelter for those without stable housing.
- South African Bohlale Mphhahele, an 18-year-old, invented the Alerting Earpiece - earrings that can record attackers and alerts police immediately by capturing photo and video evidence using a micro camera and GPS tracker.

These stories — and there are many more of them — demonstrate the unique ways that innovation manifests itself in Africa, drawing on local knowledge, supplies and ideas to address longstanding deficits in peoples' daily lives. In short, innovation is as much about reimagining how existing resources can be used as it is about embracing new technologies.

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Despite their local roots, most are replicable across borders, given similar challenges that exist across most African countries.

Why innovation matters

Innovation matters because it is a fundamental underpinning of an optimistic economy and society.

It is one of the main ways that countries raise productivity, create new industries, build wealth and improve living standards. A wide body of research has documented the strong relationship between innovation, growth, productivity, and long-term economic prosperity. It also expands

[5] Egbetokun A, Adeye D, Kruss G, Petersen LH & Sanni M, Africa's innovations are overlooked because global measures don't fit: What needs to change, The Conversation, 30 July, 2025.

the capacity of societies to solve complex challenges, from food security and health to climate resilience and social protection.

In the African context, innovation is not an abstract concept. It reflects the beating heart of optimism. When individuals, communities, companies and governments innovate, they are expressing a belief that the future can be better than the present.

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They visualise and act on better futures, take calculated risks and seize opportunities, even in difficult environments. This mindset is crucial for a continent that is young, rapidly urbanising, and navigating profound shifts in technology, trade, and geopolitics.

Innovation is also central to ~~Africa's~~ the continent's ability to turn its structural characteristics into advantages. A large youth population, rapid digital adoption, abundant renewable energy potential and rich biodiversity can all become powerful assets if they are matched with innovative policies, business models and technologies. Without innovation, these same characteristics risk becoming sources of instability. With innovation, they can be turned into engines of growth and resilience.

Evidence and trends in African innovation

Although much innovation in Africa sits outside conventional measures, it is still important to look at standard indicators for tracking progress and making comparisons. The Global Innovation Index (GII), put together by the World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO), is particularly useful because it brings together both input measures, such as education and infrastructure, and output measures, such as patents, creative exports and knowledge-intensive activities.

It measures innovation performance across about 140 economies and unveils the world's top 100 innovation clusters.

Recent GII data reveals three clear innovation stars in Africa (Figure 2 below). Mauritius, Morocco and South Africa sit in the top half of innovators worldwide and have improved their rankings significantly over the last six years. Mauritius is a striking case. It has climbed by 29 places since 2019 to reach 53rd position in the world out of 139 countries, comparable with several other emerging economies. Seychelles is also ranked 75th, although data for 2019 is not available.

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Figure 2: Innovation Performance



Source: World Intellectual Property Organisation (WIPO) Global Innovation Index 2025 and 2019 - author adaptations.

just outside the global top half sits a group of solid innovators that have also improved over the last six years. These include Egypt, Botswana, Senegal and Namibia. They may not yet be among the leading global innovation economies, but their steady progress suggests a strengthening ecosystem.

Another set of countries lies outside the top 100 yet has still moved up the rankings. Ghana, Nigeria, Zambia and Togo fall into this group. Tunisia is just outside the top 50%, although its ranking has declined over the same period.

At the lower end of the rankings are countries whose rankings have declined, including Kenya, Rwanda, Côte d'Ivoire, Zimbabwe, Tanzania, Uganda, Guinea and Malawi. This does not mean that there is no innovation in these countries. Rather, it highlights that their broader innovation systems are under pressure or that other countries are moving ahead more quickly.

The GII also identifies the top 100 innovation clusters in the world. A cluster is defined by the interplay of three factors: venture capital, patent filings and number of scientific publications. These clusters capture the relationship between innovation and entrepreneurial activity. In Africa, Cairo in Egypt appears as a top 100 cluster globally, underscoring the city's vibrant innovation scene.

For example, Cairo's cluster comprises, among other things, Si-Ware Systems and Cairo University, both drivers of the country's deep-tech sector.

Previous analysis by the GII covering the top 50 African clusters found that Egypt, with 11 clusters, South Africa with eight, and Morocco with five, lead the field. This points to pockets of concentrated innovation capacity that can anchor broader national and regional ecosystems.

When we compare innovation performance in 2025 compared to 2024, the picture remains dynamic. Mauritius, Morocco, South Africa, Tunisia, Senegal, Namibia, Côte d'Ivoire, Nigeria, Zambia, Benin, Cameroon and Burkina Faso all improved their positions. This suggests that even where countries face deep challenges, many are still managing to strengthen aspects of their innovation systems year by year.

Funding of innovation takes many forms. This includes venture capital and private equity, much of which has been going into fintech and related models, impact investing by companies and foundations, government grants and catalytic funds by specialised sector agencies, local risk capital and aid is still playing a role in this regard, despite the gradual withdrawal of aid money from Africa.

Strong performers and hidden strengths

Looking at innovation relative to GDP per capita provides another useful lens. The GII shows how countries perform compared to what might be expected given their overall level of economic development.

In 2025, Sub-Saharan Africa accounted for the largest number of over performers of any region in the world. Morocco, South Africa, Senegal, Tunisia, Malawi, and Rwanda all performed above expectations based on their income levels. Rwanda, in particular, has been a continuous over performer for the past 12 years, with its innovation performance exceeding that which might be expected given its income levels and levels of economic development.

The World Economic Forum says Rwanda's remarkable success in innovation is primarily driven by strong, top-down government commitment, deliberate regulatory agility, and massive investments in digital infrastructure.

By aggressively positioning itself as a "proof-of-concept" hub for emerging technologies, the country has bypassed traditional developmental hurdles to become a leading tech ecosystem in Africa.

Beneath the aggregate scores, broad trends show that African countries display specific areas of strength that highlight the richness of the innovation landscape. Some have national policies and programmes for innovation, with dedicated spending commitments by government. These strengths cover education, energy, entrepreneurship, creative industries, digital trade and finance.

Did you know?

As noted earlier, most of the positive stories about Africa rarely make it into the media, let alone the headlines. Yet a wealth of achievements is captured in global rankings and research reports that track progress across a wide range of indicators.

A closer look at these sources reveals a continent of far more progress and innovation than is commonly reported. The selection below highlights a cross-section of these gains across different sectors and regions.

- Namibia ranks first globally for public expenditure on education as a percentage of GPD, and Botswana is ranked third.
- Ethiopia ranks fifth globally for labour productivity growth, based on its investment in large-scale industrial parks and transformation of agriculture, with Burkina Faso 12th.
- Ghana ranks ninth for cultural and creative services exports and 16th for unicorn valuations, showing the scale and value of its creative and digital firms.
- Kenya is 35th for intellectual property receipts and 19th for ICT services exports, underscoring its role as a digital services hub.
- Lesotho ranks third for government funding per secondary school pupil as a share of GDP per capita and 10th overall for education expenditure as a share of GDP.
- Malawi ranks 17th on ICT services exports, 37th on scientific and technical articles and 15th for low carbon energy use.
- Mauritania is ninth in the world for net FDI inflows, and Mozambique ranks first for FDI net inflows as a share of GDP.
- Mauritius is eighth for operational stability for business, fifth for venture capital deal count and first for national feature films.
- Morocco ranks 12th for high-tech manufacturing, 24th for trademarks and sixth for industrial designs.
- Nigeria ranks first for unicorn valuations.
- Rwanda ranks 5th for policy stability for doing business.
- Senegal ranks first on gross capital formation and 10th on unicorn valuation.
- Seychelles ranks first for venture capital deals and investors and second for mobile app creation.
- South Africa ranks 18th on logistics performance, fourth for market capitalisation, and 23rd for global brand value.

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- Tunisia ranks first for government funding of secondary education, second for the number of graduates in science and engineering, 17th for scientific and technical articles, and 15th for industrial designs.
- Zambia ranks 8th for low carbon energy use.
- Zimbabwe ranks 21st for the number of graduates in science and engineering.

Most African countries perform strongly on the youth demographic dividend indicator, which measures the share of the population aged zero to 24 as a percentage of the total population. This reveals a potential source of long-term advantage but only if investment in education, skills and opportunities align with this youthful population.

Without such investment, this large and rapidly growing youth cohort could also become a disruptive factor in Africa's future.

The new frontier: Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence (AI) is one of the key technologies of the Fourth Industrial Revolution, alongside blockchain, the Internet of Things, gene editing and nanotechnology. AI has wide and pervasive applications across sectors, business models and workforces.

Several estimates from the likes of PwC, the African Development Bank and McKinsey & Company point to its potential impact on Africa. AI could boost the continent's GDP by up to 4.9% by 2035 and generate between $61 and $103 billion a year in additional economic value, says one estimate.

If Africa was to capture 10% of the global AI market, the economic uplift by 2030 could be between $1.5 and $2.9 trillion. Yet another estimate suggests that Africa could add 230 million new digital jobs to the continent's economy by 2030.

At the same time, it is clear that the impact of AI will be uneven across sectors and countries, and there are real risks in areas such as job displacement, inequality, privacy and security.

AI in Africa also provides important benefits for governance, helping to drive greater transparency and addressing corruption.

Critically, it enables vast new opportunities for firm creation, and industry development, reform of services and new business models. Yet the risks and constraints should not be glossed over. Investment in AI could come at the expense of jobs and job creation as well as economic and social dislocation.

One of the key risks is in industry-driven job creation as companies begin to automate functions.

An example is South Africa's automotive sector, which contributes significantly to GDP and employment. AI and robotics are quickly replacing manual assembly and other functions, including testing, maintenance and quality control. Manufacturers see major benefits in terms of safety, features, cost containment, efficiency, quality control and speed to market.

This has introduced a structural shift in employment from low-skilled line workers to higher-skilled personnel, and in the process, led to job losses. This can be addressed by upskilling workers and the creation of new tech jobs, although it is not a complete solution to a growing problem.

Governments are starting to put in place policies that protect consumers, privacy, jobs and other issues while the African Union is playing a role in AI uptake and development across the continent through its Continental AI Strategy. This is a framework to facilitate action by states on responsible, ethical and transparent AI use.

Two indices help to assess how African countries are positioned for AI: the IMF's AI Preparedness Index and the Oxford University Government AI Readiness Index.

The AI Preparedness Index combines four pillars: digital infrastructure, innovation and economic integration, human capital and labour market policies, and regulation and ethics. Scores range from zero to one, where higher scores indicate better preparedness.

Three standout African countries, Mauritius, Seychelles and South Africa, with scores of 0.5, are in the top half of the global distribution. A group of followers scoring 0.4 or more comprises Tunisia, Kenya, Rwanda, Cabo Verde, Ghana, Morocco, Namibia, Botswana, and Senegal.

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Mauritius, Seychelles, South Africa, and Tunisia all exceed the average for Emerging Market Economies (not shown).

In total, 30 African nations exceed the average for all low-income countries around the world. At the individual country level, Mauritius, Seychelles, and South Africa perform better than India, and Mauritius and Seychelles perform better than the average for the Asia Pacific region. The full table of scores shows the breadth of this performance.

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While this is reason for optimism, it is worth noting that there are many structural challenges that constrain the growth of AI solutions in Africa, key among them being affordability.

Mobile data costs an average 3.9% of income, the highest rate globally according to the International Telecommunications Union[6]. According to Brookings in 2023 only 37% of the African population used the internet with key challenges of affordability, lack of digital skills, language barriers and limited locally relevant content.[7]

Human capital is another constraint while research and development spending is well below the 2% to 3% of GDP common in advanced economies.

This does not mean there is not a large appetite for and interest in AI. A number of countries have large tech hubs and universities producing relevant talent with local developers building AI tools. The shift towards AI and the need to address the gaps in supporting infrastructure is attracting significant investment into Africa for data centres, with particular interest in South Africa and Nigeria.

More than 250 are already operational with more in the pipeline, with South Africa leading the continent's market share.

AI will help to address longstanding challenges in many sectors, including critical collection of reliable data, boosting Africa's linguistic diversity, accelerating development and improving government efficiency and transparency. The jury is still out on how this will play out in terms of jobs, as it is in other parts of the world, and regulation is still a work in progress as some of the scores below indicate.

[6] International Telecommunications Union, State of Digital Development and Trends in the African Region: Challenges and Opportunities, 2024.
[7] Munyati C, Accelerating digital inclusion in Africa, Brookings, 5 May 2025.

The African Union has an emerging continental approach to AI, but it is still in its early stages.

Table 1: AI Preparedness Index - Scores out of 1 (higher scores are better)

	AI Preparedness Index	Digital Infrastructure	Innovation and Economic Integration	Human Capital and Labour market policies	Regulation and ethics
Mauritius	.53	.12	.13	.13	.14
Seychelles	.53	.11	.14	.13	.14
South Africa	.5	.12	.11	.12	.14
Tunisia	.47	.11	.1	.13	.12
Kenya	.45	.1	.11	.11	.13
Rwanda	.44	.08	.11	.1	.14
Cabo Verde	.43	.08	.11	.12	.12
Ghana	.43	.09	.09	.11	.13
Morocco	.43	.1	.11	.12	.1
Namibia	.42	.08	.1	.12	.12
Botswana	.41	.08	.11	.11	.11
Senegal	.4	.08	.09	.1	.12
Egypt	.39	.09	.1	.12	.08
Algeria	.37	.08	.07	.14	.07
Côte D'Ivoire	.37	.08	.08	.1	.1
Liberia	.37	.04	.15	.1	.08
Zambia	.37	.07	.1	.11	.09
Benin	.36	.07	.1	.1	.1
Lesotho	.36	.07	.08	.1	.1
The Gambia	.36	.05	.1	.12	.09

	AI Preparedness Index	Digital Infrastructure	Innovation and Economic Integration	Human Capital and Labour market policies	Regulation and ethics
US	.77	.18	.16	.17	.21
UK	.73	.18	.16	.17	.21
France	.70	.18	.17	.16	.18
China	.64	.19	.15	.15	.15
Brazil	.5	.14	.11	.12	.14
India	.49	.11	.11	.12	.15

Source: IMF AI Preparedness Index 2024.

The Government AI Readiness Index measures the capacity of governments to shape and adopt AI. Out of 190 countries worldwide, 11 African nations are in the top 100: Egypt (65), Mauritius (69), South Africa (72), Rwanda (78), Seychelles (87), Tunisia (92), Kenya (93), Nigeria (94), Ghana (95), Benin (96), and Zambia (100). Morocco is just outside the top 100 in 101st place.

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Egypt performs relatively well because it has made deliberate, state-backed investments in digital infrastructure, talent development, and AI strategy, especially in recent years. It has been systematic and policy driven in building AI foundations and was one of the first countries to launch a National AI Strategy (2021-2027).

The government has rapidly introduced e-governance and digital public services, including automation in tax and customs services, and it has invested heavily in fibre broadband expansion, data centre growth and submarine cable landing hubs, which connect Africa, Asia and Europe. AI has been prioritised as an economic driver, rather than treated as a sectoral issue.

South Africa is another leader in AI, mostly driven by the private sector rather than the government, particularly the financial services sector. It is home to active AI startups and expertise and has advanced data infrastructure relative to most African countries.

Looking at the components of this index offers further insight. Eight African countries score 100, the maximum possible, for having an AI vision at national level. Egypt, South Africa, Rwanda, and Kenya all score more than 70 for governance and ethics, and each of them scores higher than China on this dimension. Tunisia is the best placed African country in terms of data availability and has scores higher than both India and China.

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In addition, 21 African nations score more than 70 for data representativeness, which measures how well available data reflects the population and circumstances of a country. These results

suggest that many African states are not only adopting AI but are also thinking seriously about how to govern it.

This is a cause for optimism as this is a transformative technology of the future, a “game changer” with multiple applications across many fields.

The topic of digital economy and AI is increasingly a feature of pan-African events held under the banner of the African Development Bank and UN Economic Commission for Africa, which has allowed policy makers across the continent to connect and discuss ideas and plans for this new future.

Innovation and sustainability

Innovation and sustainability, as noted earlier, are closely intertwined. Innovation drives sustainable products, services, processes and practices while sustainable principles and practices shape the nature and type of innovation.

There are several dimensions to the link between innovation and sustainability in the context of African nations, which are cause for optimism. Resource constraints, such as energy, water and infrastructure, have been significant drivers of sustainable innovation that can be delivered affordably and in an energy efficient manner. The circular economy is also growing, although this is based more on age old habits of recycling and reusing existing resources rather than to follow the corporate sustainability trend.

In cities such as Johannesburg, Nairobi and Lagos, waste pickers collect recyclable materials, such as boxes, bottles and plastic, and these are sold into recycling supply chains and returned to the market as new products. E-waste disposal is still limited, but growing, while plastic packaging is increasingly being charged for or banned altogether.

Plastics bans of varying intensity are in place across most of East Africa, and other restrictive measures are in place elsewhere, more to address the significant problems of littering, flooding and drainage problems in African towns and cities and general pollution rather than recycling.

Renewable energy is expanding rapidly, with innovations also moving at pace in this sector. These include solar mini grids for rural communities, pay-as-you-go solar energy systems and solar-powered irrigation, which support climate-smart agriculture.

The Environmental Performance Index (EPI) provides a useful way to see how African countries are performing with regard to environmental outcomes. The EPI combines three components: ecosystem vitality, environmental health and climate change mitigation.

Nine African countries are within the top 100 out of 180 nations on the overall EPI, which is shown in the table below. Gabon (44), Zimbabwe (53) Botswana (66), Seychelles (71), Mauritius (77), Zambia (83) Tunisia (91), Namibia (99), and Senegal (100) all fall into this group.

These countries perform better China and India, while Gabon, the best placed of African nations, performs better than Brazil. Over a 10-year period, 33 African countries (not all shown) have improved their EPI scores, which indicates gradual but meaningful progress.

Looking at the components of the EPI reveals a more detailed picture. For ecosystem vitality, which captures the health and resilience of natural systems, a number of African countries are in the top third globally, Botswana (8), Zambia (24), Zimbabwe (29), Gabon (31), Republic of Congo (32), Namibia (37), Tanzania (44), Niger (50), and Burkina Faso (52) stand out.

Botswana once again excels, sitting at 8th place in the world. The score reflects factors such as its large areas of intact ecosystems, lower historical industrialisation and the introduction of successful conservation models such as community wildlife management and dedicating large tracts of land to national parks and reserves. It also benefits from being home to the vast ecosystem of the Okavango Delta, which is also one of Africa's top tourism hotspots.

In the environmental health component, there are fewer African countries at the top, but the island states of Seychelles (21) and Mauritius (24) are ranked in the top third globally. This reflects challenges in terms of household air pollution through biomass cooking for example, urban waste treatments, industrial emissions in some cities and limited wastewater treatment.

In the climate change component, six African countries stand out: Zimbabwe (28), Gabon (32), Angola (44), South Africa (52), Djibouti (53), Sierra Leone (59), and Mauritius (68), demonstrating sustained commitment to climate change mitigation measures. For example, Gabon benefits from large-scale forest carbon sinks.

Eswatini's ranking of 31 (not shown) is driven by its low historical per-capita emissions, significant reliance on biomass and renewable energy, and extensive carbon sequestration from its natural resources and timber plantations.

Table 2: Environmental Protection Index - rank and scores in brackets (out of 180 countries)

	Environmental Protection Index (EPI)	**Ecosystem Vitality**	**Environmental Health**	**Climate Change**	**10-year movement in score for EPI**
Gabon	44 (53.3)	31 (65.4)	130 (32.3)	32 (52.8)	5.5
Zimbabwe	53 (51.6)	29 (66.3)	156 (23)	28 (53.5)	7.7
Botswana	66 (49.2)	8 (74.9)	132 (31.9)	164 (25.1)	1.3
Seychelles	71 (47.9)	110 (47.4)	21 (71.7)	159 (27.3)	-4.6
Mauritius	77 (47.3)	165 (33.5)	24 (70.4)	68 (45.8)	4.1
Zambia	83 (46.7)	24 (67)	167 (19.1)	108 (39.4)	4.7
Tunisia	91 (45.3)	111 (47.3)	79 (46.6)	93 (41.4)	.7
Namibia	99 (44)	37 (62.7)	143 (26.8)	149 (30.3)	1.5
Senegal	100 (43.8)	77 (52)	93 (43.1)	144 (32)	3.6
Egypt	101 (43.7)	79 (51.5)	124 (33.5)	103 (40.4)	4.5

	Environmental Protection Index (EPI)	Ecosystem Vitality	Environmental Health	Climate Change	10-year movement in score for EPI
Tanzania	102 (43.6)	44 (60.7)	151 (25.1)	139 (32.5)	4.3
Côte D'Ivoire	104 (42.9)	89 (49.9)	123 (33.7)	99 (40.9)	5
South Africa	106 (42.7)	93 (49.3)	153 (24.4)	52 (48)	5.0
Burkina Faso	110 (42.2)	52 (58.6)	126 (33.3)	165 (24.9)	-.1
Guinea-Bissau	112 (42)	120 (45.6)	120 (35.6)	90 (41.8)	-.4
Algeria	114 (41.7)	136 (41.8)	75 (48.2)	122 (36.2)	2.6
Republic of Congo	116 (46.1)	32 (65.1)	170 (17.7)	152 (29.3)	1.3
Angola	124 (40.1)	132 (44.1)	162 (21.8)	44 (49.4)	7.7
Niger	125 (40)	50 (59)	134 (30.6)	173 (19.4)	6.9
Sierra Leone	126 (39.9)	143 (39.4)	126 (33.3)	59 (46.8)	4.0
UK	5 (72.6)	11 (72.8)	8 (78.1)	4 (67.8)	2.1
France	12 (67)	21 (67.8)	18 (72.3)	11 (61.3)	1.7
US	35 (57.2)	73 (53.5)	18 (72.3)	42 (50.1)	.3
Brazil	47 (53)	35 (63.9)	96 (42.4)	70 (45.5)	6.6
China	156 (35.4)	158 (35.6)	136 (29.7)	107 (39.8)	7.4
India	176 (27.6)	171 (30.4)	177 (13.5)	133 (35)	4.7

Source: Yale Center for Environmental Law and Policy Environmental Protection Index 2024.

Climate change

These rankings show that, despite resource constraints, several African ~~nations~~ countries

Commented [MM35]: Is there too much on climate innovation - and sustainability - can we merge the section so we list it as an area where real innovation is happening. Another sector is fintech - that's huge in africa - my preference is we reduce the climate stuff and add in something in fintech

are not only protecting their ecosystems but are also making progress on climate mitigation and environmental health. Innovation in policy, regulation, technology and community practices underpins many of these results.

Another important measure is the Climate Change Adaptation Index, which captures how well countries can adapt to the impacts of climate change, recognising that Africa contributes only 4% to global climate change and yet it suffers the deepest consequences.

The index combines two pillars. Vulnerability measures exposure, sensitivity and capacity to adapt across six sectors: food, water, health, ecosystem services, human habitat and infrastructure.

Readiness measures the ability to leverage investments and use them for the purpose of adaptation based on economic, governance and social readiness.

Table 3 below presents the overall adaptation index rank, the vulnerability rank, the readiness rank and the gap between vulnerability and readiness.

Out of 192 countries on the overall index, Mauritius, Seychelles and Morocco are standout performers in 70th, 83rd and 90th place respectively. Tunisia, Cabo Verde, Seychelles, Botswana, and Algeria are inside the top 100 with South Africa just outside. These are African climate change adaption leaders.

On vulnerability alone, Seychelles, Algeria, South Africa, Tunisia and Morocco, are in the top 100, with Mauritius just outside meaning they are less vulnerable compared with many other nations. Morocco, in 53rd place, is the leading African country on this dimension.

Vulnerability continues to be a challenge for nations in the table due to drought, desertification, floods and agricultural sensitivity. This also reflects dependence on rain-fed agriculture, limited climate resilient infrastructure and exposure to drought.

Mauritius, as a small island state, is deemed to be one of the most vulnerable of African countries to climate change. The government moved quickly to address impending issues, setting up the Climate Change Act 2020, which enabled the establishment of a separate department to address the issue as well as an inter-ministerial council to coordinate cross sector responses.

It has also focused on nature-based solutions to protect beaches and coral reefs, and legislation to tackle increasingly frequent floods and cyclones.

Morocco has addressed climate change through a comprehensive "whole-of-government" strategy, targeting a 45.5% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions by 2030. It aims to source 52% of its electricity from renewable energy by 2030.

The country focuses heavily on climate adaptation to combat severe drought, alongside massive renewable energy initiatives, such as the NOOR Complex, and advanced water security programmes, according to the UN Development Programme. It is also, along with South Africa, a forerunner in Africa in building green hydrogen capacity.

On readiness, Mauritius is also at the top of the five African countries in the top 100, ranked 58thth. Two other island states are ranked below it — Seychelles at 67th and Cabo Verde at 79th, followed by Rwanda (80), Morocco (92), Seychelles (93), and Botswana (98).

The gap between vulnerability and readiness gives an indication of whether a country's ability to attract and deploy adaptation investments is stronger or weaker than its level of vulnerability, which reflects a strong response to environmental protection by a host of countries and proactive adaptation planning.

According to the table, seven African countries have better readiness than vulnerability. Standout examples include Rwanda, Mauritius, Cabo Verde and Namibia. But the results also show that progress could be faster and countries more proactive, given the high risks that climate change presents to the continent.

It also flags the fact that there are resource and capacity problems, which are constraining the ability of even agile countries to move forward at speed.

Table 3: Climate Change Adaptation Index Rankings (out of 192 countries)

	Climate Change Adaptation Index	**Vulnerability**	**Readiness**	**Gap between Vulnerability and Readiness**
Mauritius	70	104	58	++46
Seychelles	83	78	93	+-15
Morocco	90	95	92	+3
Algeria	96	83	106	-23
Cabo Verde	108	120	101	+19
Tunisia	110	89	127	-38
Botswana	110	126	98	+28
Egypt	106	110	108	+2
Ghana	108	104	120	-16
South Africa	116	87	139	-52
Namibia	133	145	124	+21
Rwanda	126	169	80	+89
Brazil	72	39	101	-62
India	112	118	117	+1
China	61	56	69	-13

	Climate Change Adaptation Index	Vulnerability	Readiness	Gap between Vulnerability and Readiness
UK	5	2	17	-15
US	17	13	20	-7
France	16	15	19	-4

Source: Notre Dame Climate Adaptation Index 2024 and author adaptation.

In the table above, the positive gap between readiness and vulnerability is where readiness is ranked higher than vulnerability and the minus gap is the reverse. The table is sorted according to better to less good rankings in the Climate Change Adaptation Index

Building the innovation ecosystem

The patterns described above are the result of deliberate choices by governments, businesses, communities and regional bodies, combined with the everyday creativity of citizens.

By 2010, only about eight African countries had policy frameworks for science, technology and innovation. By 2020, at least 25 countries had such frameworks in place. This shift signals a clear recognition by policymakers that innovation is not a luxury. It is a necessity for economic transformation, job creation and resilience.

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At continental level, the African Union has given this agenda a clear direction through its Science, Technology and Innovation Strategy for Africa (STISA). The most recent strategy, STISA 2034, provides an overarching framework that recognises that many innovation challenges are interdependent and go across national borders.

The vision of STISA 2034 is to build an integrated, prosperous and peaceful Africa where science, technology and innovation drive sustainable socio-economic development. Its mission is “To harness the transformative power of science, technology and innovation into a knowledge based and innovation driven continent”.

The strategy focuses on priority sectors such as agriculture, health, ICT, energy and the environment. It also highlights several cross-cutting priorities and actions. These include industrialisation, human capital, infrastructure and skills, frontier and emerging technologies, science diplomacy and partnerships, private sector engagement, and youth and gender engagement.

These priorities align closely with the evidence presented in previous sections. Countries that invest in education, especially in science and engineering, tend to show up strongly in the GII and AI indices. Those that support renewable energy, low carbon technologies and environmental protection often perform more strongly on the EPI.

Governments that articulate clear AI visions and invest in data and governance frameworks are better placed to shape how new technologies are used.

Alongside these formal strategies, grassroots and frugal innovation has continued to flourish. Local initiatives such as Wecyclers, EcoPost, EarthEnable and Fabrica de Herois, all described above, have emerged because communities face pressing problems and cannot wait for perfect conditions to find novel ways to address longstanding challenges.

Their work has, in many cases, inspired policy changes, attracted investment and influenced how larger firms and governments think about crafting solutions.

Private sector actors, from startups to large corporations, have also played a key role. Fintech companies have expanded digital payments and financial inclusion. Edtech firms have experimented with new learning platforms.

Creative industries have built new cultural exports. Nigeria's Nollywood is now a globally recognised phenomenon in the world of movies, while African producers are driving globally accessible Netflix content.

African music such as Afrobeats (Nigeria) and Amapiano (South Africa) are gaining popularity outside the continent while African fashion designers are making inroads into international markets. Technology and innovation are helping them to penetrate new markets.

Venture capital, though still limited compared to other regions, has begun to back African entrepreneurs in greater numbers, including African funders.

Regional and international partnerships have reinforced these trends. Universities and research institutes collaborate across borders. Development partners and investors support pilot projects in climate adaptation, digital infrastructure and health innovation.

The fact that many African countries now outperform or match peers in Asia and Latin America on innovation, AI and climate readiness is evidence of this cumulative effort.

This chapter has shown that innovation in Africa is widespread, varied and increasingly visible in the data. It includes high-tech research and sophisticated financial markets at one end, and localised, frugal and often informal solutions that meet immediate needs at the other.

Some countries perform strongly in the Global Innovation Index and have improved their rankings over the last five years or more. Others lead on environmental protection and climate adaptation, areas where innovation and sustainability are closely linked.

The story is not one of uniform progress. Gaps remain within and between countries. Yet there is a solid foundation for optimism. African nations have long been drawing on local knowledge, creativity and skills while also building long-term scientific capability and infrastructure.

Chapter Five: Entrepreneurship

A Continent Shaped by Everyday Enterprise

If you begin the morning in Addis Ababa, you might see a group of women sorting strips of recycled tyres, preparing the soles that will become the next batch of SoleRebels shoes. Their work is steady, careful and filled with pride. What began as a small idea rooted in Ethiopia's *barabasso* tradition now reaches customers across the world.

Yet the most powerful part of this story is not its global reach. It is the way it mirrors thousands of other stories across the continent, where people take what they have, combine it with what they imagine and create something entirely new that can provide them with a livelihood.

Scenes like this unfold everywhere in Africa. A health worker in Lagos checks the real-time dashboard of LifeBank to confirm that blood supplies are on their way to a hospital. LifeBank is a Nigerian healthcare and logistics company, founded in 2017, that transports blood from laboratories in the city to patients and doctors across the country.

A young engineer in Kigali experiments with a low-cost solar prototype. A seamstress in Accra trains two apprentices and quietly becomes an employer. A market trader in Lusaka sources produce through a digital platform to stabilise her weekly margins.

These moments often look ordinary at first glance. Yet they form the fabric of Africa's complex economic reality. They reflect a continent where entrepreneurship is not a luxury or an exception. It is a daily practice and a way of navigating life.

There is considerable cause for optimism in Africa about entrepreneurship. Many countries are rated among the highest globally for total early-stage entrepreneurial activity. For example, Nigeria, Angola, Senegal and Togo often exceed 30-40% early-stage entrepreneurial activity. There are some powerhouse numbers to show the depth and breadth of entrepreneurship[8].

According to Mohac Africa's 2026 report on The State of Entrepreneurship in Africa, more than 20% of working age Africans are actively launching or running a new business, while more than 75% of young Africans intend to start a business within the next five years. The youth population, which dominates African demographics, adds to confidence about Africa's entrepreneurship journey, given the propensity for younger people to start businesses.

Small to medium sized businesses (SMEs) are the engine of growth and in many countries contribute more than 50% of GDP and 80% of jobs. As the Mastercard Foundation points out, many SMEs are themselves optimistic about their futures. For example, half of SMEs that responded to a Mastercard Foundation survey in South Africa are optimistic about the next 12 months and 43% expect their revenue to grow.[9]

The large-scale informal entrepreneurial sector, often driven by necessity due to the paucity of formal jobs, is extremely important in providing a living for rapidly growing populations, enabling them to develop entrepreneurial experience and to become embedded in local supply chains, while building trust networks.

The end game, ideally, is the formalisation of these businesses, allowing them to enter the mainstream economy, raise capital and contribute to the state.

African entrepreneurs build solutions, address problems and challenges and develop businesses out of constraint. For example, businesses abound in the off-grid solar business to address energy access, in low- cost housing to address affordable and stable housing in an environment of significant housing shortages, to provide affordable health care, to develop climate smart agriculture to confront the challenges of climate change, as well as start logistics businesses to move products over difficult terrain.

Entrepreneurship is practical, purpose driven and often socially driven with the aim of transforming structural challenges into business opportunities and responding positively and pro-actively to market failures and institutional gaps.

There are a variety of other reasons to be optimistic about entrepreneurship. Technology hubs, including incubators and accelerators, which will drive firms and industries of the future, are developing at a rapid rate, most notably in Kenya and Nigeria. By 2023, there were more than 1,000 technology hubs in Africa, up from 300 less than a decade before.

The supporting environment for entrepreneurship is rapidly growing and improving. Venture deals (venture capital and venture debt) grew in compound annual terms by 16% in less than 10 years from 2015 to 2024.[10]

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[8] Global Entrepreneurship Monitor latest date.
[9] Mastercard Foundation, SME Confidence Index.
[10] African Private Capital Association (AVCA), 2025 Venture Capital in Africa Report.

Foreign venture capital has dominated the funding of African startups., driven by US and European venture capital firms as well as global emerging markets funds, development finance institutions and impact investors.

The numbers have been significant. In 2021, a post-COVID book saw up to $5 billion flowing into African startups, up nearly three times from 2019. It has been slightly lower since then, but African funders have started to come to the party, recognising the gains that the combination of energy, vision and technology can bring.

Fintech still dominates funding into startups, but is increasingly flowing into other sectors such as energy, health, education, logistics and climate tech.

Market size and growth, producing vast business opportunities, is an important factor associated with the rising middle class and the increasing movement of goods and people across borders. The vibrant and growing diaspora is an important source of capital, ideas, knowhow and business collaborations.

There are outstanding role models of entrepreneurs in Africa who are becoming known globally providing an important signalling effect for would-be entrepreneurs. Many of them have been mentioned earlier in this volume. African start ups received honours at the most recent Earthshot Prize, the world's most prestigious environmental prize, which had nominees from 43 African countries.

Those receiving honours included the Green Africa Youth Organisation, a Ghanaian-led circular waste organisation; Keep IT Cool from Kenya, which uses solar energy and smart refrigeration services to help smallholder farmers to reduce post-harvest waste; and Mukuru Clean Stoves, also from Kenya which won a prize for making cleaner stoves to reduce air pollution and protect women's health.

Entrepreneurship ~~in Africa~~on the continent reaches far beyond formal company registrations or the success of a few high-profile innovators. It flows through informal markets, growing SMEs, rural cooperatives, tech startups and community-based ventures.

It is visible in the resourcefulness of people who build livelihoods in unpredictable environments and in the boldness of those who take risks because they believe their ideas are worth pursuing.

It is worth noting, however, that many people survive on trading or selling activities, which often do not become a business as such, experience growth or build jobs, but do provide people with livelihoods in the streets and markets of African countries, taking advantage of the informal nature of economies.

Some step into obvious market gaps that reflect Africa's realities, for example tyre menders who are found on the roadsides, ready to address tyres damaged by potholed roads between and within urban centres.

This chapter tells the story of that entrepreneurial landscape. It argues that entrepreneurship is one of the most important forces shaping Africa's present and future. It is a driver of growth, a source of resilience and a platform for innovation.

It is also evidence of something deeper. Africans demonstrate confidence, ingenuity and optimism through the businesses they build, even when resources are limited or circumstances are difficult.

To understand this story, the chapter unfolds in four parts.

It begins by exploring what entrepreneurship means in the African context and how it manifests in daily life.

It then explains why entrepreneurship is central to development across the continent. The chapter goes on to analyse key trends and data that illustrate the scale, diversity and momentum of entrepreneurial activity. It also reflects on the policies, initiatives and social conditions that have helped shape the current landscape. Throughout, examples and case studies illuminate both the challenges and the extraordinary potential that defines African enterprise.

The central thesis of this chapter is that African countries are building opportunity daily. Rather than viewing entrepreneurship as something in infant stages or a space where people in Africa lack capacity, it's vital to understand entrepreneurship as central to the continent's development story.

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Part 1: The shape of entrepreneurship

Stories like those of SoleRebels and LifeBank reveal something fundamental about how entrepreneurship appears across Africa. It rarely begins with abundant capital or formal structures. It often starts with a problem that needs solving, a tradition that can be reimagined or a skill that can be sharpened into a livelihood. In this way, African entrepreneurship blends creativity with necessity, local knowledge with global ambition and personal resilience with community rootedness.

SoleRebels, for instance, did not emerge from a typical manufacturing environment. It grew out of a neighbourhood where employment opportunities were scarce and where creative talent was abundant but overlooked.

Bethlehem Tilahun Alemu did more than build a footwear company. She built a model for how local craft can become a global product without abandoning its cultural identity. The company channels traditional weaving, recycled materials and ethical production into a modern business that has reached international markets. It shows how African entrepreneurs often innovate by drawing on heritage while responding to contemporary demand.

LifeBank followed a different path but illustrates the same principle. It responded to a challenge that is both urgent and deeply human. Hospitals across Nigeria struggled to source blood in time to save patients. Temie Giwa Tuboson transformed her own experience of childbirth complications into a mission to close that gap.

Her solution used technology in a way that is both sophisticated and practical. Real time tracking, predictive inventory and a network of delivery methods such as drones and motorbikes make LifeBank a platform that fits the realities of African cities. It is entrepreneurship shaped by empathy, necessity and a determination to improve public health systems.

These examples show that entrepreneurship in Africa encompasses new ventures, informal enterprises, cooperatives, side businesses and local innovations that grow from everyday life. It includes the person who opens a home-based tailoring shop, the farmer who experiments with

new irrigation techniques or the software developer who designs a tool for mobile payments. The common thread is the willingness to act, even when conditions are uncertain, and to pursue opportunity in ways that reflect local strengths and constraints.

Definitions from institutions such as the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor and the OECD help formalise the concept, but African entrepreneurship often stretches beyond these definitions. It thrives in informal markets that operate with remarkable efficiency despite often seeming chaotic to outsiders.

It adapts quickly to shifts in economic, political or environmental conditions. It brings together small networks of family, friends and community members who pool resources or share risk. It is fluid, responsive and shaped by the unique social landscape of each country.

Understanding entrepreneurship in Africa therefore requires an appreciation of the environments in which people imagine and build businesses. It requires attention to the economic, cultural and personal forces that influence decision making. And it requires recognition that even in places where formal employment is limited, people create their own opportunities.

This chapter builds on this understanding by examining why entrepreneurship matters so deeply for Africa's development and how the evidence reveals a pattern of confidence, innovation and determination.

Part 2: Entrepreneurship and Africa's story

Entrepreneurship matters because it gives shape to Africa's development story. It represents the way people build futures in environments that shift quickly, where formal employment is limited and where ambition often outpaces available resources.

For many families, a business is more than an income. It is a source of stability, a pathway to dignity and a tool for building generational progress. When a young woman opens a salon that later trains apprentices, or when a small trader grows her market stall into a supply business, the impact moves far beyond the individual. It influences households, neighbourhoods and entire value chains.

Economic studies across the continent echo this lived reality. They show that entrepreneurship is strongly linked to economic growth and is far more effective at spurring long-term development than interventions such as foreign aid. Entrepreneurs introduce new ideas, create jobs and stimulate consumption. They make economies more competitive and more adaptive.

Entrepreneurship also provides something less measurable but equally important: agency. It allows people to respond to challenges in ways that reflect their own priorities and strengths. It encourages problem solving and nurtures local solutions to issues ranging from food systems and health logistics to climate adaptation. When viewed together, these effects reveal that entrepreneurship is not peripheral to Africa's development; it is one of the main engines powering economic and social progress.

Part 3: What the evidence shows

The evidence across Africa offers a rich and convincing picture of a continent overflowing with entrepreneurial drive. The numbers reveal not only activity, but a pattern of optimism, intention and resilience that runs through societies at every level.

One of the strongest indicators is New Business Density, a World Bank dataset that measures how many new businesses are created for every thousand working age people (ages 15-64). It is a simple measure, yet it captures something profound: the willingness of people to take risks, imagine new possibilities and create value.

It should be noted that the World Bank data captures only formal, registered businesses not the plethora of informal enterprises that abound in African nations. But it still provides a useful indicator of economic activity.

According to the Bank, 30 out of 43 African countries with available data saw New Business Density rise between 2013 and 2022. This steady increase over a 10-year period points to shifts in economic confidence and capability.

Commented [MM37]: What does new business density mean and why is it important

In 2022 or the nearest available year, the top performers were Cabo Verde with an impressive 18.5, South Africa 11.1, Mauritius 9.6 and Botswana 8.7. Five countries exceeded the global average, three countries scored higher than China, four countries performed better than France and Brazil and all the African countries in the table exceeded India's increase.

These results disrupt the common assumption that African economies lag in business formation. Sub-Saharan Africa as a region performs better than South Asia, even though performance varies significantly across the continent. Variation, however, does not signal weakness. Instead, it reflects the diversity of African economies and the different stages of transformation under way.

Table 1: New Business Density 2022 (number of businesses per 1,000 people - working age population)

	2012	**2022**
Cabo Verde	2.9	18.5
South Africa	6.9	11.1
Mauritius	7.7	9.6
Botswana	12.9	8.7
Eswatini	2.4	4.1
Morocco	1.5	2.6
Zimbabwe	1.3	2.3
Sâo Tomé and Principe	2.8	2.2
Rwanda	1.4	2.1
Seychelles	2.9	1.9
Tunisia	1.6	1.7
Djibouti		1.6
Kenya	1.4	1.6

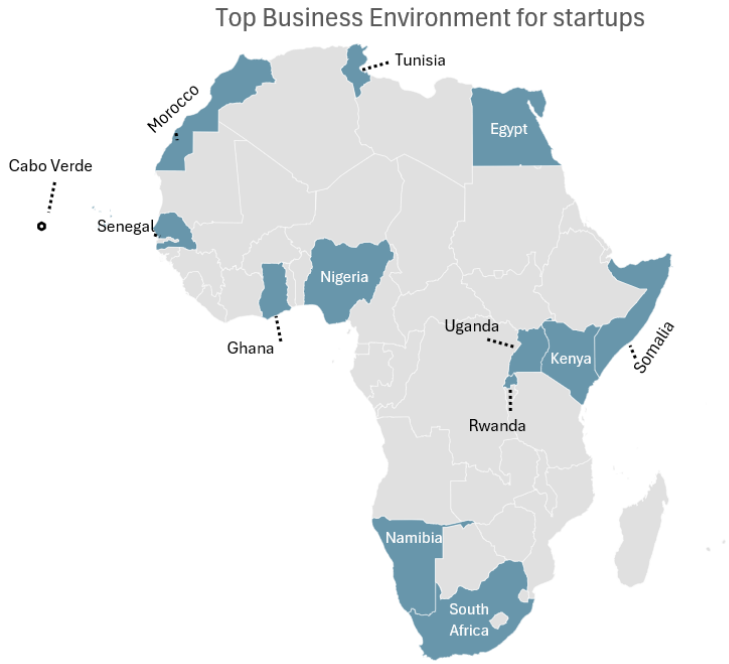
	2012	2022
Zambia	1.2	1.6
Lesotho	1.5	1.4
Angola		1.3
Ghana	.9	1.3
Senegal	.5	1.3
Côte D'Ivoire	.1	1.2
SSA	1.3	1.8
UK	11.8	18.6
China	3.8	8.6
France	3.8	6.7
Brazil	2.7	5.1
India	.12	.18
World	1.95	3.4

Source: World Bank New Business Density Index.

The vibrancy of Africa's startup ecosystem adds another layer to the story. The Global Startup Ecosystem Index Report for 2025 by global research platform StartupBlink, identifies 13 African countries as being among the top 100 startup environments in the world. South Africa is ranked 52nd with Kenya close behind at 58th. Egypt, Nigeria, Cabo Verde, Ghana, Tunisia, Namibia, Morocco, Senegal, Uganda, Rwanda, and Somalia round out the list.

The report points to the importance of the entrepreneurial ecosystem which comprises firms and the supporting architecture such as technology hubs, incubators and government policy. These ecosystems cross regions, languages and economies, yet all share a similar momentum.

Map 1: Top Startup Environments (shown in blue)



Source: Author adaptation from StartupBlink report 2025

Startups ~~in Africa are across the board. They~~ are emerg~~e~~ing in fintech, edtech, clean energy, ICT, agtech and rapidly growing frontiers such as artificial intelligence and big data. Their rise is driven by multiple forces.

Youth-led innovation is reshaping industries. Diaspora communities bring skills, capital and networks. Strategic locations link Africa to the Americas, Europe and Asia. Public and private sectors are investing in enabling environments where experimentation is encouraged.

Taken together, these drivers point to a continent positioning itself to compete in industries of the future.

Table 2: Start-ups in Africa

Source: Author adaptation from Startup Blink report 2025

Country	Rank in the world 2025	Rank 2021	Key drivers of start-up activity	Best industries for start-ups	Govt policy
South Africa	52	48	Youth	Edtech, fintech	Grants, loans, non-financial assistance. Institutions such as Silicon Cape Initiative, Plug and Play Tech Centre, Digital Collective, Founders Factory
Kenya	58	61	Tech Hubs, attraction of capital, English speaking point of access	Fintech, clean energy	Kenya Innovation Bridge connecting potential partners in the ecosystem; Digital nomad visas; International collaborations
Egypt	65		Access to talent, large market size	ICT, fintech	Public sector support for incubators and accelerators; Comprehensive ICT policy; Publicly backed venture capital fund
Nigeria	66	63	Market size, establishment of unicorns	Fintech, consumer goods	Seed funding; Co-creation hubs; incubators; Start Up Act; National Council for Digital Innovation and Entrepreneurship; International collaboration and infrastructure support (Starlink)

Country	Rank in the world 2025	Rank 2021	Key drivers of start-up activity	Best industries for start-ups	Govt policy
Cabo Verde	75	87	Public sector commitment; geographical linkage between Africa, the Americas and Europe; foreign entrepreneurs and digital nomads; strong core of local entrepreneurs	ICT, tourism, blue economy	NOSI Managing the Information Society; Digital nomads programme; Cabo Verde Digital Programme; Diaspora investment attraction; Youth entrepreneurship programmes
Ghana	81	81	Female entrepreneurs; hubs and accelerators	Mobile finance; agtech	Start up and innovation Bill; National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme; YouStart government programme for young entrepreneurs; Centres of Excellence and Schools of Technology
Tunisia	82	82	International investment attraction and collaboration; incubators and accelerators; proximity to Middle East, Africa and Europe	AI, big data, life sciences, blue economy	Tax breaks; Legal frameworks; Startup Tunisia; World Bank support

Country	Rank in the world 2025	Rank 2021	Key drivers of start-up activity	Best industries for start-ups	Govt policy
Namibia	85	99	Secure and stable environment; links to strong innovation agenda	Energy and environment	Namibia Investment Promotion and Development Board; StartUp Namibia; ScaleUp Namibia to bridge the gap between start up ideas and market ready business; incubation and innovation centres
Morocco	88	95	Youth; international attractiveness; digital connectivity	E-commerce and retail	Digital strategy; Tax breaks for entrepreneurs; Technology parks
Senegal	92	105	Favourable business climate and strong institutions	Logistics, fintech, AI, Internet of Things	Digital Strategy; Technological New Deal focusing on national digital infrastructure and internet access; Technology hubs; innovation funding and skill enhancement programmes
Uganda	94	97	Youth and influx of skilled people; well educated workforce; entrepreneurial culture	Agtech; AI, machine learning; robotics and biotechnology	National ICT initiatives; hubs; Deep Tech Centre of Excellence

Country	Rank in the world 2025	Rank 2021	Key drivers of start-up activity	Best industries for start-ups	Govt policy
Rwanda	96	69	Strong innovation and start-up culture	ICT; foodtech	Tax breaks; Smart Rwanda Master Plan; Vision 2050 plan; Supportive Infrastructure including Centre for Fourth Industrial Revolution
Somalia	100	94	Strategic location; female entrepreneurship; youth and diaspora	Energy and environment; mobile telephony; e-learning; telemedicine	Business climate policies to attract investors

Source: StartupBlink Report 2025. Adapted by author.

Survey data from the Global Entrepreneurship Monitor adds insights into the mindsets behind Africa's entrepreneurial activity.

In every African country surveyed, more than half of adults believed there are good opportunities to start a business. This is extraordinary when viewed through a global lens. Countries such as Togo and Sudan register opportunity perception rates exceeding 70%, placing them among the highest in the world.

These perceptions matter because entrepreneurship begins long before registration documents are filed. It begins with the belief that an idea is worth pursuing. This is a cause for considerable optimism.

Confidence in personal capability is equally remarkable. More than 89% of adult respondents in Senegal, 88% in Sudan and 87% in Togo believe they possess the skills to start a business. These confidence levels far exceed those of many other regions.

Sixteen African countries reported confidence rates above 70%. Low fear of failure strengthens this picture. In Uganda, only 12% of respondents indicate fear of failure as a barrier. In Senegal and Nigeria, the figure is 16%, and in Malawi and Zambia it stands at 15%. These psychological conditions are powerful. They show that African societies are filled with people who feel ready to take risks and who do not let uncertainty deter them.

Intentions to start businesses highlight this readiness even further. The percentage of adults surveyed that were planning to start a business in the next three years was among the highest globally. In Angola, 83% of respondents expressed this intention.

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Put differently, more than three quarters of the population sees entrepreneurship as part of their immediate future. In Angola, the GEM report says, four or more adults are starting or running a new business for every established company. It sits alongside countries such as Venezuela, Argentina, the UAE and Canada in this regard.

When compared with other regions, the contrast is striking. China's intention rate stands at 4% while France is 14%. African intention rates vary, with South Africa at a low of 7%, while countries such as Togo, Tunisia, Burkina Faso and Botswana exceed 50%.

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While this is also likely to speak to the smaller percentage of formal economies versus the formal economy in almost all African countries, it is still notable.

It is also notable that this confidence also reflects, in part, the low levels of formal employment available in Africa versus some other regions, and the fact that entrepreneurship is open to everyone, hence the high belief that this is the pathway to choose to earn a livelihood and succeed in business.

Another powerful indicator of Africa's entrepreneurial strength is the participation of women. In many countries, women are not only active contributors to enterprise, they also help business ecosystems to function. Their involvement is visible in ownership, management, market activity and local innovation.

The data from the World Bank Enterprise Surveys makes this clear. It shows that 15 African countries have a higher share of firms with women participating in ownership than the global average of 33.9%. Seychelles leads with an impressive 60.6%, followed by Lesotho at 55.4%, Eswatini at 50.2%, followed by Cabe Verde, Zimbabwe, and Burundi.

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These numbers do more than place African countries ahead of global benchmarks such as India, China, and the US. They show that entrepreneurial opportunity is not confined to a narrow segment of society. Instead, women are shaping markets, making investment decisions and building enterprises in ways that expand the continent's economic base.

This is partly because they tend to have fewer opportunities in formal employment than men and lower wages as a rule, but also because of their strong community focus and need to provide for their families.

Women are also stepping into leadership as top managers. Eswatini stands out at 34% and Lesotho at 30%. Both countries have prioritised female education and women have benefited from high labour migration of men to neighbouring South Africa to seek employment. But the shift has been positive for the economy. Women are also more commonly employed in the country's important garment and textile industry, which maintains strong export links to the global economy.

These figures reveal that women are not on the periphery of African entrepreneurship. They sit at its centre. They contribute to its resilience, innovation and sustainability. They show that when conditions improve for entrepreneurs, the greatest gains often appear among women, whose economic participation has historically been undervalued. In many African countries, women's entrepreneurship is not just rising. It is reshaping how economies function.

Table 3: Female Engagement in Entrepreneurship (latest available year)

	Percent of firms with female participation in ownership	Percent of firms with a top female manager
Seychelles	60.6	26.3
Lesotho	55.4	30
Eswatini	50.2	34
Cabo Verde	48.4	26.7
Zimbabwe	47.2	17.8
Burundi	47	11
Namibia	46.8	27.5
Zambia	41.5	12.9
Mauritius	39.6	18.1
Rwanda	37.8	28.1
Cameroon	36.8	21.2
Gabon	36.7	19.2
Kenya	36.5	17.7
Botswana	35.1	23
Ghana	35	19.8
South Sudan	33.8	10.5
Mozambique	33.7	21.3
Ethiopia	32.3	16.4
Benin	30.1	24.4
Uganda	27.9	22.6
India	3.9	6.8
France	51.2	19.9
Brazil	50.2	19.4

	Percent of firms with female participation in ownership	Percent of firms with a top female manager
UK	47.1	12.3
China	44	19.6
US	30.5	22.2
All economies	33.9	19.5

Source: World Bank Enterprise Surveys. Data is latest available year for each country which varies but is approximately 2021-2023.

This pattern strengthens the broader story captured in the data. High levels of optimism, confidence, skill and opportunity perception are not abstract traits. They translate into concrete outcomes, including high rates of women business ownership, participation and leadership. The momentum is therefore not only deepening; it is becoming more inclusive.

Africa's entrepreneurial landscape is not a small cluster of startups in major cities, but it is widespread mindset shaped by optimism and confidence. It shows that entrepreneurship is embedded in how people see their futures and navigate their lives. It also reflects a deep cultural foundation in which resourcefulness, adaptation and collaboration are longstanding strengths. When viewed together, the evidence challenges outdated narratives and positions Africa as a continent of builders, problem solvers and opportunity creators.

The business environment in African economies is a reason to be optimistic. One such measure is the average number of days to obtain a licence to operate. The data shows that African economies have a clear edge over a number of international competitors, thus providing a first to market competitive advantage.

The benefits to business include lowering start-up costs, reducing business uncertainty, enabling faster entry into markets, and encouraging formalisation of businesses. Thus, barriers to formalisation may not be anywhere near as constraining as is commonly assumed about Africa.

For example, Eswatini, Mali, Sudan, Somalia, Senegal, South Sudan, and Zimbabwe all have a shorter average time to get an operating licence than China, which is the best of the international competitors. In addition, all the African countries in the table have an operating licence turnaround that is twice as fast as the global average. This is a remarkable achievement.

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As further examples of the orders of magnitude, France takes 35 times longer than Eswatini and Brazil 25 times longer than Mali. All African countries in the table perform better than Brazil, France, India, UK and the US.

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The data also shows that efficiency is not about economic size. Both larger and smaller African economies have made extensive strides in this area, with some turning to automation and one-stop investment shops for new market entrants, with decentralised approvals processes.

Table 4: Average Days to Obtain a Licence (most recent year)

Country	Average number of days to get a licence
Eswatini	3.1
Mali	4.1
Sudan	4.7
Somalia	5
Senegal	5.1
South Sudan	5.5
Zimbabwe	6
Kenya	6.6
Mauritania	6.6
Ethiopia	6.9
Guinea	7.1
Uganda	7.1
Botswana	7.5
Togo	8.5
Djibouti	8.8
Tanzania	11.8
Madagascar	12
Seychelles	12.4
Morocco	12.8
Cameroon	13
Brazil	79.7
China	6.5
France	110.1
India	23.8
UK	37.2

US	17.7
All economies	27.4

Source: World Bank Enterprise Surveys. Note that years differ considerably by country.

StartupBlink measures the overall business environment for 125 countries globally according to the criteria of ease of operating a business, business incentives (how financially attractive a country is for entrepreneurs and investors), and market perception (how a country is viewed globally in terms of such factors as governance quality, human capital and international mobility).

The data shows that 22 African countries are among these 125 countries of the ranking, with 13 inside the top 100. The best performing countries are South Africa (61st), Kenya (58th), and Cabo Verde (70th). This highlights the fact that African countries are competitive on the global stage.

Part 4: How Africa built the ecosystem

Africa's entrepreneurial landscape did not appear overnight. It is shaped by longstanding cultural traditions of trade and community enterprise, but also by recent investments in education, policy reform, infrastructure and digital connectivity.

Governments, private sector actors, development partners and communities have all contributed to building ecosystems that nurture new and growing businesses, a trend that is only growing as countries find ways to address the challenge of employment.

Many countries have introduced programmes that support entrepreneurs at different stages of their journeys. Innovation hubs, incubators, accelerators and technology parks offer training, mentorship and access to networks.

Rwanda's Vision 2050 and Smart Rwanda Master Plan prioritise digital infrastructure and position the country as a centre for innovation. Tunisia's Start Up Act has created a supportive legal environment for young firms. Kenya has built a vibrant ecosystem of hubs and digital platforms that connect entrepreneurs to investors, markets and partners.

Cabo Verde has used its strategic geography to attract digital nomads and diaspora investment. Ghana has invested in youth entrepreneurship and opened Centres of Excellence in technology.

These efforts create environments in which taking risks feels possible and where support systems help entrepreneurs turn ideas into tangible ventures.

Table 2 above points to the range and depth of specific measures that have been implemented in countries to support entrepreneurial ecosystems. These include access to seed funding; institutional support for technology, incubators and accelerators; establishment of Centres of Excellence; digital nomad programmes; and tax breaks for research and investment.

Beyond formal policy, Africa's entrepreneurial landscape is also shaped by social dynamics. Extended families often share resources that help businesses get started. Community groups support informal savings and credit schemes. Informal markets create entry points for traders and small enterprises. Mobile technologies expand financial inclusion and lower barriers to participation. These systems, both formal and informal, anchor entrepreneurship in daily life.

The result is a landscape built on collective investment. It shows that entrepreneurship is not only an individual act. It is supported by national strategies, local ecosystems, cultural norms and shared ambitions. It is a product of intention, resilience and the determination of societies to create their own economic futures.

Chapter Six: Youth

A Demographic Dividend

There are many reasons to be optimistic about Africa's future and key among them is the continent's youthful demographic. Some 60% of the population is under the age of 25, and in Sub-Saharan Africa, 70% are under the age of 30.[11]

This rapidly growing young population offer Africa a significant demographic dividend, but the proviso is that the youth must be nurtured for this to become a reality. This requires improvements in quality education, skills development, and labour market access, among other key interventions.

According to the World Economic Forum, by 2030, 40% of the world's young people will be African. By 2050, Africa will account for 85% of the expected increase in the global working age population (those aged between 15-64 years old), with its own nearly doubling to 1.56 billion".[12]

Renowned African development economist Carlos Lopes calls Africa's demographic expansion a megatrend. He challenges the notion that population growth is a threat, arguing that African youth drive consumption, technological adoption, and new market opportunities. He believes this factor will be key to the global economy as populations age in other regions. But he cautions that the opportunity must be managed to prevent the large youth population becoming a driver of political instability and populism.

Some predictions indicate that, subject to appropriate education, skills, and training policy, per capita real incomes in economies in Africa could increase four-fold by 2050. Other predictions suggest that the favourable age structure could contribute 11–15% of GDP growth by 2030[13], while yet others predict growth rates in the range of 5%–8% across various countries in the region.

These projections are not guarantees. They are better understood as what becomes possible when young people can build skills, enter productive work, and contribute to growth for long enough to shift national trajectories.

There is much to be optimistic about in Africa's youth population. The youth is technologically savvy. They are users and developers of ICT which underpin industries of the future. On average 40% of Africans between the ages of 18 and 25 use the internet daily. It is high as 70% for Cabo Verde, 75.6% in Gabon, 91.8% in Seychelles and 88.2% in Tunisia.

Mobile phone usage data, a key enabler of business and maintaining human connections, shows that an average of 82% of African youth use a mobile phone every day. In Botswana, Cameroon, Congo and Côte d'Ivoire is above 84%, and more than 90% in Kenya, Gabon, Eswatini, Mauritius and Seychelles, according to Afrobarometer.

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[11] Itchikowitz Family Foundation African Youth Survey, 2024.

[12] McCallion P, Young population provides a bright outlook, World Economic Forum meeting, 23 January 2026.

[13] Japan International Co-operation Agency 2014, Development challenges in Africa towards 2050. See also Ahmed S, Cruz M, Go D, Maliszewska M & Osario-Rodarto M, How significant is Africa's demographic dividend for its further growth and poverty reduction? World Bank Policy Research Working Paper, 2014.

Youth in Africa are more likely to be entrepreneurs, the vehicles of wealth for a nation, than employees. This is because they have a greater propensity to take risks, see opportunities and possibilities, especially in ICT related businesses. They are also aspirational and are motivated by a desire for autonomy and flexibility.

However, the reality is also that self-employment is often the only option of ~~jobless~~ young people. Not everyone is an entrepreneur. Some young people engage in activities just to survive, hoping for a change in fortunes along the way.

Unemployment levels are high in many African countries, usually disproportionally affecting the youth. South Africa, one of the biggest economies in Africa, also has one of the highest jobless rates on the continent.

According to Statistics South Africa, in the first quarter of 2026, the national unemployment rate stood at 32,7%. The burden was disproportionately carried by the youth, with those aged 15-24 facing the highest unemployment rate at 60,9%, followed by those aged 25-34 at 40,6%.

Neighbouring Eswatini has the highest jobless rate in 2026 at 34.2%. High levels of informality may drive up those numbers.

But governments are increasingly aware of the need to create jobs, partly to quell dissatisfaction in their countries but also to improve livelihoods. The issue of local content in certain sectors and particularly in the resources sector, is becoming a big policy issue in Africa, while trade unions in countries such as South Africa are proactive in pushing for jobs to be both created and saved where disinvestment looms.

More than half of 18- to 25-year-olds in Africa would prefer to start their own businesses than be formally employed, according to research, going up to 74% in Senegal. For the 26- to 35-year-old age bracket, the corresponding number is 54%.

According to the Johannesburg-based Ichikowitz Family Foundation, which researches African advancement, seven out of 10 youth aim to start their own business in the future. [14]

Young people play a critical role in driving and maintain peace, stability and democratic norms. There is cause for optimism in Africa's in political outlook.

A 2024 survey by research organisation Afrobarometer showed that more than 64% of young people interviewed believe that democracy is preferable to any other kind of government. It was particularly high in a number of countries, at 84.6% for Senegal, 83% for Liberia, 81.5% for Morocco, 81% for Sierra Leone, 84.9% in Zambia, and 82.3% in Zimbabwe. [15]

The findings show that the youth rank unemployment and management of the economy as their top priorities for urgent government action, and most see their governments as failing on these issues, it said. The research also highlighted the fact that young people, despite dissatisfaction with the way their countries are being run and their preference for proper management of the economy, are reluctant to do anything about it, including not voting against incumbent regimes.

[14] For statistics in this paragraph see Afrobarometer and Ichikowitz Family Foundation African Youth Survey 2024

[15]

While this suggests that the voices of the youth are not being heard in policy discussions and decisions, a reason for optimism is a finding that there is greater engagement with the political process.

For example, 18 % of Gambian youth have banded together with others to request action from government, as a collective exercise to shape and drive the provision of services, and as high as 24% for Guinea, 26% for Kenya, 21% for Madagascar, about 30% in Uganda, and 22% in Zimbabwe.

The African Union has made youth participation a formal policy objective through the African Youth Charter, which calls for young people to be actively involved in policymaking and decision-making processes.

Many countries have youth ministries, youth councils, youth parliaments, and formal consultation mechanisms. The key is for their voices to filter through to policy decisions and not remain as talk shops.

While the youth are increasingly on the agenda, they still seem to be sidelined into community initiatives rather than having a seat at the table where the real discussions take place on political issues such as city management, for example, where they can bring new ideas to the table to solve age-old problems.

Another reason for optimism is the fact that young people are environmentally conscious and want to actively maintain their environments, an issue often neglected in their countries.

According to the Ichikowitz foundation, African youth exhibit rising concerns about climate change, and vulnerability of the continent. This means they are likely to be a positive force in influencing responses to environmental challenges, helping to shape new green futures.

Afrobarometer survey results show that about 70% of young people on the continent believe it is important for governments to take steps now to limit climate change in the future, even it is expensive or causes job losses or other harm to the economy.

This is the case for more than 80% of youth in Eswatini, Gambia, Guinea, Liberia, Madagascar (more than 90%), Malawi, and Tanzania.

Young people also tend to support the empowerment of females. For the continent as a whole, more than 58% disagree with the proposition that men have more right to a job, according to Afrobarometer.

The extent of disagreement with the proposition is far higher in Botswana, Benin, Cabo Verde, Seychelles at more than 80%, with findings between 71% and 78% in Kenya, Lesotho, Mauritius, Namibia, and South Africa.

This importantly shows a positive attitude to female empowerment in the workplace.

There are some important reasons for optimism on the broader issue of acceptance and tolerance of difference and diversity. When asked by Afrobarometer whether they like having neighbours of different ethnicities, more than 60% of the continent's youth surveyed answered in the affirmative.

The data shows that those saying they "somewhat like" or "strongly like" is highest in the Congo, Gambia, Cote D'Ivoire, Chad, Ghana, Kenya, Liberia, Malawi, Mozambique, Nigeria, Senegal,

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Sierra Leone, and Zambia, all either topping 60 or 70%. In Guinea, the numbers are as high as 84%, Mali 84.5%, and Tanzania 83.5%.

African youth believe that Africa needs to have a much stronger role in influencing global affairs. This potentially places the continent in a good position in the future shaping global events, addressing collective challenges, and navigating geopolitical issues.

Afrobarometer data shows that more than 70% of youth across the continent believe that Africa should have greater influence in the decision making of international bodies like the United Nations.

This sentiment is particularly strong in West Africa and North Africa, shown by surveys in Cameroon (79.9%), Côte D'Ivoire (82.2%), Gabon (89.9%), Liberia (82.9%), Madagascar (81%), Morocco (82.6%), Senegal (84.3%), Sierra Leone (85.3%), and Tunisia (84.6%).

African youth entrepreneurs and leaders also abound in more visible spaces. The Forbes magazine's 30 under 30 list, the World Economic Forum's Young Global Leaders (YGL) and Time's World's Most Influential Rising Stars programmes provide numerous examples of young Africans as change makers.

One such example is Nomzamo Mbatha, a South African actress, producer, humanitarian and accountant who has also established the Nomzamo Lighthouse Foundation. This provides scholarships for college students, supports basic school needs for youth and raises funds for black women entities that operate in underserved communities.[16]

Take the example of Ugandan Comfort Peace Ayikoru, who at the age of 27 is the Founder and Chief Executive Officer of Buri Care Ltd, a health entity comprising doctors, engineers, designers and caregivers who are providing care for premature babies and support for families.[17]

Many political leaders have come out of programmes such as the WEF's YGL, including South Africa's current minister of international relations and co-operation, Ronald Lamola. The WEF YGL programme, working with the Aliko Dangote Foundation in Nigeria, has also produced leaders in business, law and human rights organisations as well as governments.

Contributing to growth

In short, youth contribute to growth and improved living standards in several ways. They add labour that can drive productivity growth, they expand domestic consumer markets, they raise savings over time, and they often adopt new technology quickly.

They also start businesses, and their movement into urban centres fuels city-led growth. Generally, they are tolerant of diversity and have enlightened views about the role of females in the economy and society.

The Ichikowitz Family Foundation Report 2024 also finds that optimism and confidence among youth in countries in Africa has picked up since COVID-19.

[16] World Economic Forum, The Forum of Young Global Leaders, Website. https://www.weforum.org/communities/current-ygls/

[17] Forbes Africa, 30 Under 30 2025, Website. https://www.forbesafrica.com/category/under-30

Commented [MM42]: I think we should separate this out and list top 10 African changemakers….- or talk about the many fellowships and networks that support changemakwers - e,g, gates Goalkeepers, Skoll Foundation, tutu fellows.. And highlight those that have won awards eg Prince Here are some of the strongest pan-African leadership and changemaker networks that have influential alumni communities.

- Young African Leaders Initiative (YALI) – The largest leadership network for young Africans, with Regional Leadership Centres in Ghana, Kenya, Senegal, South Africa and beyond.
- African Leadership Institute – Archbishop Tutu Leadership Fellowship – One of Africa's most respected executive leadership fellowships, run with Oxford University, bringing together senior leaders from business, government and civil society.
- Obama Foundation Leaders: Africa – Selects emerging civic, business and public-sector leaders from across Africa for leadership development and lifelong networking.
  - Acumen Fellows East Africa & West Africa – Fellowship for values-driven social entrepreneurs and change leaders.
  - Ashoka Africa – Network of leading social entrepreneurs solving systemic problems across the continent.
- Eisenhower Fellowships Africa – Global network of influential leaders with many African fellows in business, government and civil society.
  - Africa Leadership Initiative (ALI) – Aspen Global Leadership Network – Country-based fellowships (South Africa, East Africa, West Africa, Nigeria) for senior leaders.

- Anzisha Prize Fellowship – Network of Africa's youngest entrepreneurs.
- Chevening Africa Alumni Network – Thousands of African leaders who have studied in the UK through the Chevening programme.
- Mo Ibrahim Foundation Leadership Fellowship – Highly competitive fellowship placing outstanding Africans in major multilateral institutions.
- African ChangeMakers Initiative (ACi) – Leadership and changemaker fellowship with alumni across all 54 African countries.

Harry Moonshot prize. Here is a list from Chatgpt:

Sentiment that the African continent is moving in the right direction rose from 31% in 2022 to 37% in 2024. Some countries ranked high on this optimism indicator, with Rwanda at 92% and Côte d'Ivoire at 90%. However, this is counterbalanced by more negative sentiment in Nigeria, Cameroon, and Chad.

As the report contends, "green shoots of Afro Optimism" are apparent. The majority of youth plan to build businesses into the future, and four out of five respondents in the survey have a strong sense of what they want to do with their lives.

They are confident that standards of living will rise and will be better than that experienced by their parents. They are more likely to feel concerned about issues rather than pessimistic, noting that corruption was at the top of their concerns, according to the Ichikowitz foundation.

These confidence measures are not the same as lived prosperity, and they should not be read as denial of hardship. They are better understood as a signal of social energy. In many economies in Africa, young people still plan, still invest effort, and still attempt enterprise and skills building, even while recognising corruption, limited public services, and job scarcity as real constraints.

Consistent with the optimistic view among the youth themselves is data from Afrobarometer, which, among other things, identifies how confident and optimistic African youth are about their country's economy heading in the right direction.

For example, 88% of 18 to 25-year-olds in Gabon believe this is the case for their economy, with strong outcomes registered in Mali (71%), Morocco (70.4%), Senegal 74.9%, Tanzania (77.3%), and Uganda (59.5%). In some countries, the youth is more confident about this than the general population as a whole.

Similarly, when asked whether their country would be better or much better in 12 months' time, more than 70% of youth surveyed in Algeria, Botswana, Mali, Senegal, and Cabo Verde thought it would. It was more than 86% of people surveyed in Gabon.

Other countries where the youth had strong confidence of better days ahead were Côte D'Ivoire, Kenya, Lesotho, Liberia, Mozambique, Tunisia, Sierra Leone, and Morocco. These nations traverse a range of geographical boundaries, income and population levels.

The youth's confidence about the state of their nations is likely to fuel greater youth investment, entrepreneurship and engagement in the labour market and possibly less migration to seek opportunities elsewhere.

These positive impacts, however, should be understood alongside the challenges that sit behind this optimism. Countries in Africa must provide jobs for a rapidly expanding labour force, which puts a premium on job creation policies, human capital investments, and broader structural reforms that unlock new sectors and higher productivity.

It is also important to treat youth optimism as something that shows up in daily decisions, not only in speeches or strategies.

A 23-year-old in Nairobi might take her first job in a small retail shop and quickly realises the wage will not carry her rent, transport, and family obligations. She starts selling phone accessories after hours, then shifts to taking orders through WhatsApp, and learns the hard part, which is not buying stock, but building trust.

Customers return when deliveries arrive on time, when faults are handled fairly, and when prices stay consistent. Her “side hustle” looks informal from the outside, yet it requires organisation and planning. It is also a practical response to an economy where many young people stitch together livelihoods.

That journey captures the chapter’s core argument. Youth optimism is often expressed as persistence, adaptation, and a willingness to keep building even when the formal system moves slowly and sometimes move against informal entrepreneurs.

We argue, in this chapter, that the wider point across economies in Africa is that youth are building social and economic value in ways that can be measured. The evidence below shows how that optimism manifests across education, work, wellbeing and civic participation, and confidence about economic direction.

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Prospects and participation

There is evidence that youth in African nations are to some extent becoming more skilled. There is reason for optimism in that these young people are finding jobs in higher paid, more secure jobs in or supporting more advanced sectors of the economy as economies grow. This is particularly true for technology-related work.

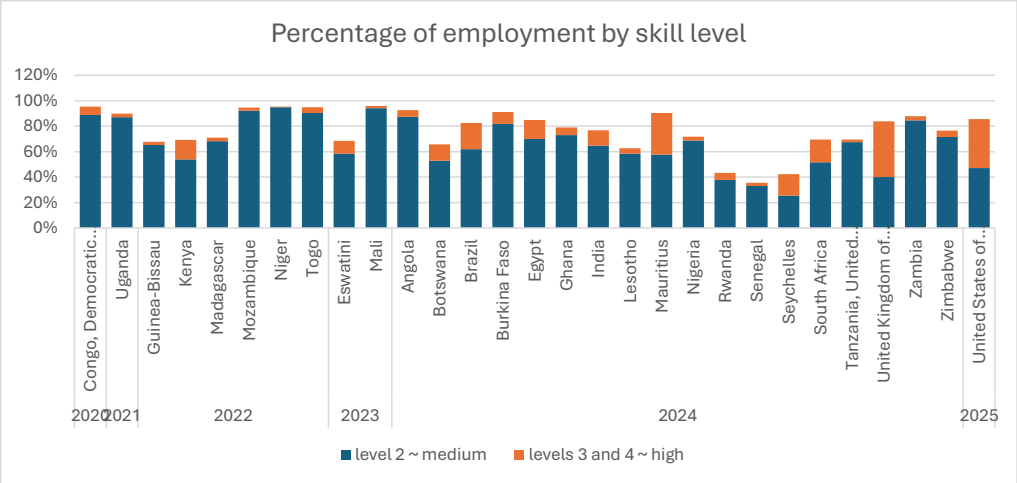
Of course, there are still very significant challenges in terms of providing enough meaningful jobs for the vast numbers of young people entering the workforce and given high rates of informality. But nonetheless, the signs are promising.

The following chart shows the proportion of total employment among youth that is accounted for by those in medium-skilled and high-skilled jobs, for the latest year available, with the remainder being in low-skilled jobs.

According to the International Labour Organisation (ILO), medium-skill employees typically are those with post-secondary non-tertiary education or upper secondary level of education. High skilled employees are those with degrees from higher education institutions (or short-cycle tertiary education).

As can be seen, of total youth employment, medium-skill jobs dominate in African nations, although high-skill jobs are significant in several countries including in Mauritius (33%), South Africa (18%), Seychelles (17%), and Egypt (15%).

While companies needing low-skill professions do absorb much African labour, the market is not dominated by those professions, with millions moving up the ranks to medium-skill jobs.



Source: International Labour Organisation. Graph composed by author.

Building youth capability

Underpinning this data about skilled employment is the fact that education levels are improving in many African countries, a cause for optimism. Completion rates and years spent in education provide one of the clearest signals that systems are strengthening, even as quality and equity challenges remain.

Table 1: Lower Secondary Completion Rates - UNESCO modelled estimates (%)

	2000 (or nearest year)	**2015 (or nearest year)**	**2024 (or nearest year)**
Botswana	58.80	88.80	96.10
Mauritius	67.70	88.50	93.40
South Africa	78.20	85.60	90
Egypt	65.40	81.60	88.20
Zimbabwe	63.60	69.20	74.10
Nigeria	56.20	67.20	73.70
Algeria	36.00	61.90	72.60
Djibouti	34.60	55.80	66.60
Ghana	43.60	54.90	64.70
Comoros	24.20	46.90	62.50

	2000 (or nearest year)	2015 (or nearest year)	2024 (or nearest year)
Congo	25.70	44.50	62.00
Kenya	38.90	59.50	61.10
Gambia	28.40	47.30	56.70
Namibia	37.20	49	55.30
DRC	23.90	43.50	50.40
Cameroon	22.80	39.50	48.10
Zambia	31.90	45.10	47.80
Togo	15.50	34.20	47.50
Morocco	30.80	42	47.40
Sierra Leone	11	38.20	46.40
UK	99.60	99.70	99.90
US	96.30	98.70	99.00
France	96.10	97.70	98.50
China	68.90	89.50	94.30
India	54.60	80.60	89.90
Brazil	62.70	78.90	88.30

Source: UNESCO Table. Arranged according to 2024.

** Lower secondary refers usually to children of 12-15 years of age*

The table shows completion rates for lower secondary education over a 25-year period for the top 20 African nations and benchmark countries. All African economies in the table have experienced increases, often very significant. Between 2000 and 2025 for example, Algeria's completion rate for lower secondary more than doubled to reach 72.6% in 2025.

Fifteen economies in Africa have completion rates of more than 50%. Botswana grew from 58.80 to 96.10, to reach almost universal lower secondary rate completion. Mauritius and South Africa have rates of completion at more than 90%, with Egypt, just outside, at 88.8%.

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These three economies in Africa have completion rates which exceed those in India and Brazil. Botswana's lower secondary completion rate is higher than China's.

Thus, the often-held perception that African youth are uneducated is a misconception. The growing engagement with schooling reflects African youth commitment to education and the investments that countries have been making in education.

Table 2: Completion Rates, Upper Secondary - UNESCO modelled estimates (%)

	2000 (or nearest year)	2015 (or nearest year)	2024 (or nearest year)
Egypt	60.30	80.20	87.60
Nigeria	50.90	58.90	64.00
Botswana	29.80	52.20	63.90
Mauritius	19.70	48.10	60.40
South Africa	41.70	45.80	50.90
Algeria	15.40	36.70	49.40
Ghana	12.70	30.30	45.20
Bangladesh	11.50	24.10	39.30
Kenya	21.30	34.50	37.40
Namibia	24.70	31.90	36.50
Comoros	11.30	24.60	34.60
Sudan	18.50	29.30	33.90
Djibouti	13.30	25.50	33.70
Gambia	16.40	27.30	33.10
Congo	13.90	23.60	31.10
Zambia	15.00	25.00	29.80
Morocco	16.10	23.40	26.50
Guinea	7.20	18.70	24.90
Lesotho	12.80	19.60	24.00
Mauritania	6.20	14.80	23.30
US	88.10	92.50	93.20
UK	87.40	88.40	90.00

	2000 (or nearest year)	2015 (or nearest year)	2024 (or nearest year)
China	28.30	66.90	88.10
France	79.90	83.80	87.40
Brazil	44.80	59.90	71.30
India	25.30	49.40	63.90

Source: UNESCO Chart. Arranged according to 2024 data from higher to lower.

** Upper secondary is typically children of 15-17 years of age*

Completion rates for upper secondary are lower than for lower secondary as youth seek employment, and engage in home care and household activities, especially females, as they get older.

There is still evidence of a gender divide, despite significant improvements over time. For example, in 2024 there were 93 girls in Africa for every 100 boys in upper secondary education, with North Africa having more girls enrolled than boys, but in Central Africa it was 79 girls for every 100 boys, and in East Africa 71 girls for every 100 boys.

Across the continent, there is still a five-point percentage gap in lower and upper secondary competition rates when taking into account late completers. [18]

Nonetheless, over the 25-year period, all economies in Africa shown in the table have experienced improvements, with these most pronounced in Algeria, Botswana, Comoros, Djibouti, Egypt, Gambia, Ghana, Kenya, and Mauritius.

Five economies in Africa have completion rates of greater than 50%, namely Botswana, Egypt, Mauritius, Nigeria, and South Africa. Egypt has the highest in Africa at 87.60 and is on a par with lower secondary completion rates.

In terms of comparators outside Africa, Egypt is above India, Brazil and France, while Egypt, Nigeria, and Botswana outperform India. These patterns suggest that investments in secondary education infrastructure, pedagogy and teacher training are paying dividends for economies in Africa, while noting that indicate anything about the relative quality of education systems.

There are two clear points to be optimistic about Africa. Firstly, more people are completing secondary school and second, more are completing advanced secondary education. This highlights the potential for young people to engage in higher skill intensive industries, which will drive future prosperity.

School life expectancy at secondary level has increased over time in almost all countries in Africa. In some, including Cabo Verde, Gambia, Mauritius, and South Sudan, school life expectancy is approximating or exceeding levels in some non-African countries.

[18] UNESCO 2026, Gender equity in access for education in Africa.

Comparisons can be difficult because school systems differ in the length of study and the possibility of repeats. Even so, higher expected rates of school life expectancy generally mean a higher probability of spending more years in education and therefore higher retention in the system.

Table 3: Gross Enrolment Ratio for Tertiary Education - UNESCO modelled estimates

	2000 (or nearest year)	**2015 (or nearest year)**	**2024 (or nearest year)**
Algeria	15.29	38.24	54.43
Morocco	10.15	28.55	48.18
Mauritius	16.45	37.76	45.78
Tunisia	18.25	33.37	38.12
Egypt	27.89	32.88	38.04
Namibia	7.40	19.66	26.11
Cabo Verde	1.78	22.52	24.29
South Africa		17.94	23.49
Ghana	5.35	15.56	22.10
Botswana	6.98	26.87	21.41
Comoros	1.6	9.59	18.82
Cameroon	4.69	17.30	16.66
Senegal	4.75	10.84	15.33
Togo	4.95	10.81	14.90
Seychelles		16.50	14.53
Gambia	1.07	1.18	13.48
Côte D'Ivoire	7.94	8.46	11.57
Kenya	2.82	9.25	10.42
Congo	5.24	8.57	10.38
Benin	3.5	12.49	10.24
UK	57.37	56.49	80.50
US		88.89	79.36

	2000 (or nearest year)	2015 (or nearest year)	2024 (or nearest year)
China	7.58	47.12	76.88
France	50.60	62.79	70.45
Brazil		48.43	60.39
India	9.94	27.06	34.42

Source: UNESCO. Sorted by 2024, higher to lower.

While the data for gross enrolment ratios in tertiary education is patchy, two features can be highlighted. First, almost universally across ~~economies in~~ countries in Africa, gross enrolment ratios in tertiary education have risen over the 25-year period. This points to a gradual shift towards more knowledge-based economies, where competitive advantage is increasingly derived from skills and advanced learning.

Second, stand out countries include Algeria, which is highest at 54.43%, Egypt at 38.04%, Mauritius at 45.78%, Morocco at 48.18%, and Tunisia at 38.12%. These countries have higher rates of gross enrolment than Bangladesh, India, Malaysia, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, while Algeria and Morocco exceed the Philippines.

Education access and retention are not only about time spent in school. They also shape whether youth can realistically move into high skilled work, build careers, and create value in new sectors. That is why the strength of higher education institutions is an important part of the youth optimism story.

But it is also important to note that countries differ greatly in post-school training and education options outside the university system, which is the next tier of education for building skills and careers.

It is also important to note the growth of private schools in African countries, amid widespread public system failures. A growing number of parents are willing to pay for a quality education, particularly with an eye on possible tertiary education in developed countries.

According to a report by the Institute of Security Studies in South Africa, African Futures (2026), enrolments have soared since the 1990s, with more than 20% of primary and secondary students in 19 Sub-Saharan countries now attending non-state facilities.

Private schools are booming across Africa, driven by surging parental demand for reliable teaching and modern facilities amid widespread public system failures. Enrolments have soared since the 1990s, with over 20% of primary and secondary students in 19 Sub-Saharan countries now attending non-state facilities.

In Equatorial Guinea, 54% of primary school students are in private schools. At 60%, Liberia has the largest proportion of secondary school students in private schools, followed closely by Mauritius (57%).

The private education boom is particularly visible in South Africa. Independent schools have doubled to over 2,300, accounting for about 10% of all schools, with several private school groups listed on the Johannesburg Stock Exchange.

On the downside, the rise of private education is fuelling greater inequality. The issue with public schools is not always the quality of education but poor outputs, resulting from limited infrastructure, sometimes low-grade teachers, overcrowded classrooms, and other challenges.

The ISS estimates that African governments spend an average of about 15% to 20% of their total national budgets on education. The African Union recommends an ambitious 20% or more of public budgets be allocated to the sector. This has been met or exceeded by top spenders like Namibia, Botswana, and South Africa.

However, this measures inputs, such as number of learners, classrooms and schools, rather than output. For example, South Africa was ranked the lowest in the world in the 2023 Progress in International Reading Literacy Study, covering 50 countries, which showed that more than 80% of Grade Four learners were unable to read for meaning in any language.

Nevertheless, the expenditure on education, and the rise of private-school networks, shows a dedication and commitment by families, business and governments to providing education, cognisant of its important role in development and progress.

Higher education and the future

One of the key drivers of youth prospects is the quality and strength of a nation's education infrastructure. This includes the performance of the university sector, which provides opportunity for advanced education with the expectation of creating sustainable employment and careers in high skilled occupations.

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The Times Higher Education Ranking measures the strength of higher education institutions globally according to criteria of education, research, industry connections and income. Institutions must meet minimum thresholds to be considered for ranking.

Note in the chart that countries ranked below 1,000 in 2021 are not given exact rankings and are recorded in a band of rankings, and in 2026 this is the case for rankings beyond 1,200.

Table 4: Times Higher Education Global University Rankings, 2026

	2026 Number of Ranked Institutions	**Best ranked**	**Best Ranked Name**	**2021 Number of Ranked Institutions**	**Best Ranked**	**Best Ranked**
South Africa	13	=164	University of Cape Town	11	=155	University of Cape Town
Algeria	28	1201-1500	University of EL Oued and Badji Mokhtar-	10	501-600	Ferhat Abbas Setif University

	2026 Number of Ranked Institutions	Best ranked	Best Ranked Name	2021 Number of Ranked Institutions	Best Ranked	Best Ranked
			Annaba universities			
Botswana	2	1001-1200	University of Botswana	1	1001+	University of Botswana
Egypt	36	601-800	American University in Cairo	21	401-500	Aswan University
Ghana	4	801-1000	University of Cape Coast	1	1001+	University of Ghana
Kenya	2	1501+	Kenyatta University	1	601-800	University of Nairobi
Libya	1	1201-1500	University of Tripoli			
Mauritius	1	1201-1500	University of Mauritius			
Morocco	12	351-400	Mohammed V1 Polytechnic University	5	801-1000	Side Mohamed Ben Abdellah University
Mozambique	1	1201-1500	Universidade Eduardo Mondlane			
Namibia	1	1501+	University of Namibia			
Nigeria	24	801-1000	University of Ibadan	6	401-500	University of Ibadan
Rwanda	1	1501+	University of Rwanda			
Senegal	1	1501+	Universite Cheikh Anta Diop de Dakar (UCAD)			

	2026 Number of Ranked Institutions	Best ranked	Best Ranked Name	2021 Number of Ranked Institutions	Best Ranked	Best Ranked
Tanzania	2	1501+	Muhimbili University of Health and Allied Sciences			
Tunisia	9	801-1000	University of Tunis El Manar	6	1001+	University of Carthage
Uganda	1	801-1000	Makerere University	1	401-500	Makerere University
Zambia	1	1501+	University of Zambia			
Zimbabwe	1	1501+	University of Zimbabwe			
Total Africa	141		Total Africa	63		
Total Institutions	2,191		Total Institutions	1,526		
Share African Institutions	6.4%		Share African Institutions	4.1%		

Source: Times Higher Education Global University Ranking 2026.

** Note: = before a ranking number indicates it is one of several institutions with the same ranking*

University performance and capability is on the rise significantly in African countries, as the numbers show above. These learning institutions are providing a strong skills base for students, and undertaking important, globally recognised research.

The table compares 2021 and 2026. Across economies in Africa in 2026, a total of 141 institutions were ranked out of 2,191 globally. The most ranked universities are found in Egypt (36), Algeria (28) and Nigeria (24), South Africa (13), and Morocco (12). Nineteen ~~economies~~ countries in Africa have globally ranked institutions, linking them to an elite group of higher learning institutions.

As a share of globally ranked institutions, Africa accounts for 6.4%, rising from 4.1% and surpassing the growth in ranked institutions globally.

South Africa has the best ranked institution, the University of Cape Town, which is ranked 164th in the world. This is higher than India's and Brazil's best ranked institutions. Morocco's best

ranked institution is ranked 351–400, and it also sits ahead of the best ranked institution in various countries.

Since 2021, the number of African institutions ranked has more than doubled from 63 to 141 institutions, although overall ranked institutions globally grew from 1,526 to 2,191.

The biggest gains were Algeria, with 28 institutions ranked for 2026 compared to 10 in 2021, Egypt with 36 up from 21, Nigeria rising from six to 24, and Morocco rising from five to 12. Thus, even within the relatively short time frame of five years, African countries have experienced a rapid rise in the number of globally recognised Institutions of Higher Education, a very positive outcome.

Sub-Saharan Africa ratings schema

A recent development by Times Higher Education Rankings has been the establishment of a university rankings schema for Sub-Saharan Africa, which encompasses resources and finance, access and fairness, student engagement, ethical leadership and Africa impact, including research citations, African research co-authorship and evidence of African cultural heritage.

Overall, for 2024, 129 African institutions were ranked across 22 countries. The largest number of ranked institutions belonged to Nigeria (41), Kenya (15), Ghana (11), South Africa (10) and Somalia (10). South Africa has four of the top 10 spots, with Rwanda in 4th place and Ghana in 5th place.

The University of Johannesburg is number one in the region thanks to particularly high performance in access and fairness, and resources and finances. Other leaders are the University of Pretoria, the University of South Africa (Unisa), the University of Global Health Equity (UGHE) in Rwanda, Landmark University in Nigeria, and Universidade Eduardo Mondlane in Mozambique.

African business schools also feature in rankings by the UK's Financial Times and QS. South Africa features prominently with five of its main business schools regularly at or near the top of the rankings. These are:

- GIBS, part of the University of Pretoria
- Henley Business School Africa
- The Graduate School of Business in Cape Town
- Wits Business School in Johannesburg; and
- Stellenbosch Business School in the Western Cape

Others are the Lagos Business School – Pan African University in Nigeria, the American University in Cairo School of Business in Egypt, and Strathmore in Kenya.

According to the QS Global MBA Rankings, Cape Town's Graduate School of Business (GSB) is rated as the best business school for a full-time MBA in the Middle East and Africa. This is followed closely by the American University Cairo in 3rd and the Wits Business School in South Africa at 7th.

The importance of this data is the fact that youth are being supported by potential access to quality higher education institutions, which are a pathway to improving their lives and accessing higher value jobs.

Increasingly, in an environment of job scarcity, there is an emphasis on technical education as well as different ways for university students to build networks that may support a career.

Take, as an example, a student in a North African country who might be the first in her family to attend university. Her first year is a shock. The content is demanding, the cost of transport is high, and the promise of a job after graduation feels uncertain. What changes her outlook is an internship programme tied to industry connections, a supervisor who guides her through research basics, and a clear route into work that exists locally.

The journey is still hard, but institutions that deepen research and strengthen industry links make it easier for youth to picture a future that does not depend on leaving their home countries. That is how university strength becomes a practical optimism indicator.

Work, learning, and the NEET story

Youth not in employment, education or training (NEET) is a complex story with many dimensions but it is important to understand it to complete the labour market story.

At the outset, as can be seen from the table below, the numbers show that most youth are in some form of employment, education or training. This is a positive development. It is important to reframe the narrative in an optimistic way to show that most youth are engaged in the labour market.

For example, close to 90% of youth in Burundi are engaged in employment, education and training, and in fact Burundi has a lower NEET than the US, while most of the countries listed in the table have NEET rates below Brazil, and all are below India.

In addition, 13 countries out of the 20 listed here have shown decreases in NEET over the past 10 years.

Table 5: Share of Youth NEET (ILO-modelled estimates)

	2015	**2025**	**Change 2015-2025**
Burundi	5.4	12.5	increase
Tanzania	14.6	12.9	decrease
Togo	10.8	13.2	increase
Nigeria	15.2	13.4	decrease
Uganda	17.4	13.7	decrease
Guinea Bissau	13.6	13.9	increase
Liberia	12.9	14.4	Increase
Benin	16.2	15.3	decrease
Niger	25	16	decrease
Ethiopia	12.2	17.4	increase

	2015	2025	Change 2015-2025
Kenya	14.6	19.1	increase
Côte D'Ivoire	24.8	19.2	decrease
Malawi	21.4	19.8	decrease
Algeria	21.2	20.1	decrease
Mauritius	20.4	20.1	decrease
Angola	29.1	21.4	decrease
Comoros	26.4	21.4	decrease
Mozambique	21.3	21.9	increase
Djibouti	23	22.6	decrease
Tunisia	29.9	22.7	decrease
USA	12.4	11.2	decrease
UK	12.9	12.7	decrease
China	12.8	11.7	decrease
Brazil	22.1	20.5	decrease
France	14	10.5	decrease
India	27.9	23.6	decrease

Source: ILO. Sorted by 2025 data.

However, if NEET is in evidence, it doesn't mean young people are inactive. Many engage in side hustles, informal employment, and other forms of work that can be difficult to capture. Some forms of work escape the statistical net.

A recent study of NEET in Sub-Saharan found issue with the idea that NEET equates to inactivity. Many young people earn livelihoods through street vending, small trading, gig work, casual agricultural work, motorcycle taxi work, car and other repairs, helping a family business, and helping to find customers for other businesses.[19]

According to the Mastercard Foundation, "Contrary to conventional beliefs, young Africans work more than their peers on other continents. About 57% or 304 million youth In Africa are

[19] See Cieslek K, Barford A & Young VB, Young People not in Employment, Education or Training in Sub-Saharan Africa: Sustainable Development Target 8.6 missed and reset, Journal of Youth Studies, 25-8, 2021. See also Mastercard Foundation Africa Youth Employment Outlook 2026 and ILO data.

estimated to be working as of 2025, compared with 48% in the rest of the world". However, 90% of young people work in informal jobs.[20]

A further layer of the story is unpaid and socially oriented work that holds households and communities together. There is a vast array of youth, mostly female, who undertake domestic, unpaid work including cooking, cleaning, household chores and child rearing.

Beyond this, youth who fall into NEET categories engage in volunteering, charity work, care work, church group participation and activities, and helping to run savings groups and co-operatives. Youth may also participate in informal training, including informal apprenticeships, skills learned from relatives, NGO-driven short courses and online self learning, which may not be captured in the data.

A young man in a coastal economy might finish school and fail twice to secure formal work. He starts as an assistant in a repair shop, unpaid at first, then paid per task. His learning is real, but invisible to official classifications. He picks up skills, builds reputation, and later begins taking small jobs on his own, then trains a cousin.

The constraint is not the effort being made. It is the gap between skills and capital, and the difficulty of turning informal progress into stable earnings. That journey complements the NEET figures because it explains why participation can be higher than the headline suggests, while also showing the policy challenge of improving pathways from informal learning into reliable work.

Commonwealth Global Youth Index

The Commonwealth Global Youth Index provides a multifaceted, comprehensive picture of youth development in 183 countries, including the policy support given to youth.

The Youth Development Index tracks progress on the Sustainable Development Goals associated with youth development. It focuses on a core set of indicators that experts have shown influences youth development.

It considers metrics such as:

- Youth mortality, drug abuse and mental health
- Five or more years experiencing the internet in the 15-2- year-old age group
- Literacy and school completion rates among youth
- Underemployment
- Ownership of a financial account among 15-24-year-olds and those not in employment,
- education or training
- Youth population considered to be poor
- Gender parity in literacy and NEET
- Youth policy, recognition for helping to improve the city or area where they live and voicing an opinion to an official, and
- Conflict and terrorism, risk of humanitarian crisis, and youth interpersonal violence

Together these variables are aggregated into five main pillars: Education, Employment and Opportunity, Equality and Inclusion, Health and Well-Being, Peace and Security, and Political and Civic Participation. These pillars are then turned into an overall ranking.

[20] Master Card Foundation, Youth Employment Outlook 2026.

The following table shows the overall rankings for the top 20 African nations out of 183 countries, and other benchmark countries. Scores, out of one, are given in brackets with the higher score the better. African countries are ranked in descending order, from best to worst.

Table 6: Commonwealth Global Youth Index 2023 (out of 183 countries)

	Overall rank	**Score (out of 1)**
Tunisia	63	(.768)
Mauritius	69	(.761)
Morocco	82	(.750)
Libya	86	(.745)
Cabo Verde	92	(.738)
Sâo Tomé and Principe	99	(.733)
Egypt	99	(.733)
Algeria	102	(.728)
Seychelles	102	(.728)
Ghana	105	(.721)
Gabon	112	(.714)
Comoros	119	(.703)
Gambia	125	(.697)
Namibia	126	(.696)
Senegal	127	(.694)
Mauritania	130	(.692)
Togo	132	(.690)
Equatorial Guinea	135	(.682)
Djibouti	140	(.676)
South Africa	141	(.675)
France	37	(.800)

	Overall rank	Score (out of 1)
UK	49	(.790)
China	69	(.761)
USA	76	(.757)
India	121	(.700)
Brazil	130	(.692)

Source: Commonwealth Global Youth Index

The data shows that by international standards, African countries perform well on youth outcomes. For example, seven African countries are placed overall in the top 100 in the world, out of 183 countries. These countries are Tunisia, Mauritius, Morocco, Libya, Cabo Verde, Sâo Tomé and Principe, and Egypt. A further three countries sit just outside the top 100 — Algeria, Seychelles and Ghana.

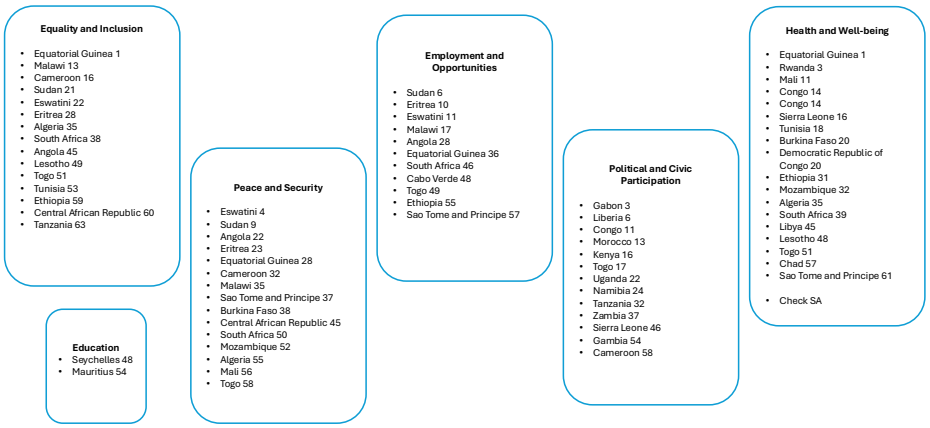
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Tunisia, the best placed country in this set, is ranked higher than China, USA, Brazil, and India from the benchmark set of nations. A similar pattern is found for Mauritius. What is particularly noteworthy is the better performance of some African countries compared to the US despite having significantly lower per capita incomes.

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When the index is unpacked, it shows where youth outcomes are strongest, as reflected in the following diagram. This shows African countries in the top one-third of the rankings according to each pillar.

Chart 1: Performance on Youth Outcomes



Source: Commonwealth Youth Index

It should be noted that because this index has some very specific and narrow criteria and metrics, its outcomes should not be read as broader commentary on economic and social conditions in these countries. For example, equity and inclusion refers to very specific criteria mainly on gender equality, rather than broader measures of inclusion, democracy, rights, governance and freedom.

On equality and inclusion, 15 ~~nations~~ countries are in the top one third of the rankings on this pillar. It is striking is that Equatorial Guinea is rated first in the world, Malawi 13th, Cameroon 16th and Eswatini 22nd. These countries have deep levels of poverty and poor governance, which raises questions about the way this is measured.

The pillar measures economic marginalisation (population percentage of youth classified as extremely poor or moderately poor); gender parity in safety and security; gender parity in NEET; and early marriage.

On education, island nations have fared well on the index. Seychelles, in 48th place, sits in the top one third of all countries in the table and is one of only two African countries to score well. The other is Mauritius in 54th place. Education on the index measures number of years using the internet by people aged 15 to 29, literacy rate; and lower secondary completion rates.

In general, across the globe, peace and security is an area of concern. However, in the index, several economies in Africa rank strongly, mirroring the data in the Peace chapter. Fifteen countries are in the top third. The best placed are Eswatini, Sudan and Angola in 4th, 9th and 22nd place respectively.

It is worth reminding that the index under examination is from 2023, and a serious conflict started up in Sudan in that year so that would not form part of the research into the index used in this volume. But this also highlights that these indices reflect a certain period of time. Increasingly, the changes are not dramatic but there can still be examples of that.

Peace and Security is measured by conflict and terrorism (years of life lost); risk of humanitarian crisis; composite measure for domestic peace and safety and security; and years of life lost from interpersonal violence, ages 15-29.

On employment and opportunity, 11 countries are ranked in the top one third. Leading the field are Sudan 6th, Eritrea 10th and Eswatini 11th.

The employment and opportunity pillar is measured by respondents who report having an account at a bank or financial institution, adolescent fertility rates, NEET, and underemployment.

The specific criteria explain why the youth and employment results appear to differ markedly from overall levels of economic development in these countries.

In political and civic participation, Gabon (ranked third), Liberia (sixth) and Congo (11th) are among the 13 countries in the top one third of rankings. In these nations, youth appear to be engaged with political processes and civic life in ways that influence how societies adapt and how futures are negotiated. Political and civic participation is reflected by recognition for community improvement, voiced opinion to an official, volunteer time, and youth policy score.

This matters for optimism because civic participation is not only about voting or protest. In many places, it is about problem-solving, local advocacy, and negotiating access to services.

The usual narrative is that health and well-being lags badly in countries in Africa. The index challenges that assumption.

Equatorial Guinea is first in the world in terms of youth health indicators, Rwanda is third followed by Mali 11th and South Africa 14th. There are 17 African countries ranked in the top one-third of all countries.

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This set of rankings signals a robust youth base in a range of economies in Africa, and it suggests that progress on youth wellbeing can be more uneven and more surprising than the common story allows. Health and well-being indicators for 15 to 29-year-olds cover alcohol disorders and drug abuse, HIV rates, mental health' mortality rates, tobacco consumption, and self harm.

Communities coming together

Commented [dg45]: These are little story clips of imagined scenarios to add colour, as noted earlier. Need to be reflected slightly differently in the layout.

A youth group in a secondary town might begin by organising around something small, such as better lighting on a road where people are robbed on the way home. Their first meeting fails because the format feels like a lecture and nobody returns.

They try again, this time using short sessions, clearer roles, and a simple record of what the local council promised and when. It takes months, not days, and some doors stay closed, yet eventually a small win arrives and builds momentum. This reflects a steady civic persistence that is the lived version of what strong participation scores can point to.

Shaping outcomes

Improvements in youth performance are not a coincidence. They are informed by policies and strategies at pan-African and national levels. The African Union has a commitment to youth development through its African Youth Chapter and the Youth Decade Plan of Action. The action plan has several key priorities, namely education and skills development; youth employment and entrepreneurship; governance, peace and security; youth health and sexual reproductive health rights; and agriculture, climate change and the environment.

International players are also involved. The AU/ILO Youth Employment Strategy is a collaboration between young people, governments, and social institutions that aims to provide employment and training for young people, taking a holistic approach.

It has five strategic areas, namely structural transformation and sectoral approaches, to transition from low to high productivity sectors; economic integration to leverage the continent's free trade agenda; a just transition to build inclusive, green and digital economies; labour market policies aimed at decent work and security while protecting vulnerable youth; and skills development and economic empowerment.

The Youth for Peace Programme is part of the AU Youth Charter and seeks to effectively engage, involve, and promote peace through inclusive collaboration with young people. This aims to change the perception that young people can cause trouble and present problems in Africa and reshaping the narrative that they are partners for peace.

Individual countries also focus on youth development. South Africa's National Development Plan to 2030 calls for a youth lens across policies to expand opportunities for young people. This involves better health and food security, better health care, better education to meet the demands for higher skill levels, life skills and entrepreneurship training, easier labour market entry, and labour mobility.

It also includes student allowances for families of poorer people, work placement schemes, training vouchers for job seekers, graduate recruitment initiatives into the public sector, and expanding the role of state-owned enterprises in training artisans and technical professionals.[21]

Youth moving Africa forward

This chapter has argued that youth in African countries are not simply a demographic statistic. They are one of the most practical indicators of optimism because they show, early and clearly, if societies are expanding capability, widening opportunity, and building the conditions for sustained growth.

Through their vibrant youth populations, African countries have every reason to be optimistic about the future. Young people are not untouched by hardship, but they come with energy, ideas and hope. Improving education systems is critical to harnessing this energy for good and building confidence in young people.

As this chapter has outlined, the youth are technologically savvy, likely to start businesses, drivers of social and environmental change and increasingly engaging in the political process. In addition, according to Afrobarometer and the Ichikowitz Family Foundation, youth are positive

[21] South African Government, National Development Plan 2030, Website. https://www.gov.za/sites/default/files/gcis_document/201409/ndp-2030-our-future-make-it-workr.pdf

about their futures and their countries' futures. This is a good starting point to build a more progressive continent.

The demographic statistics highlight why the youth is such a powerful indicator of optimism. With 60% of the population in Sub-Saharan Africa under the age of 25, and 70% under 30, the continent's future weight in the global population is already visible. By 2050, one in three young people globally will be African.

When governments in Africa invest wisely in the future, the payoff is not marginal. It can shift national trajectories.

Projections that per capita real incomes could increase four-fold by 2050, and that favourable age structures could contribute 11%–15% of GDP growth by 2030, should be read as a statement about possibility. They capture what can happen when systems enable young people to learn, work, and participate in ways that compound over time.

This chapter shows that education levels are on the rise in countries in Africa, paving the way for more engagement with skilled, better paying and more secure jobs. Universities are paving the way for the jobs of the present and the future.

Even NEET has an upside. It is easy to treat it as a headline of exclusion. The more useful interpretation, backed by observations and examples, is that most young people are participating in some type of work, learning, or training, with improvements showing over a decade.

At the same time, the chapter has emphasised why participation should be understood with care.

In economies where informal work is widespread, some youth activity is productive yet statistically hard to capture. This does not weaken the conclusions reached about reasons to be optimistic. It refines them. Optimism about youth is visible not only in formal jobs, but also in the ways young people adapt, learn informally, and keep households and micro-economies functioning.

The task for policymakers and business is to convert that energy into stability, progression, and higher productivity livelihoods.

The tables in this chapter strengthen that argument by showing where progress is already measurable. While noting the limitation of how it has measured some of the information, the Commonwealth Youth Index challenges the simplistic story that youth outcomes in countries in Africa are uniformly weak. Seven African countries sit inside the top 100 out of 183, and several countries perform strongly across specific pillars.

Taken together, the evidence demonstrates that youth in economies in Africa are a signal of forward motion because the data shows both rising capability and persistent belief. The demographic dividend is not automatic, and the risks of job scarcity, inequality, and weak governance remain real. Youth outcomes reveal whether societies are getting the fundamentals right. Where completion rates rise, where participation expands, where universities strengthen, and where young people retain confidence in the possibility of improvement, optimism becomes measurable trend.

If youth is the strongest indicator of optimism, then youth-centred investments are also the most reliable route to sustaining it.

Countries in Africa that want to convert demographic scale into durable prosperity will need to deepen education quality and delivery, build smoother pathways from school to work, recognise and upgrade informal livelihoods rather than ignoring them, expand vocational and apprenticeship systems, and keep improving the institutions that shape trust and participation.

The reward is not only better youth outcomes but stronger economies, more resilient societies, and a continent whose largest cohort is not treated as a problem to be managed, but as the core asset that makes long-term progress achievable.

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Chapter Seven: ICT and Africa

The Future has Arrived

Africa is much more connected than is commonly understood and its connectedness is a cause for optimism. It is a core capability of the present and the future.

One of the most successful trends to come out of Africa in its history has been the mobile phone explosion. In a relatively short time, mobile telephony has changed the way the continent works and how its people do things.

Since the pioneering days of the early 1990s when companies such as MTN and Vodacom in South Africa, Telecel in the Democratic Republic of Congo and Celtel in East Africa launched operations, Africa in 2026 had more than 500 million individual mobile subscribers across the continent, with the number doubling when including those with additional subscriptions.

The technology has changed peoples' lives. Even those on meagre incomes made sacrifices in order to own a phone and be able to connect for pleasure and business. Phones have, since they first became available, become a priority spend for most Africans. The pay-as-you-go model rolled out in the mid 1990s was the main catalyst for explosive growth across the continent by eliminating the need for strict credit checks and expensive monthly contracts.

The mobile revolution continues as operators roll out diversified models, moving into new areas such as mobile money, where they have taken on established banks by offering agile digital solutions for African consumers. Some 70% of global mobile money accounts are in Sub Saharan Africa. Platforms such as M-PESA in East Africa are globally recognised.

Mobile money is not just a product. It's an everyday system that reduces friction in trade and helps people to manage risk. What is distinctive and cause for optimism in the African context is that connectivity is often designed around real-life constraints and daily needs.

Many systems are built to work for people who may not have formal addresses, bank branches nearby, or predictable cash flows. In those conditions, the phone becomes more than a device. It becomes a wallet, a marketplace, a learning platform, and a service access point. That is why connectivity is not simply "useful". It is foundational.

Apart from money transactions, mobile phone and internet usage allows business to be conducted more easily and gives people the ability to create new businesses online, build personal and professional networks, and enable access to government e-services.

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Through its investments in and uptake of ICT, the continent ~~Africa~~ is well placed to take advantage of the rapidly evolving digital economy, which is radically re-defining the way businesses develop and operate.

Africa's youthful population holds the key to the rapid uptake and diffusion of ICT in African countries. Youth adopt technologies at higher rates than other age groups and are active in technology hubs and accelerators on the continent, building apps and other products aimed specifically at African consumers and businesses and their particular realities.

~~There is much cause for optimism about the economy wide benefits of ICT.~~

According to GMSA, the mobile economy's contribution to the region is expected to increase from $240 billion in 2025 to $290 billion by 2030, while in 2025, mobile technologies and services accounted for almost 8% of the region's GDP and supported around 13 million jobs. Further, mobile technologies and associated services in Africa accounted for $4 billion in public revenues in 2025.[22]

This chapter argues three things.

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First, African countries are increasingly connected by technology in distinctive ways that fit local realities. Mobile-first systems, digital finance that works in everyday life, and practical applications that reach informal and small business contexts are all part of this story.

Second, the data shows that progress is broad-based. It is not limited to a handful of "usual suspects". Across multiple indices, African countries have improved over the last decade, and many have moved into higher categories of readiness and performance.

Third, these improvements matter because they strengthen capability. Capability is a useful lens for optimism. It signals that households, firms, and governments have more tools, more options, and more capabilities than before.

The tables in this chapter are the evidence that connectivity gains are real, uneven in interesting ways, and increasingly linked to outcomes such as digital economic growth and service delivery.

Formalising the informal

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A small tailoring business gets its customers through word-of-mouth referrals and walk-in customers. It is agile, but income is unpredictable. Once the owner gets reliable mobile data, she begins posting her work, taking orders through messaging, and receiving payments digitally. She keeps the flexibility of informal trade while gaining the predictability of a wider market and easier transactions. Over time, she starts tracking orders and expenses because the digital trail makes it simpler.

Seeds of information

A small-scale farmer used to rely on neighbours and local traders for price information. That meant selling when prices were low and buying inputs late. With a basic smartphone and more reliable connectivity, she begins to check prices and coordinate with other farmers before selling. She also receives payments digitally, which reduces risk and makes it easier to plan. Her productivity does not change overnight, but her bargaining position improves. Connectivity becomes part of her production system.

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[22] GSMA, The Mobile Economy Africa 2026.

Connectivity: Reasons for optimism

This section draws on several datasets that measure different dimensions of connectivity. Each table strengthens a specific part of the chapter's argument. The aim is not to celebrate rankings, but to interpret what improvements and strengths mean for real capability in African countries.

The GSMA Mobile Connectivity Index 2025 comprises four enablers: infrastructure, affordability, consumer readiness, and content and services. It is not a ranking as such, but the data reflects relative scores from zero to 100. All African countries bar one improved in overall scores between 2014–2024.

The description "improved in overall score" is easy to skim past, but it is a clear signal that there is much to be optimistic about. It suggests that the enabling environment has strengthened across most countries, even where media headlines may focus on crisis or hardship.

Improvement in this index is not only about more towers or more devices. It also reflects affordability, readiness, and the ability of more people to actually tap into connectivity for useful services. In other words, it captures whether connectivity is becoming usable, not just available.

While, as noted above, all African countries in the table have improved in scores since 2014, some have done so dramatically. The fastest growth has occurred in Botswana, Libya, Tunisia, Eswatini, Ghana, Algeria, Cabo Verde, Côte D'Ivoire and Morocco. This indicates rapid digital transformation built off investments and capabilities in mobile broadband, digital services, fin tech adoption and infrastructure development.

Such is the swift progress that all countries have made progress from one category to other, indicating dynamism of African nations' development and usage of ICT.

Leaders are countries with score above 80, Advanced score over 65, Transitioners score above 50, Emerging score above 35, and Discoverers score below 35.

Egypt, Tunisia, Libya, and Morocco have moved very significantly over the 10- year period, jumping from the Emerging to the Advanced category. Côte D'Ivoire and Eswatini have jumped over the Emerging Category to go from Discoverer to Transitioner. These jumps are particularly meaningful. They suggest step-change improvements rather than slow incremental gains. This is a reason for significant optimism.

Several countries have moved into the same development level as Brazil and India, both major emerging economies. Seven African countries are in the Advanced category: Seychelles; Mauritius; South Africa; Libya; Tunisia; Egypt, and Morocco. This is the second top category of classifications.

There is a significant group of mid-tier countries, those in the Transitioner category. These are Botswana, Cabo Verde, Algeria, Ghana, Eswatini, Kenya, Namibia, Gabon, Nigeria, Rwanda, Senegal, and Côte D'Ivoire. These are the economies where scaling can take place quickly through digital entrepreneurship, growth in e-commerce and digital services, among other things.

All countries in the table, except Cameroon, have scores in the top 50, meaning that they are in the top half of the countries in the world. This matters because they show breadth. There are island states, economies in North Africa and Southern Africa, as well as fast-growing West and East African markets. This mix signals that connectivity progress is not confined to a single sub-region or model. It is playing out in different contexts.

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Three countries — Seychelles, Mauritius and South Africa — have scores exceeding India in 2024, pointing to rapid progress on the continent. Moreover, over time the gap between African nations and the leaders has been shrinking, indicating that catch up to the best is under way

TABLE 1: Mobile Connectivity Index scores - 2014 versus 2024

Country	2024 Score	2014 Score	Classification 2024	Classification 2014
Seychelles	73.98	54.90 19	Advanced	Transitioner
Mauritius	72.96	55.18 17	Advanced	Transitioner
South Africa	71.68	59.88 12	Advanced	Transitioner
Libya	67.09	42.16 25	Advanced	Emerging
Tunisia	66.64	43.37 23	Advanced	Emerging
Egypt	65.85	47.38 18	Advanced	Emerging
Morocco	65.25	44.30 21	Advanced	Emerging
Botswana	64.44	37.96 27	Transitioner	Emerging
Cabo Verde	60.05	37.84 23	Transitioner	Emerging
Algeria	57.89	36.92 21	Transitioner	Emerging
Ghana	57.59	35.20 22	Transitioner	Emerging
Eswatini	57.15	32.01 25	Transitioner	Discoverer
Kenya	56.77	36.51 20	Transitioner	Emerging
Namibia	56.29	42.16 14	Transitioner	Emerging
Gabon	55.19	36.89 19	Transitioner	Emerging
Nigeria	53.41	37.20 16	Transitioner	Emerging
Rwanda	52.55	36.06 16	Transitioner	Emerging
Senegal	51.37	32.64 19	Transitioner	Discoverer
Côte D'Ivoire	50.57	28.94 22	Transitioner	Discoverer
Cameroon	48.96	32.14 16	Emerging	Discoverer
United Kingdom	91.41	79.38	Leader	Advanced
US	91.33	78.93	Leader	Advanced

France	89.59	72.55	Leader	Advanced
China	83.48	64.82	Leader	Transitioner
Brazil	77.12	59.36	Advanced	Transitioner
India	69.16	44.02	Advanced	Emerging

Source: GSMA. Scores out of 100, sorted by 2024 data.

Prices are an important signal of mobile phone affordability. Data from the International Telecommunications Union, based on a representative bundle of mobile telephony services, shows that between 2018 and 2024 prices in all but two African nations fell, in some cases dramatically. The price for a voice-data package in the countries below over the six-year period shows the changes.

- Botswana: $91.7 to $15.5
- Angola: from $35.9 to $4.8
- Cabo Verde: $56.5 to $6.8
- Guinea Bissau: $38.2 to $8.2
- Seychelles: $50.8 to $11.7
- Chad from $41.9 to $13.1

In some countries, prices for a similar package are below all the benchmark countries of Brazil, China, France, India, the US and the UK.

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The dramatic fall in prices is driven by a reduction in smart phone prices in particular, due to lower production costs in Asia, but also because of increased competition, technological advances, and deliberate efforts to expand digital access.

This is a game changer for the African population, allowing previously underserved customers to become mainstream users of the technology, with consequent positive impacts for networking, collaboration, doing business, and having access to essential services. This is a good reason for a healthy dose of optimism.

Building locally, selling globally

A young developer in a city with improving connectivity joins an ICT hub. At first, she is learning and doing small tasks. As affordability improves and services become more usable, she begins collaborating remotely and selling digital services beyond her country.

The turning point is not that she becomes "more talented". It is that connectivity makes it realistic to compete and deliver from where she is. That is the deeper optimism. Opportunity becomes less tied to geography.

Network readiness

The Network Readiness Index 2025, a ranking of 127 countries, has an overall rank and rankings for its components: technology, people, governance and impact.

“Technology” compromises three dimensions: access to ICT covering availability and affordability; content, which is the generation and deployment of digital technologies and locally developed relevant content; and the exposure to, and uptake of, future technologies including AI, the Internet of Things and investment in nascent technologies.

“People” consists of individual and business ICT usage and its deployment by the public sector for service delivery and data management. “Governance” covers trust (security and reliability of digital environments) and reputation (public policy, regulatory frameworks and inclusion).

“Impact” is based on: the economic effects of digital integration; quality of life (social impacts and societal well-being); and the Sustainable Development Goals (progress towards health, education, gender and environmental sustainability).

Some African nations perform better on network readiness than would be expected given their income levels. According to the Network Readiness Index Report, this includes Rwanda, Tanzania, Malawi, Kenya and Senegal, reflecting the impact of digital strategies and policies, scale of ICT application and institutional capacity. This is a reason for real optimism.

The top African nations are Mauritius, South Africa, Morocco, and Kenya. Mauritius, at number 58, is in the top 50% of ranked nations and it is closing in on Brazil of the comparator set of countries

Table 2: Network Readiness Index 2025 (out of 127 countries)

	NRI Rank	**Technology Rank and score**	**People Rank and Score**	**Governance Rank and Score**	**Impact Rank and Score**
Mauritius	58 (51.79)	76 (40.59)	48 (45.65)	59 (62.46)	45 (58.47)
South Africa	69 (47.94)	66 (43.41)	72 (39.04)	55 (64.54)	100 (44.77)
Morocco	73 (46.38)	47 (47.80)	80 (37.42)	75 (55.53)	99 (44.78)
Kenya	77 (45.77)	70 (42.09)	90 (34.26)	66 (60.02)	92 (46.70)
Ghana	85 (43.05)	87 (35.59)	82 (36.63)	74 (55.99)	101 (43.99)
Rwanda	87 (42.82)	86 (35.70)	92 (33.91)	72 (56.64)	97 (45.02)
Egypt	88 (42.70)	79 (39.81)	87 (34.84)	98 (48.71)	89 (4.42)
Cabo Verde	91 (41.99)	113 (25.08)	64 (41.56)	88 (51.50)	83 (4.82)
Tunisia	96 (39.29)	68 (42.50)	84 (36.18)	105 (42.11)	117 (36.38)
Tanzania	97 (39.18)	100 (30.73)	96 (31.99)	91 (50.65)	103 (43.33)

	NRI Rank	Technology Rank and score	People Rank and Score	Governance Rank and Score	Impact Rank and Score
Senegal	98 (39.03)	90 (34.63)	118 (23.21)	84 (52.18)	95 (46.08)
Côte D'Ivoire	100 (38.27)	94 (33.46)	105 (29.47)	103 (43.30)	91 (46.84)
Nigeria	103 (36.81)	96 (31.82)	114 (26.47)	99 (48.03)	107 (40.90)
Algeria	109 (35.27)	84 (37.23)	99 (31.06)	119 (32.93)	110 (39.85)
Benin	110 (34.67)	115 (23.93)	117 (23.98)	85 (51.79)	111 (38.97)
Botswana	111 (34.40)	114 (24.53)	109 (27.21)	95 (49.62)	118 (36.24)
Uganda	112 (34.29)	111 (27.15)	116 (24.82)	101 (46.31)	113 (38.86)
Zambia	113 (33.95)	119 (17.71)	88 (34.78)	100 (47.50)	119 (35.83)
Namibia	114 (33.47)	109 (27.42)	106 (27.93)	108 (39.61)	112 (38.92)
Cameroon	115 (32.19)	108 (27.49)	113 (26.69)	115 (35.86)	116 (38.72)
Brazil	51 (53.64)	53 (45.99)	52 (44.28)	41 (70.85)	63 (53.46)
China	24 (65.74)	12 (64.37)	6 (67.83)	50 (66.60)	30 (64.15)
France	19 (68.16)	15 (61.64)	16 (59.17)	21 (81.99)	21 (69.86)
India	45 (54.43)	33 (53.07)	34 (48.81)	73 (56.62)	42 (59.21)
UK	8 (73.85)	7 (67.74)	5 (67.97)	13 (84.62)	11 (75.07)
US	1 (79.13)	1 (82.47)	1 (76.16)	9 (86.48)	16 (71.42)

Source: Portulans Institute Network Readiness Index. Scores in brackets.

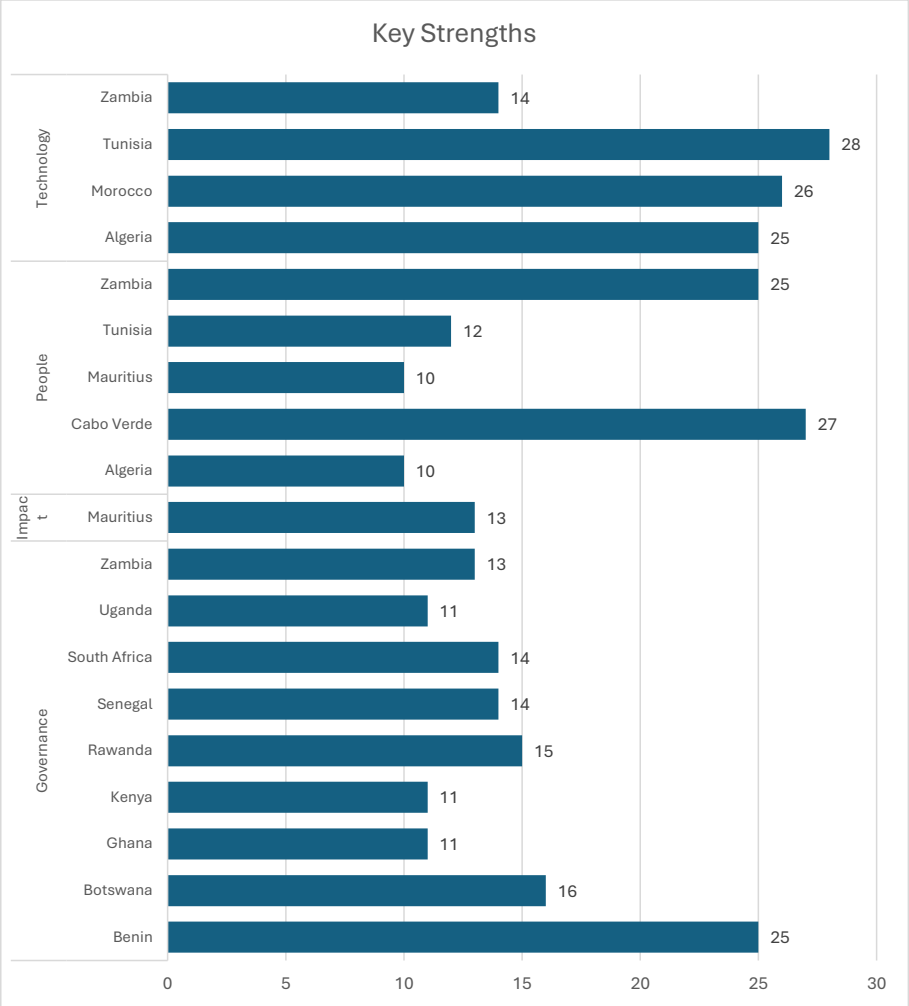
These rankings matter, but the deeper story is in the pillars. We define stand-out pillars as those in which countries rank 10 places or better in these areas than in their overall rankings. This means that there are concentrated strengths in these countries.

Some countries are strongest in governance, which signals institutional readiness. Others stand out in people, which points to skills and adoption. Others perform in terms of impact, meaning connectivity is translating into economic and quality-of-life outcomes. Optimism, here, is not about everyone doing the same thing. It is about many countries building strength in at least one enabling pillar that can be deepened over time.

As the diagram below shows, Tunisia is ranked 28 places higher in the Technology pillar than its overall ranking in the index. Cabo Verde is ranked 27 places higher in the People pillar than in its overall ranking.

Other examples include Morocco and Algeria (Technology); Zambia (People); Mauritius (Impact); and Benin (Governance).

The Governance pillar has the most African countries represented in the area of key strengths.



Source: Portulans Institute Network Readiness Index 2025. Author adaptation.

This list shows multiple pathways to digital progress and as such, it is crucial to understanding why there is optimism about Africa. While countries may not stand out in the overall rankings, many have growing areas of real strength that matter for nation building but also provide a platform for overall improvement of performance on global indices.

The internet of things

Table 3 (below) shows that in 2024, the best performing African nations were Morocco, Seychelles and Libya, each with internet usage over 80% and as high as 91.2 % in the case of Morocco, a score that indicates almost universal internet usage and exceeds that of France.

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Morocco and Seychelles outperform Brazil while 10 African nations exceed India's performance.

These comparisons strengthen the case for optimism in a specific way. They show that some African countries are not simply improving from low baselines. They are reaching high absolute levels of internet use that compare well with major economies.

That kind of penetration changes what is possible for education, commerce, media, public service delivery, and entrepreneurship. It also signals scale. When a high proportion of the population is online, digital products and services can reach viability faster.

Using statistics from the International Telecommunication Union, the table shows the change in the number of individuals using the internet between 2018 and 2024, or nearest.

We define growth of more than 25% as stellar; strong as 16–24%; good from 5–15%; solid from 0–4%; and weak as negative.

The first thing to note is that all African countries in the table have experienced growth over the five-year period. It indicates broad adoption rather than isolated progress. It also suggests a widening base for digital services and markets.

There is cause for optimism as the data shows that in just five years, the growth in internet usage has exploded in some countries.

Algeria, Morocco, Libya, Egypt, Ghana and Equatorial Guinea are in the "stellar" growth category. South Africa, Seychelles, Namibia, Eswatini, Senegal, Sâo Tomé and Principe, and The Gambia are in the "strong" category.

Tunisia, Cabo Verde, Mauritius, Gabon, Djibouti, Botswana, and Lesotho fall into the "good" category. There are no simply solid or weak growth rates among countries listed.

This distribution is important because it shows both acceleration and consolidation. Stellar and strong growth indicates fast catch-up. Good and solid growth indicates steady deepening. Together, they suggest that connectivity is becoming part of everyday life, which is exactly what enables large-scale transformation.

Table 3: Individual Internet Usage - 2018 and 2024

	2018	**2024**
Morocco	64.8	91.2
Seychelles	69.2	87.8
Libya	47.5	82.0
South Africa	62.4	78.4
Algeria	49	77.4

	2018	2024
Tunisia	64.2	76.5
Cabo Verde	59.5	74.7
Egypt	46.9	74.6
Mauritius	58.6	73.3
Ghana	43	72.2
Gabon	55.4	68.7
Djibouti	57.1	65.3
Namibia	42.8	64.9
Eswatini	39.4	63.4
Equatorial Guinea	29.4	63.3
Senegal	35.3	60.1
Sâo Tomé and Principe	38	59.1
Botswana	46.1	57.5
Lesotho	40.8	51.8
The Gambia	28.3	49.5
UK	90.7	95.5
United States	88.5	94.7
China	65.4	91.6
France	82	88.7
Brazil	70.4	84.5
India	20.1	70

Source: ITU, sorted by 2024 data.

Reaching people, not just places

A public health team wants to reach a dispersed population quickly. In the past, they relied on posters and sporadic community meetings. As internet use grows and mobile access becomes

widespread, they deliver targeted information through digital channels and receive feedback faster. The real success is about reach and responsiveness. Connectivity turns a slow process into a faster loop between citizens and services.

E-government and institutional capability

Governments are key players in ICT, setting the framework for policy, providing infrastructure, procuring goods and services, and delivering services online. An index of e-government comprises e-participation, online services, human capital and telecommunications infrastructure.

Six African countries are inside the top 100 in 2024 out of 193 countries in the E-Government Index.

Best placed is South Africa at number 40, Mauritius at 76 and Tunisia at 87, followed by Morocco, Seychelles, and Egypt. In 2014, South Africa was ranked 93, showing a dramatic improvement to 40, and Mauritius was at 76.

This is one of the clearest "optimism through capability" signals in the chapter. E-government performance is about more than technology. It reflects coordination, delivery, skills, and a state's ability to operationalise digital systems.

South Africa's dramatic shift suggests a significant strengthening of digital governance over a decade. The ranking places it above Brazil at 50 and well above India at 97.

The point of the comparisons in this chapter is not to claim superiority in every dimension, but to highlight how competitive many African countries are in specific areas. This, along with many other success stories in this volume, aims to counter the pervasive negative perceptions about Africa that are embedded in narratives about the continent.

Several urban centres scored well on the E-government index, showing a slow but steady move towards smart cities. Out of 193 covered by the index, those that stood out in Africa included Cairo and Casablanca in Egypt, ranked at 86, Dar es Salaam (Tanzania) 99, Kigali (Rwanda) 55, Nairobi (Kenya) 58, Port Louis (Mauritius) 97, and Tunis (Tunisia) 89.

Cairo, Morocco, Dar es Salaam, Kigali and Nairobi all performed better on the specific e-government index than their countries.

City performance matters because urban areas are often the place where digital services and infrastructure scale first, refining models that can be replicated elsewhere and supporting national planning and policy alignment.

When cities outperform national averages, it suggests a diffusion pathway. Improvements can spread outward over time through learning, replication, and national policy alignment.

These component strengths show something important. Many countries are not building everything at once. They are building key pillars that can unlock further progress. Strong telecommunications infrastructure supports broader digital growth. Strong online services signal that citizens and businesses can interact with government more efficiently. Strong e-participation suggests movement towards more inclusive digital civic space.

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Commented [MM51]: I think we should unpack this a little more and to show why its important… is it about a better functioning govt? the fact access becomes easier for citizens etc. I think it needa a little more before jumping to the data

Commented [MM52]: What does this mean? Let us simplify and ensure things are accessible - this should be easy reading

Connecting for the future

African countries are placing a great deal of emphasis on ICT policy frameworks with longer-term planning taking place as governments try to keep up with the rapid pace of change driven by technology.

The African Union has in place its Digital Transformation Strategy for Africa 2020–2030. This focuses on infrastructure, capacity building, private sector investment, and digital innovation.

This is important for optimism because it signals coordination and intent. When the continent sets a shared direction on digital transformation, it becomes easier to build regional interoperability, attract investment, and share lessons across countries.

Digital Ethiopia is the country's vision to 2030. This envisages "a digitally empowered Ethiopia where innovation reflects local identity, inclusion is intentional and technology serves national priorities".

It is anchored by four main objectives: empowering people and institutions; accelerating inclusive digital economic growth; achieving universal digital access; and positioning Ethiopia as a destination of choice for foreign investment in the digital sector.

To give effect to these objectives are six core enablers: digital public infrastructure; data as a national asset; building digital skills and capacity; policy and regulation; modernising government services; and adoption of industry 5.0 technologies tailored for Ethiopia. The plans include applications for a wide range of sectors including agriculture, health, manufacturing, and logistics.

This is a useful example because it shows that connectivity is not seen as a narrow tech agenda. It is being framed as national economic strategy. It also emphasises inclusion and local identity, which matters in African contexts where digital transformation must reach beyond formal employment and elite institutions to be meaningful.

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Building a creative business that exports culture

A small creative studio produces digital content rooted in local culture. In the past, its audience was mainly local. As connectivity improves and the internet economy grows, the studio can distribute work more widely and earn from digital services.

The opportunity is not only economic. It is also narrative. Connectivity allows African creativity to travel at scale, on its own terms, and to become part of the continent's economic future.

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The link between connectivity and optimism

The data in this chapter supports a clear story of optimism grounded in evidence. Mobile connectivity scores have improved across almost all African countries over a decade, and 33 countries have transitioned into higher categories. Several countries, including Egypt, Tunisia, Libya and Morocco, have made significant jumps.

Network readiness results show multiple areas of relative strength across technology, people, governance and impact. International telecommunications data shows growth in internet use across all African countries over five years, with several in stellar or strong growth categories, and high absolute performance in 2023 in countries such as Algeria, Botswana, Cabo Verde, Egypt, Gabon, Ghana, Libya, Mauritius, Morocco, Seychelles and Tunisia.

E-government results show institutional progress, including South Africa's dramatic ranking improvement from 93rd to 40th place between 2014 and 2024, and strong component performance across multiple countries. City-level results show urban accelerators that can lift national capability over time.

Through the lens of optimism, the significance is not only that connectivity can enable strong outcomes. It is that it is already doing so in measurable ways, across a wide range of African countries, and through distinctive models suited to local realities.

Africa's global leadership in mobile money, the growing economic contribution of ICT, and the continental and national strategies being deployed all point to a deeper shift. Connectivity reflects already strong performance, and as it continues to strengthen, it will drive more progress in markets and services, and in building resilience and innovation across the continent.

Chapter Eight: Diaspora

Connecting Countries and Continents

Africa's diaspora is one of the continent's most practical reasons for optimism.

It represents a powerful combination of capital, skills, global networks, market access, and influence. It is proof that African talent is mobile and can compete globally while keeping alive a relationship with home. This widely dispersed group of Africans can, and do, support the continent's development in ways that aid, governments, and even foreign investment often cannot.

The powerful connection with home is most visible in the large amounts, collectively, of money sent to families in Africa, in investments made back home, in ideas and technologies shared across borders, and in the cultural and diplomatic influence that Africans abroad help to build.

Even when people do not return permanently, they can still contribute through remote work, online collaboration, and short-term travel that moves skills and opportunities in both directions.

What do we mean by "diaspora"

The diaspora is hard to define. The Mo Ibrahim Institute (MIF) for Governance notes that there are more than 270 definitions of it. The African Union considers it to comprise "people of African origin living outside the continent, irrespective of their citizenship and nationality who are willing to contribute to the development of the continent and the building of the African Union". [23]

The concept is complex because it can include ancestry and multiple generations of people of African origin, and it also raises questions about how connected people remain to their home countries.

By one estimate, the African diaspora is about 200 million people. That number goes far beyond what the data can capture, particularly given the dispersed nature of emigration.

For the sake of analysis and clarity, this chapter focuses on emigration stock and emigration rates, while noting that this approach does not include people beyond the first generation who left the continent. It is a narrower lens, but it allows us to describe patterns in a way that is measurable and comparable across countries.

The analysis focuses on the diaspora outside Africa, while noting that there is significant movement of Africans within Africa as well, a way out of hardship and poverty that is more affordable and closer to home.

This framing also helps us address a key debate. One school of thought emphasises the dangers of "brain drain" and the loss of investment in human capital, for example the outflow of doctors from Nigeria to the UK and the US.

[23] Mo Ibrahim Foundation, Joint Research Paper, Africans in the world: Engine for development or Brain Drain? 2020.

Newer strands of thinking focus on “brain circulation” and the benefits that flow back home through money, knowledge, technology, networks, and investment. This chapter sits within that broader conversation, while staying grounded in the evidence available.

While the size of the African diaspora is hard to estimate given how dispersed it is, some have suggested it may be more than 200 million people, as noted above. Either way, it is large, growing and vibrant.

The impact of diaspora engagement with Africa is reflected is in the rising share of remittances/GDP for a variety of African nations. Countries such as Nigeria, Egypt, Kenya and Ghana receive billions of dollars annually in remittances from their diaspora, which stimulates economic activity back home and helps people to live. Sometimes it is invested and agglomerated for investment by recipient governments in Africa.

There is much to be optimistic about. African origin communities tend to be over-represented in their host countries in terms of education levels, business achievements and entrepreneurship. However, not all those in diaspora are highly skilled. Many relocate because of family ties or difficult conditions and a lack of opportunity at home.

But economic clout and human capital linkages are on the rise, and increasingly, high-level African talent is in demand. Many of those in the technology industries in Africa have a diaspora origin or exposure in terms of cross-border partnerships and access to global capital markets. Africa’s soft power is globally expanding through the diaspora.

Music, art and cultural sectors are increasingly global, with a distinct preference for developed country markets, often communicated via the diaspora. This in turn strengthens tourism, investment attractiveness in home countries and agency in global affairs. Thus, the diaspora serves as an important bridge between home countries and global markets.

The findings of the Brand Finance Global Soft Power Index 2026, the world’s most comprehensive study on nation brand perceptions, points to reasons to be optimistic.

The index, which measures familiarity, reputation and influence of a nation, shows that there are nine African countries in the top 100 nations in the world out of 193 ranked.

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South Africa is the best placed at 43 followed by Morocco at 50, Nigeria 71, Algeria 74, Tunisia 75, Kenya 88, and Tanzania, Ghana and Mauritius at 94, 95, and 96 respectively. Given that the diaspora is a strong determinant of familiarity, reputation and influence, these are impressive results for those African nations, some of which are the highest earners of remittances in Africa.

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South Africa’s situation is slightly different with regard to branding. On the remittances front, its inflows are negligible, but it is the biggest source of intra-African remittance flows. But it has benefited significantly from its political profile as the most sophisticated economy in Africa and being the only African member of BRICS and the G20 until recently.

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But the results for the other nations listed show that the African diaspora is playing a key influences in raising the profile, standing and international view of their home countries, which in turn is associated with good global citizenry.

The diaspora is strengthening African identity, and notions of “dual belonging”. According to a report produced by Africa No Filter, second generation young Africans abroad are intentional about cultural connections, language revival, food, heritage travel, philanthropy and technology

investment, despite experiencing discrimination in host countries and sometimes hardship at home. [24]

They actively challenge and address negative media stereotypes about Africa. Between 80% and 85% of respondents to the survey for the report said that being African is an important part of their identity, while 75% indicated strong pride in their heritage.

Two thirds said they participate in African cultural traditions wherever they are, 65% said they regularly follow news about Africa, while nearly 60% said that they actively challenge negative stereotypes about Africa.

The diaspora is one of circulation of people and ideas, talent, and commitment. It tells us that African countries have people with global access and global credibility, and that these advantages can be converted into better outcomes at home.

A declaration: The diaspora is an engine of Africa's progress

There is a familiar narrative that migration is mainly a loss. Sometimes it is, especially when it involves scarce professionals like doctors leaving countries that urgently need them. Yet the diaspora also signals something else that is easy to miss.

It signals ambition and agency. It signals that African people are not waiting for opportunity to arrive, but are building it, seeking it, and then often channelling it back to communities and institutions at home.

This chapter treats the diaspora as a key aspect of optimism because it reflects three big realities.

First, many African households and communities are not relying only on the state or aid to build resilience. They are building safety nets through family networks that stretch across borders. Second, African countries increasingly have access to global skills, technologies, and relationships through their people abroad, as well as their employers in Africa, which strengthens business, universities, public policy, and innovation ecosystems at home.

Third, the diaspora is becoming a meaningful economic force in several African countries, sometimes exceeding traditional external finance flows such as overseas development aid, and at times even foreign direct investment.

Amina's 'two homes' strategy

Amina left Kenya for a nursing job in the UK. At first, her goal was to support her younger siblings through school. Over time, the money she sent home became something bigger. Her remittances helped to stabilise her family's income during a tough season and later became the seed capital for a small pharmacy in Kisumu run by her cousin.

Amina did not return in the traditional sense, yet her choices reshaped outcomes at home. She introduced her cousin to an online inventory tool used by her clinic in the UK, connected the pharmacy to a supplier, and arranged short training visits for a relative studying to become a

[24] Africa No Filter, Being African: How the Africans experience the Diaspora. 2024.

laboratory technician. In her story, optimism looks like a cross-border family enterprise built patiently over years instead of a single dramatic moment.

Why the diaspora matters

The African diaspora living in other regions of the world turns distance into capability. It is one of the clearest illustrations that African ambition goes beyond the borders at home, and that mobility can create new resources for Africa rather than severing ties. When people leave, many continue to carry responsibility, identity, and investment with them.

That is why through the diaspora there is much to be optimistic about. It shows that even in difficult conditions, households, communities, and institutions can reach outward, access opportunity, and then channel parts of that opportunity back into African economies and societies.[25]

The most visible expression of this is remittances. For many families, remittances are not a bonus, they are the difference between coping and falling behind. They support daily living costs, education, healthcare, and housing. More than that, they function like informal insurance. When prices rise, jobs disappear, or harvests fail, remittances often arrive as a stabiliser that keeps households afloat.

Over time, these flows can also become a form of household-level development finance. They pay for school fees that enable future earning potential, and they fund small businesses and property that create longer-term assets.

In the language of optimism, remittances show that many African families are not waiting to be rescued. They are building resilience through networks that stretch across continents.

Yet this optimism would be misunderstood if we reduced diaspora impact to money alone. The deeper value is capacity and connection. Diaspora communities move skills, ideas, and professional standards across borders through mentorship, collaboration, and institutional partnerships.

This can happen without permanent return, especially that remote work and digital communications make consistent contribution possible from anywhere.

Physical distance no longer automatically means disconnection. It often means access to new systems, new technologies, and new ways of doing things, which can be translated into local advantage when diaspora professionals remain engaged. Africa's strengths in ICT, noted in a previous chapter, are a key capability.

The research referenced in this chapter supports this broader view. A study by the African Development Bank finds that the African diaspora contributes positively and significantly to improvements in real per capita incomes in Africa, and that higher education levels among emigrants are associated with larger gains through productivity and total factor productivity. [26]

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[25] Gnimassoun B & Anyanwu J, The Diaspora and Economic Development in Africa, African Development Bank Working Paper Series 308, January 2019.

[26] Op. Cit.

It also notes that remittances are greater from those with lower levels of education. This is not a contradiction. It simply shows that diaspora contributions come through different channels and do not rely on highly skilled employees only.

Some people contribute mainly through financial support, others through skills transfer and investment, and many do both at different life stages.

Other studies also highlight growth effects of remittances, knowledge and technology spillovers, and even institutional benefits such as improved governance and democratic outcomes.

Evidence from Cabo Verde suggests that the possibility of migration can increase incentives to complete secondary schooling back home. Read through an optimism lens, this points to a powerful idea: diaspora pathways can also raise aspiration and investment in human capital, not only remove it.[27]

Diaspora impact also shows up in markets and influence. Diaspora communities create demand for cultural products and home-country goods, which can support exports, strengthen brands, and build global recognition for African countries.

They also generate soft power. They can shape how African countries are perceived, widen diplomatic relationships, and amplify civic debates and reform agendas. This matters because perception ~~can~~ influences ~~affect~~ investment, tourism, partnerships, and credibility. A diaspora that is visible, organised, and successful can quietly shift how a country is treated in global spaces.

This geographical shift carries a responsibility for ensuring that people are law abiding and enter their new space legally or their presence can feed a negative narrative that can make it harder for emigrants to succeed in their new homes.

Beyond economics and global networks, there is often something simpler and more durable: the motivation to give back. Surveys show that a large number of respondents see giving back to the country of origin as being important, and that engagement happens through sharing knowledge, mentoring, volunteering time, and supporting institutions, not only donating money.

This civic and relational dimension is central to optimism. It suggests that diaspora engagement is not only transactional. It is rooted in identity, belonging, and responsibility, which makes it more resilient than short-term trends.

It is also important to recognise that the diaspora story is not a zero-sum one. African migrants contribute meaningfully to host countries by filling skill shortages, widening the tax base, and adding productivity and new perspectives.

Data cited on migrants from Sub-Saharan Africa moving to the US illustrates this clearly. Many are of working age, and educational attainment is high in several communities.

The same data does show that poverty rates remain elevated for certain groups, demonstrating that diaspora life includes hardship as well as success. That realism strengthens the argument rather than weakening it.

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[27] Batista C; Lacuesta A, & Vicente P, Testing the brain gain hypothesis: Micro evidence from Cabo Verde Journal of Development Economics, Elsevier Vol 97 (1), pp 32-45, 2012.

It shows that diaspora engagement is shaped by lived experience. Even when the journey is difficult, many still find ways to support families, build bridges, and create opportunity across borders.

The "remote return" entrepreneur

Thabo moved from South Africa to Australia and found work in logistics. Years later, he noticed that many small exporters back home struggled with shipping costs and documentation. He began helping a friend's small agribusiness enterprise navigate export requirements and introduced them to a simple tracking system he used at work. The first exports were small and there were setbacks, including rejected paperwork and delayed shipments, but the business learned. Within two years, two more local producers joined the arrangement.

Thabo never moved back permanently, yet he became a bridge to new markets. His optimism was not expressed in speeches. It was expressed in the patient work of translating global systems into something local businesses could use.

Evidence of how the diaspora is manifesting in Africa

The tables in this chapter show how large diaspora communities are, where people go, how remittances shape economies, and how intentions to migrate may change future trends. Each table is a different lens on the same question: how diaspora linkages translate into economic and social outcomes, and why these linkages are a reason for optimism.

Emigration stock and emigration rates

The measurement of the diaspora is complex. One approach is to apply the lens of **emigration stock data**, which measures the number of people who have left their country of origin. It underestimates the actual size and scope of the diaspora, since, for example, it does not account for second and subsequent generations. Nonetheless, it is instructive data.

Table 1 shows emigration stock data for the top 20 African countries. The largest diaspora by this measure is from Egypt, followed by Sudan, Morocco, South Sudan, Democratic Republic of Congo and Nigeria. Emigration rates, which measure emigration relative to population, are highest for Eritrea, South Sudan, Central African Republic, Somalia, and Burkina Faso.

Table 2 shows the emigration data by main destination. Tables 1 and 2 taken together reveal a complex and rich story line. The diaspora transcends income levels of home countries.

Wealthier and poorer nations have significant emigration levels, although it is more pronounced for some poorer nations. Second, emigration is not only a feature of large countries. Smaller countries also have very high outward migrations relative to population size.

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Third (not shown) is that emigration stock within Africa is greater than emigration from Africa to the world. Thus, the diaspora is still heavily linked to African roots, driven by geography, family ties, regional labour markets and conflict dynamics but also by corporate opportunities as African multinationals expand across the continent.

This is not cause for scepticism about the power of the diaspora. It reflects reality. This is important from an optimistic viewpoint because it is a sign of maturation and the rise of developing regional labour markets and production systems to support industrial development and address skills gaps and shortages. It is also a stabiliser during conflict or adverse climatic conditions.

Further, it is about keeping ideas, knowhow and capabilities within the continent, which in turn is a potentially important marker of continental market formation, shared economic space and emerging middle-class corridors.

Table 1: Emigration - Migrant Stock 2015 and 2024 (numbers of people)

	Emigration Stock 2015	**Emigration Stock 2024**	**Emigration Rate 2024**
Egypt	4,193,177	4,820,002	4%
Sudan	2,209,101	3,786,603	7%
Morocco	2,907,733	3,627,829	9%
South Sudan	853,845	3,168,836	21%
DRC	1,512,153	2,097,387	2%
Nigeria	1,359,519	2,094,265	1%
Burkina Faso	1,759,971	2,050,050	8%
Somalia	1,719,780	1,935,594	9%
Algeria	1,662,433	1,780,399	4%
Zimbabwe	1,237,826	1,519,324	8%
Mali	1,117,148	1,292,519	5%
Ethiopia	896,584	1,240,645	1%
Côte D'Ivoire	1,025,536	1,211,422	4%
Ghana	846,131	1,055,494	3%
South Africa	782,819	1,005,800	2%
Eritrea	478,597	912,792	21%
CAR	666,056	905,808	15%
Senegal	558,252	741,357	4%

	Emigration Stock 2015	Emigration Stock 2024	Emigration Rate 2024
Benin	628,871	726,530	5%
Tunisia	619,432	715,249	6%

Source: UN Population Division. Ordered according to 2024 data.

Table 2 and Chart 1 below show some important and interesting findings. One is the globally diffuse diaspora found for countries such as South Africa, Egypt and Somalia. Emigrants from these countries reach out to Asia, the Middle East (especially from Egypt) and Oceania in addition to western developed nations.

The shifts also reflect strong ties with former colonial powers, such as the location choices for Moroccans in European centres and people from Francophone Africa in France. Some nations are heavily concentrated in specific countries. Nigerians, for example, are heavily represented in the UK and UK, while Zimbabweans tend to congregate in the UK.

Many of those who now live in these countries have brought with them sought after skills, not just doctors, for example, but nurses and carers too. Many are actively recruited from Africa.

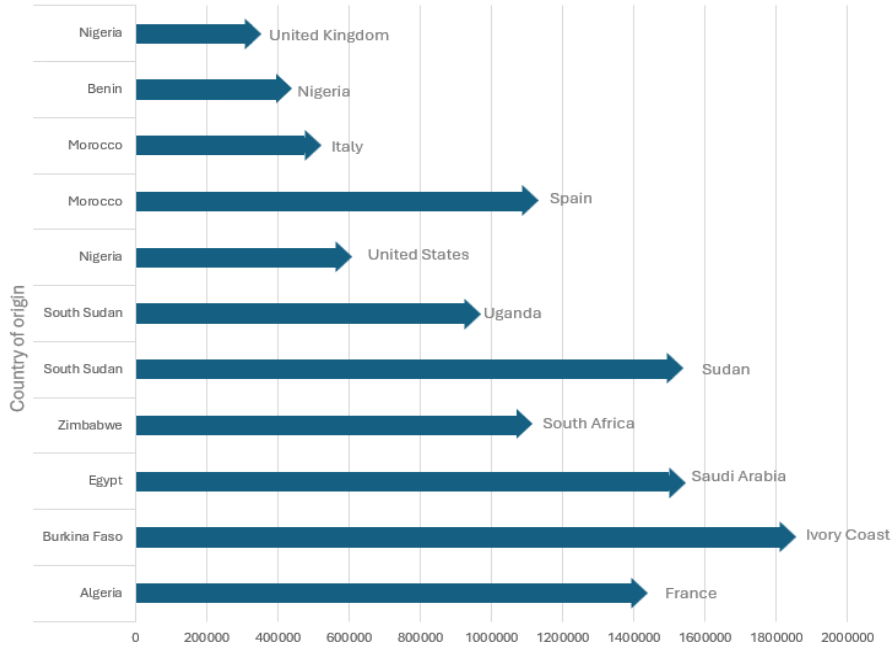
Table 2: Top Emigration Destinations 2024

Destination	Top African Country of Origin	Total African emigration to country 2024
France	Algeria 1,405,235	4,428,182
Côte D'Ivoire	Burkina Faso 1,820,882	2,811,282
Saudi Arabia	Egypt 1,498,313	2,622,804
South Africa	Zimbabwe 1,072, 620	2,348,920
Sudan	South Sudan 1,507,976	2,338,949
Uganda	South Sudan 923,658	1,987,250
US	Nigeria 565,053	1,822,434
Spain	Morocco 1,088, 408	1,420,567
Italy	Morocco 472,734	1,338,067
Nigeria	Benin 404,468	1,262,314
UK	Nigeria 324,007	1,114,649
Ethiopia	South Sudan 443,743	1,106,924
UAE	Egypt 841,883	1,052,564
DRC	CAR 368,125	1,046,870
Kenya	Somalia 401,953	927,104
South Sudan	Sudan 608,817	909,840
Canada	Nigeria 112,065	905,273
Jordan	Egypt 767,948	796,787
Burkina Faso	Cote D'Ivoire 574,409	690,598
Egypt	Sudan 500,000	648,843
Cameroon	DRC 336,349	616,419
Belgium	Morocco 246,575	578,932
Kuwait	Egypt 449,863	529,926
Australia	South Africa 213,447	519,852
Israel	Morocco 190,607	509,981

Source: UN Population Division sorted by total African emigration to country higher to lower

Chart 1 below shows the top countries of origin and destination based on the table above. It shows both the importance of intra-African migration and emigration from African nations to the rest of the world, most notably more advanced economies, such as the US and European nations.

Chart 1: Main origin and destination countries



Source: UN Population Division. Author adaptations.

Resilience and agency

The growing importance of the diaspora is reflected in remittances as a share of GDP. Over the last 10 years, most African countries have experienced growth in remittances as a share of GDP, as shown in Table 3, and elsewhere in the book.

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In 2024, in The Gambia and Lesotho, remittances exceeded 20% of GDP, while for Comoros, Somalia, Liberia, Cabo Verde, Senegal, and Nigeria, remittances as a share of GDP exceeded 10%.

In several African countries, remittances as a share of GDP are also higher than in benchmark countries outside Africa, the world as a whole and Sub-Saharan Africa.

These flows are a source of optimism. When remittances rise as a share of GDP, it signals a stronger cross-border household economy. It suggests that families and communities are financing stability and opportunity through their networks.

It also signals that diaspora connections are becoming part of the economic structure of countries, not merely a private matter. Further, it reflects the actual needs of citizens which is often not the case for other forms of assistance. In this context it is empowering.

Significantly, in some countries, the value of personal remittances is greater than that of overseas development aid and the value of foreign direct investment, which can be volatile and even negative in some years. This is particularly the case for Egypt, Ghana, Kenya, Morocco, Nigeria, Tunisia, and Zimbabwe.

These numbers matter because they show the diaspora is becoming more important than aid in certain contexts. That shift is politically and psychologically meaningful. It reflects a form of agency that is not conditional in the same way that aid can be, and it reflects the growing influence of Africans abroad in shaping home-country resilience.

It is also a signal of greater African identity in the sense of Africans abroad shaping the futures of those back home. This is an important mindset shift away from the notion of African countries being purely vehicles for extraction by advanced economies.

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Table 3: Personal remittances as Percentage of GDP & Value

	2014	**2024**	**Value of Remittances 2024 ($m)**	**Value Net ODA and Official Aid 2023 ($m)**	**Value Inward FDI Flows 2024 ($m)**
The Gambia	11.2	21.1	528.8	343.9	232
Lesotho	16.6	20.9	475.8	172.3	-42
Comoros	13.9	18.3	282.4	166.4	7
Somalia	-	17.5	2118.1	2281.1	765
Liberia	15.9	14.3	680.0	562.6	747
Cabo Verde	9.6	12.1	334.0	101.7	64
Senegal	9.8	11.6	3750.0	1859.6	2,016
Nigeria	3.7	11.3	21,293	3596.4	1,080
Guinea Bissau	8.1	9.7	206.1	188.9	27
Morocco	6.5	8.1	12,510.9	771.7	1,639
Zimbabwe	9.8	8.1	3,600.0	791.5	597

	2014	2024	Value of Remittances 2024 ($m)	Value Net ODA and Official Aid 2023 ($m)	Value Inward FDI Flows 2024 ($m)
Burundi	2.1	7.8	168.6	621.7	32
Egypt	6.4	7.6	29,559.1	480.1	46,578
Tunisia	4.7	6.1	3257.0	1225.9	936
Togo	6.7	6.0	600.0	615.5	84
Sierra Leone	0.8	4.3	321.6	497.8	274
Mali	5.4	4.1	1094.5	1292.5	709
Kenya	2.1	4.0	4,999.8	2595.8	1,503
Rwanda	2.2	3.8	537.5	1387.3	819
Ghana	3.7	3.7	3,027.4	1572.0	1,669
SSA	2.2	3.3	57,375.6	62,285.6 (2021)	46,440
India	3.5	3.5	137,674.5	2376.6	27,556
China	0.3	0.2	31,410.6	-267.2	116,238
Brazil	0.1	0.2	4,902.4	700.0	59,178
World	0.7	0.8	905,976.2	202,111.7 (2021)	1,508,803

Source: World Bank, Knomad database, UNCTAD. Sorted by 2024.

History shaping money corridors

Table 4 shows data for bilateral remittances. For many African countries, the main source of remittances is other African nations. This is the case for Zimbabwe, DRC, and South Sudan especially.

This highlights how regional labour movement creates regional financial support systems. South Africa is the main source of intra-African remittances, as noted above, and has become a magnet for migrants from not just Southern Africa but further afield, despite recurrent outbreaks of anti-migrant protests mostly directed at other Africans.

These have been focused on, but not limited to, the large number of illegal migrants believed to be in the country. The country's porous borders and years of lax immigration enforcement have

allowed this issue to become a flashpoint amid other socio-economic challenges, particularly in lower income areas. The recent focus of protests in 2026 has been illegal immigration, with some South Africans accusing undocumented Africans from other countries of taking scarce jobs, overcrowding schools and health facilities despite not paying tax, building squatter camps in urban areas and getting involved in crime.

The data also shows that some African economies are gradually de-linking from colonial ties. For example, in Algeria, Canada is the number one source of remittances and not its former colonial power, France. This is also the case for Egypt, Nigeria, Ghana, Kenya, Tanzania, and various other countries. The growth of Intra-Africa remittances is part of the displacement. This data speaks to greater agency and is thus cause for optimism.

The Middle East is also becoming an important source of remittances, reflecting regional corridors of the movement of people and skills.

The other point to note is the sheer size and scale of remittances. Egypt, Kenya, Nigeria and Morocco are all recipients of high levels of capital inflows from remittances, flows that have become strong drivers of economic prosperity.

In the case of several nations, including Kenya and Ghana, there are significant flows from the UK and US, which are associated with the technology-based diaspora, where professional networks and connections in London or Silicon Valley are being leveraged to develop high-value industries back home.

Finally, there is the group of countries that receive significant support from neighbours such as South Sudan (Sudan), which represent stabilisation remittances or funds from nearby economies to provide an important safety net.

The relevance of the table below is that it shows how diaspora engagement is structured by specific corridors that are influenced by history, proximity, and labour demand. These corridors shape where networks are strongest, where investment is easiest, and where policy engagement efforts may yield the greatest returns.

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Table 4: Bilateral Remittances 2021 ($m)

Country	Total Remittances	No 1 Source of Remittances	No 2 Source of Remittances	Former Colonial Power
Egypt	31,500	Saudi Arabia: 8,100	UAE 8,100	Britain
Nigeria	19,500	US: 5,700	U.K 2,800	Britain
Morocco	10,700	France: 3,400	Spain 2,500	France and Spain
Ghana	4,500	US: 1,100	Nigeria 809.3	Britain
Kenya	3,800	US: 1300	UK 1000	Britain
Senegal	2,700	France: 704.6	Italy 494.4	France

Country	Total Remittances	No 1 Source of Remittances	No 2 Source of Remittances	Former Colonial Power
Tunisia	2,200	France: 1,100	US 445.9	France
Zimbabwe	2,000	South Africa: 956.6	UK 375.0	Britain
Algeria	1,800	Canada: 61.4m	Spain: 52.2m	France
DRC Congo	1,300	Uganda: 189.5	France: 163.7	Belgium
South Sudan	1,200	Sudan: 449.5	Uganda: 356.6	Egypt and Britain
Mali	1,100	Côte D'Ivoire: 377.5	France: 153.7	France
Sudan	1,100	Saudi Arabia: 327.1	South Sudan: 227.5	Egypt and Britain
Uganda	1,100	Kenya: 321.2	US: 177.3	Britain
South Africa	926.7	UK: 248.1	Australia: 204.6	Netherlands and Britain
Togo	674	Nigeria: 171.4	Benin: 115.5, Ghana: 115.5	Germany
Madagascar	614.6	France: 522.6	Germany: 14.5	France
Tanzania	569.4	US: 186.8	UK: 98.8	Germany and Britain
Burkina Faso	560.6	Côte D'Ivoire: 468.8	Mali: 17.9	France
The Gambia	547.1	US: 160.5	Italy: 86.5	Britain

Source: World Bank Knomad database. Author adaptations and interpretation.

What intentions say about opportunity and perception

Afrobarometer data on intention to emigrate is another useful lens because it signals possible future diaspora growth. Table 5 shows that Lesotho, Senegal and Guinea have the highest rates of people considering emigration. If these intentions translate into actions, they could expand diaspora networks and remittance flows over time.

However, in most countries, there is no real intention to leave, which from the point of view of talent mobility is reassuring. In several countries the gap between 'not at all' and 'a lot' is very wide in favour of 'not at all', especially in Madagascar, Mauritania, Seychelles, Tanzania, and Zambia, though other countries have smaller gaps.

Europe and North America are the preferred destinations for emigration from Africa. The main reason for this is overwhelmingly employment.

This is revealing. It points to the urgent need for more and better jobs, and it also challenges the simplistic narrative that people are leaving mainly due to conflict or governance collapse. In this dataset, jobs are the primary driver. However, high unemployment is also linked to poor governance, with many governments failing to develop or implement effective growth plans that could provide employment.

There are many other drivers as well. In the case of South Africa, high crime levels also play a role as well as policy. Many emigrants are white people who feel excluded by the country's race laws, specifically black economic empowerment legislation, which is aimed at redressing the economic inequalities of apartheid and focuses on increasing the economic participation of non-white citizens.

Table 5: Africans Considering Emigration

	Not at all	A lot	Top Choice of Country/Region	Main Reason for considering emigration
Tanzania	90.6%	5.0%	Europe (23.1%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (3.9%)
Madagascar	85.8%	5.5%	Europe (31%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (8.7%)
Seychelles	83.6%	5.6%	Europe (31.4%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (7.7%)
Zambia	73.1%	16.6%	North America (24.3%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (13.4%)
Mauritania	71.0%	6.9%	North America (31.8%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (15.8%)
Kenya	66.3%	18.9%	North America (37.7%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (19.7%)

Commented [MM60]: Explain that this is a list of countries with the highest negative response leaving… majority of Tanzanians, Madagascans, Kenyans etc want to stay put. Reader shouldn't have to figure out what this means

	Not at all	A lot	Top Choice of Country/Region	Main Reason for considering emigration
Namibia	64.5%	11.9%	Europe (24.4%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (19.2%)
Tunisia	63.8%	26.2%	Europe (56.5%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (19.5%)
Botswana	63.7%	19.4%	Region (26.3%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (23.9%)
Côte D'Ivoire	62.1%	17.8%	North America (42.4%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (18.7%)
Eswatini	61.8%	18.0%	Region (51.2%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (25.9%)
Chad	61.2%	17.4%	North America (20.5%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (16.2%)
Guinea	56.4%	27.5%	North America (32.0%)	Poverty/destitution (17.8%)
Morocco	55.4%	15.9%	Europe (58.7%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (22.1%)
Malawi	55.2%	24.9%	Region (54.8%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (23.4%)
Benin	54.2%	23.2%	Europe (24.9%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (16.9%)

	Not at all	A lot	Top Choice of Country/Region	Main Reason for considering emigration
Gabon	53.9%	20.1%	Europe (30.9%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (15.1%)
Lesotho	53.8%	36.9%	Region (71.9%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (33.3%)
Senegal	51.3%	28.6%	North America (41.2%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (33.9%)
Mauritius	46.1%	17.0%	Europe (34.7%)	Find work/better job/better work opportunities (25.4%)

Source: Afrobarometer. Sorted by 'Not at all" column.

Return migration is part of the story

There is limited data on return migration, but a small sample suggests it is happening. Where robust data is available, Ethiopia leads in returnees, mostly from Saudi Arabia and Yemen. For other countries, returnees from other parts of Africa are important, though there is also some evidence of people returning from more advanced economies.

The relevance of Table 6 is that it supports the broader "circulation" story. Even a partial return, or repeated short-term movements back and forth, can reinforce skills transfer and investment.

How did we get here: The win-win ecosystem

Diaspora impact does not happen automatically. It grows when there are channels that make it easy to contribute, and when people feel their contribution will matter. This is where institutions, networks, and deliberate programmes become important.

One piece is the rise of diaspora-focused organisations that coordinate skills, funding, advocacy, and collaboration. Examples include the Somali Diaspora Network, which focuses on education and peacebuilding, and the African Diaspora Network in Silicon Valley, which connects African investors and entrepreneurs abroad with African opportunities.

There are also academic and professional programmes such as the Association of African Universities Diaspora Linkages Programme, which brings diaspora scholars to engage with African universities, and sector initiatives like the African Diaspora Health Initiative, made up of health professionals abroad promoting healthcare delivery in Africa. The African Science

Diaspora Network focuses on research collaboration between diaspora scientists and researchers back home.

Another piece is the role of prominent individuals whose influence creates visibility, funding, and cultural confidence. Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, a Nigerian-born author based in the US, promotes African identity, gender equality, and education.

Ghanaian entrepreneur and educator Patrick Awuah founded the Ashesi University Foundation, incorporated in the US, providing high-quality education to African students from 32 countries. Senegalese American singer and businessman Akon co-founded the Akon Lighting Project to expand access to low-cost, sustainable solar power, which reached 14 African nations in its first year.

Alek Wek, a global supermodel hailing from South Sudan, advocates for refugees and serves as a UNHCR Goodwill Ambassador. Nigerian tech entrepreneur Iyinoluwa Aboyeji helped found Flutterwave and Andela, linking African talent to global markets. Professional Egyptian footballer Mohamed Salah supports sanitation, hospitals, ambulance services, and a girls' school in Egypt.

These examples matter not because celebrity is the point, but because they show different pathways of global Africans in their engagement with their home base, from education to energy access, from technology to humanitarian advocacy. And there are many of them doing so.

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Some governments have tapped into the diaspora proactively, playing a role by creating formal mechanisms to engage diaspora communities.

Nigeria's Nigerians in Diaspora Commission is one example of a structured approach. It was formalised by an act of parliament to support the engagement of Nigerians in diaspora in development, and to use human capital and other resources of Nigerians abroad for socio-economic, cultural, and political development.

Its contributions include engagement with government and investors, giving advice to governance on policy issues and support for diaspora welfare and return.

These efforts point to a broader lesson. When diaspora engagement is treated as a strategic national asset, not a side story, countries can turn global networks into domestic progress.

The "skills corridor" that began with an email

A university lecturer in Ghana noticed that her department's curriculum had fallen behind industry practice. She emailed a former classmate now working in Canada. The classmate agreed to host monthly online seminars.

At first, attendance was small and the internet connection often failed. But over time, the seminars became a steady learning space, and alumni abroad began contributing guest lectures and internship links. A year later, two students secured placements, and the department partnered with a local company to co-design a practical module. The change was not sudden, and it did not rely on a massive donor programme. It relied on trust, persistence, and a diaspora connection that stayed active.

The diaspora story is one about what African people do even if they are far from home. The evidence in this chapter shows growth in emigration stock in most countries, strong intra-African migration patterns and the scale of remittance flows, which are rising as a share of GDP in many countries.

This shows that African households and institutions have access to support and capability that goes beyond national borders. The diaspora is a stabiliser in hard times, a source of investment and entrepreneurship, a bridge to global markets and knowledge, and a contributor to soft power and cultural confidence. It also shows us that Africa is shaping the world through its people.

Optimism, in this context, is not about pretending challenges do not exist. It is about recognising that Africa already has global assets in motion.

The task ahead is to deepen the channels that turn diaspora energy into long-term transformation, so that the movement of people continues to produce movement in opportunity, institutions, and outcomes.

Chapter Nine: Creative Cities

Hubs of Possibility

Cities are vital integrated, cohesive hubs of creativity, innovation and talent. They represent pools of skilled and educated labour and give people access to leading edge facilities and institutions, entrepreneurs and communities, and diverse business offerings and entertainment.

In discussions about Africa, the focus tends to be on countries and on the array of issues that influence the national trajectory. However, African cities deserve attention for a few reasons.

One is that the large urban centres tend to be the beating heart of countries. Another is that they contribute immensely to overall national economic activity and wellbeing, and yet another is that they are where investors, business leaders and many others cluster, drawn by better infrastructure, transport connectivity and lifestyle choices.

There is much to be optimistic about in cities in Africa. They are concentrations of possibility, and historically have been the engines of transformation and renewal. They compress talent, capital, infrastructure and ideas into shared space.

When people cluster, productivity rises, proximity allows knowledge transfer, networks form and intensify, and collaborative ventures develop, including between firms, and firms and education and research institutions.

Urban centres enable scale. This means larger consumer markets, denser labour pools, more efficient service delivery than in rural areas, stronger innovation ecosystems, and greater returns on investment. Infrastructure investment is often focused on cities where returns are better, which drives development.

Entrepreneurship in cities blossoms in proximity to customers, suppliers and collaborators. Technology hubs emerge around universities and co-working spaces, while diaspora capital fuels further development and growth.

Cities anchor regional trade corridors and integrate national economies into global supply chains, providing air links to other regions and road and rail connections to ports and international markets.

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In the African context, urbanisation is not a marginal trend. It is the defining shift of the coming decades. According to the Economist Intelligence Unit, African cities are expected to realise among the fastest growth rates across the world through to 2035.

By that time, Africa's top 100 cities by population are expected to represent 21% of Africa's population.[28]

They will also generate more than 60% of the continent's GDP, with their collective GDP tripling between 2023 and 2035.

Africa has, and will continue to have, the fastest growth rate of urbanisation across major regions in the world. The population in urban areas is expected to increase from 650 million in 2023 to almost one billion people by 2035, or a compound annual growth rate of 3.5%.

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This means that the share of people living in towns and cities will be greater than 50% by 2035.

In 2025, 32 countries had urbanisation rates of more than 50%. This is a significant increase from six in 2000. Nine countries, Burundi, Egypt, South Africa, Gabon, Mauritius, Kenya, Libya, Seychelles, and Sâo Tomé and Principe, have urbanisation rates of more than 75%, which means that more than three-quarters of the population in these countries live in urban.

The urbanisation is expected to intensify over the next 25 years. In addition, 21 countries are expected to have urbanisation rates in excess of 75%, up from nine currently with a further 42 countries expecting urban spaces to grow by more than 50% by 2050, up from the current 32.[29]

This matters because urbanisation, when managed and invested in, is one of the most reliable predictors of economic transformation. Every high-income region in the world industrialised and modernised through cities.

The link between growing urbanisation and city GDP is shown in the following table.

Table 1: African City GDP

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City	Compound Annual GDP Growth Rate 2023-2035 (%)	City GDP Rank 2023	City GDP Rank 2035
Greater Cairo	5.1	1	1
Greater Johannesburg	5.0	2	2

[28] Economist Intelligence Unit, African Cities 2035: Rapid urbanization and economic expansion, 2024.
[29] OECD, African Urbanisation Dynamics: Planning for Urban Expansion, March 2025.

City	Compound Annual GDP Growth Rate 2023-2035 (%)	City GDP Rank 2023	City GDP Rank 2035
Lagos	4.7	3	3
Cape Town	5.0	4	4
Alexandria	5.1	5	5
Addis Ababa	10.6	12	6
Casablanca	4.4	6	7
Dar es Salaam	9	15	8
Abidjan	8.8	18	9
Durban	4.9	7	10
Kinshasa	7.5	14	11
Luanda	6.0	10	12
Nairobi	5.6	8	13
Pretoria	5.4	9	14
Accra	6.7	13	15
Kumasi	7.4	19	16
Abuja	5.0	16	17
Kampala	9.6	27	18
Kano	4.6	17	19
Algiers	3.1	11	20
Dakar Region	7.8	24	21
Ibadan	4.6	21	22
Rabat	4.5	20	23
Yaoundé	6.2	25	24
Port Harcourt	5.2	26	25

Source: Economist Intelligence Unit.

The African city GDP projections of major cities (from the top 100 African cities) as shown in the table below from The Economist Intelligence Unit, demonstrates the expected rapid growth in city GDP.

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Particularly strong growth rates are expected for Addis Ababa, Dar es Salaam, Abidjan, Kampala, Kinshasa, and Dakar.

For example, Addis Ababa is expected to be ranked sixth in City GDP, up from its 2023 rank of 12th, out of 100 cities in Africa. It should be noted that despite the fact that significant compound annual growth in GDP is predicted, some cities are expected to decline in rank due to the faster growth of other cities.

Both larger and middle-tier cities are expected to be at the core of this growth. As the Economist Intelligence Unit suggests, "We expect rapid urbanisation across Africa to help to create more dynamic and wealthier consumer markets, better connected and more sophisticated commercial and distribution hubs, and larger bases for industrial production and import-export operations".

Yes, it is the case that cities face congestion, inequality, environmental strain and governance pressures. This is the reality. These are signs of growth under pressure.

But rapid urbanisation also creates urgency which catalyses reform, experimentation, innovation and opportunity. African cities are increasingly becoming hubs where solutions in renewable energy, fintech, mobility, housing and climate change adaptation are found.

Africa's urbanisation rates are therefore not merely a demographic statistic. They are a structural advantage, signalling and driving scale, dynamism and the formation of ecosystems. The acceleration of urbanisation is not something to be feared. It is transformation to be harnessed and a powerful reason for optimism.

A number of African cities are emerging as leading hives of creativity.

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Lagos a creative capital for music (Afrobeats) and home to a large movie industry (Nollywood), as well as being a major hub for advertising, fashion and digital content creation. Its citizens are exporting music and visual culture across Africa, Europe, and North America.

Cape Town has positioned itself as a design and film hub, making a significant contribution annually to the economy and attracting major international productions. Cape Town has twice been chosen as the winner of the World Design Capital created by the World Design Organisation.

Dakar is internationally renowned for the Dakar Biennale, one of the most important contemporary African art exhibitions globally. Senegal's cultural sector remains central to its international brand, with Dakar serving as a regional centre for visual arts, literature and fashion.

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Marrakech has built a strong global reputation as a centre of heritage, art and cultural tourism. Morocco's creative and cultural industries, including crafts, fashion and festivals, constitute a significant part of the tourism economy, which in turn contributes roughly 7-8% of national GDP.

Accra is a hub of music, fashion and film, with Ghana's Year of Return initiative, a blueprint for diaspora engagement, attracted more than one million visitors in 2019 and billions of dollars in

economic activity, reinforcing Accra's position as a cultural capital for the diaspora. It aimed to get diaspora from other regions to visit, relocate to or invest in the country.

Cairo remains one of the Arab world's most influential film and publishing centres, with Egypt's film industry historically producing the majority of Arabic-language cinema.

Abidjan has become a leading Francophone music and fashion centre, particularly through genres such as coupé-décalé, while Côte d'Ivoire's cultural industries are integrating into West African media markets.

Addis Ababa combines a rich musical heritage with a fast-growing contemporary fashion and design scene, supported by Ethiopia's expanding urban middle class and tourism sector.

These cities illustrate a broader trend. Across Africa, cultural and creative industries are among the fastest-growing sectors globally. UNESCO estimates that the global creative economy generates over $2 trillion annually and employs nearly 50 million people worldwide. It notes that there is significant untapped potential in Africa, where a young, digitally connected population is accelerating content production and consumption.

Urbanisation amplifies this momentum. As cities expand, they concentrate audiences, talent pools, creative clusters, performance venues, digital studios, and investors.

Informal creativity becomes formal industry. Local scenes become export platforms. Diaspora networks plug urban creators directly into global markets via streaming platforms, social media, and touring circuits.

The optimism lies not simply in cultural vibrancy, but in economic structure. Creative industries are labour-intensive, youth-driven, innovation-friendly, and globally scalable. They shape perception, attract tourism, stimulate services, and reinforce city brands.

On a continent where the median age is under 20, cities that successfully harness culture are not peripheral to development — they are central to it.

Africa's urban creative capitals are therefore more than lifestyle stories. They are evidence that African cities are building globally competitive sectors rooted in identity, innovation, and demographic advantage — a powerful and measurable reason for optimism.

International competitiveness of cities

A glance at the international competitiveness of African cities vis-à-vis the rest of the world shows some interesting and important features.

Oxford Economics, an independent research organisation, launched its Global Cities Index in 2024, which ranks the top 1,000 cities in the world.

They are ranked according to the criteria of: Economics (GDP, employment, industry diversity, business activity); Human Capital (education levels, presence of universities, talent pools, population growth and demographics); Quality of Life (income levels and inequality, housing and affordability, healthcare and life expectancy, safety and cultural amenities); Environment (air quality and emissions, climate risk, green spaces and environmental policies); and Governance (political stability, regulator quality, infrastructure and public spaces, ease of doing business).

In addition, there is an overall ranking.

Of these, 113 African cities are ranked in the 2025 index. The table displays the top 20. The top five are placed in the top 300 with Cairo (Egypt) leading the field followed by Port Louis (Mauritius), Nairobi (Kenya), Accra (Ghana) and Algiers (Algeria).

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The main number of ranked cities by country are as follows, noting that population size of a nation is clearly a factor in the number of ranked cities: Egypt (12 cities), Nigeria (14), Kenya (2), Morocco (8), Ghana (2), South Africa (8), Algeria (2), and Tunisia (2).

These criteria demonstrate that African cities are competitive by world standards, and this is important since locations around the world compete for talent, resources and investments.

Thus, African cities are well placed to receive foreign investment and secure home-grown and overseas talent. It means that potential investors when looking at places to invest will have reason to pay attention to these cities. This also applies equally to retaining capital and talent.

By pillar, there are several standout cities, which we define as those inside the top 100 on a pillar. Four cities stand out for human capital. These are Cairo (56), Johannesburg (43), Cape Town (86), and Lagos (89). This recognises that cities in African countries are undertaking critical investments in skills, labour force development as well as education and training — all essential ingredients for modern competitive advantage, which is also a cause for optimism.

Eight cities stand out on the quality of the environment. These are: Nairobi (69), Windhoek (87), Maputo (68), Mombasa (59), Luanda (51), Yamoussoukro (50), Pointe Noire (57), and Asmara (55). Note that only the first two are shown in the table below.

Environmental quality is not cosmetic; it underpins foundational and long-term competitiveness and liveability. Cities that manage pollution, protect green areas, and invest in sustainable infrastructure signal institutional capacity and forward planning. Higher scores suggest not only cleaner air or better-managed spaces, but stronger regulatory systems, civic awareness, and investment in public goods.

For rapidly urbanising regions, this is significant. It indicates that growth and environmental stewardship are not mutually exclusive — that some African cities are demonstrating the ability to expand while maintaining or improving ecological standards.

In a century defined by climate risk and sustainability transitions, cities that build environmental resilience early are positioning themselves for healthier populations, stronger tourism appeal, greater investor confidence, and lower long-term adaptation costs. Within the Funnel of Optimism, environmental quality strengthens both foundations and capabilities — reinforcing the case that urban Africa's rise can be not only fast, but sustainable.

Table 2: Oxford Economics - City Rankings for Africa 2025

	Overall	**Economics**	**Human Capital**	**Quality of Life**	**Environment**	**Governance**
Cairo (Egypt)	302	171	**56**	492	823	846
Port Louis (Mauritius)	338	305	785	353	144	160

	Overall	Economics	Human Capital	Quality of Life	Environment	Governance
Nairobi (Kenya)	381	216	166	907	**69**	621
Accra (Ghana)	387	437	309	541	232	370
Algiers (Algeria)	389	507	243	308	592	859
Casablanca (Morocco)	431	412	260	584	555	596
Rabat (Morocco)	447	398	463	557	292	596
Johannesburg (SA)	457	316	**43**	969	819	372
Constantine (Morocco)	474	599	293	371	643	859
Gaborone (Botswana)	475	551	149	951	121	332
Windhoek (Namibia)	487	480	227	933	87	354
Cape Town (SA)	506	591	86	966	184	372
Lagos (Nigeria)	526	487	89	913	460	894
Tunis (Tunisia)	529	647	279	668	687	618
Nouakchott (Mauritania)	539	420	611	674	493	638
Kigali (Rwanda)	540	538	257	891	415	515
Alexandria (Egypt)	557	602	242	703	785	846
Conakry (Guinea)	560	459	519	722	209	914

	Overall	Economics	Human Capital	Quality of Life	Environment	Governance
Doula (Cameroon)	568	537	349	666	513	929
Oran (Algeria)	578	896	384	345	646	859

Source: Oxford Economics 2025. Sorted by Overall Index, ranking from higher to lower.

The Africa Report, an independent magazine, in 2026, released its list of the 30 cities it considers to be the most attractive in Africa. The list comprises the following key elements: Foreign Direct Investment; Quality of Life; Infrastructure and Housing; Employment and Business; and Essential Services. These are the essential parameters which drive and shape investment and the business climate.

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The top five cities overall are Cairo, Kigali, Nairobi, Cape Town and Casablanca. Cairo has made the most rapid strides, rising from 8th place in 2024 to the top in 2025. It is also the best-placed city in Africa for attracting investment.

Kigali tops the list for quality of life, infrastructure and housing, employment and business and essential services. Thus, strikingly, Kigali is the best performing city on most of the parameters. The reason that Cairo is top of the list for FDI and not other areas measured is because that category is accorded a higher weighting.

Table 3: Africa's Top 30 Most Attractive Cities (Scores out of 10)

Rank 2025	Country	Overall Index Score	FDI	Quality of Life	Infrastructure & Housing	Employment & Business	Essential Services
1	Cairo	7.00	9.7	6.5	6.6	5.8	6.5
2	Kigali	6.64	1.5	8.6	7.9	7.1	8.1
3	Nairobi	6.28	6.4	5.9	6.6	5.5	7.0
4	Cape Town	6.13	4.9	6.5	6.5	5.9	6.9
5	Casablanca	6.10	3.4	7.1	6.7	6.6	6.7
6	Rabat	6.03	1.1	8.0	7.3	6.4	7.4
7	Johannesburg	5.95	6.2	5.4	6.3	5.5	6.4
8	Lagos	5.87	5.7	6.1	5.3	6.1	6.1
9	Pretoria	5.59	1.0	6.7	7.1	5.9	7.2
10	Tangier	5.53	2.6	7.2	5.9	6.2	5.8
11	Alexandria	5.50	1.2	7.1	6.5	6.0	6.7

Rank 2025	Country	Overall Index Score	FDI	Quality of Life	Infrastructure & Housing	Employment & Business	Essential Services
12	Accra	5.48	3.0	6.2	5.5	5.8	6.9
13	Abidjan	5.48	2.5	6.6	5.8	5.6	6.9
14	Mombasa	5.46	2.4	6.1	6.5	5.5	6.7
15	Dar es Salaam	5.45	1.5	6.4	6.2	6.1	7.0
16	Cotonou	5.23	0.2	7.2	6.2	5.7	6.8
17	Abuja	5.19	0.7	6.9	6.3	5.8	6.2
18	Addis Ababa	5.06	1.1	6.9	5.8	5.5	6.1
19	Gaborone	5.05	0.6	6.4	6.3	5.0	7.0
20	Marrakesh	5.04	0.2	7.2	6.0	5.7	6.1
21	Algiers	5.04	0.4	6.5	5.8	5.5	6.9
22	Tunis	4.98	0.8	5.9	5.8	5.1	7.3
23	Dakar	4.92	1.3	6.1	5.4	5.0	6.8
24	Lusaka	4.84	0.6	6.1	6.3	5.6	5.5
25	Durban	4.78	1.1	5.8	6.2	4.8	6.0
26	Kampala	4.54	0.6	5.7	5.2	4.8	6.4
27	Libreville	4.41	0.3	6.1	5.1	5.0	5.5
28	Maputo	4.15	0.6	5.4	4.9	4.2	5.7
29	Harare	4.10	0.8	5.5	4.8	4.3	5.1
30	Lomé	3.98	0.6	5.4	4.7	4.0	5.1

Source: Africa Report (1 December, 2025). Sorted by Overall Index Score

Creating dynamic spaces

As flagged earlier, creativity and innovation go hand in glove with urbanisation. Creativity and cities go hand in hand because cities concentrate the very conditions that allow culture to flourish: density, diversity, infrastructure, capital, and audiences. Over time, this concentration produces not only economic value, but cultural identity.

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History reinforces this pattern. The great cultural capitals of the world have almost always been cities, such as London and Paris, the former a hub for creative industries, and the latter synonymous with art, fashion, literature and philosophy.

More generally Africa's recent growth in Cultural and Creative Industries (CCI) was around 14%, with a rise of CCI-related exports between 2010-2020. PwC estimates that revenue from entertainment and media industries in Nigeria is projected to grow from $6.6 billion in 2022 to $12.9 billion in 2027.[30] These numbers are fuelled by vibrant youth, technology, innovation, entrepreneurship, and a strong diaspora, all features of an optimistic Africa.

Africa No Filter, in conjunction with the British Council, has established a Creative Vibrancy Index for cities. This is based on the parameters of Cultural vibrancy, Enabling Environment, and Creative Economy.

As can be seen from the table below, Johannesburg tops the list of 12, followed by Cairo, Lagos, Luanda, Harare and Dar es Salaam, to round off the top half of the rankings. Johannesburg is ranked number one on enabling environment, while Cairo is ranked in top place for cultural vibrancy, and Lagos for the creative economy.

Cultural Vibrancy refers to: venues and facilities including sights and landmarks, cinemas and theatres, concert and music halls, art and cultural facilities; as well as participation and attractiveness encompassing participation in events both in person and online.

The Enabling Environment covers: openness and trust (foreign born population), governance (quality of governance, national cultural policy), International connections (tourist visits), and censorship (personal freedom ranking index).

The Creative Economy comprises: intellectual property and innovation (patents, local films, entertainment and media market), and education capacity (knowledge diffusion, university rankings in arts and humanities subjects).

Creative sectors are labour-intensive, innovation-driven, and globally tradable. They generate tourism, attract foreign students, stimulate hospitality and retail, and enhance a city's global profile. Cultural capital becomes economic capital.

This is why creativity is a serious development variable. When African cities such as Johannesburg, Cairo, Lagos, Luanda, Harare, and Dar es Salaam score strongly on a Creative Vibrancy Index, they are demonstrating the early architecture of what London and Paris institutionalised decades or centuries ago: dense ecosystems where culture, commerce, and innovation intersect.

Table 4: Creative Vibrancy Index – Measuring 12 Cities

City	Overall Rank	Score	Cultural Vibrancy Rank (Score in Brackets)	Enabling Environment Rank (Score in Brackets)	Creative Economy Rank (Score in Brackets)
Johannesburg	1	64.37	3 (59.01)	1 (99.25)	5 (52.29)
Cairo	2	56.9	1 (68.9)	8 (21.01)	3 (62.85)

[30] PwC, PwC Africa Media and Entertainment Outlook, 2023.

City	Overall Rank	Score	Cultural Vibrancy Rank (Score in Brackets)	Enabling Environment Rank (Score in Brackets)	Creative Economy Rank (Score in Brackets)
Lagos	3	52.21	4 (52.97)	9 (20.4)	1 (67.35)
Luanda	4	43.21	9 (27.56)	4 (28.83)	2 (66.04)
Harare	5	37.94	11 (22.82)	2 (45.28)	7 (49.4)
Dar es Salaam	6	37.75	8 (36.17)	12 (13.48)	6 (51.46)
Accra	7	37.43	10 (27.38)	5 (27.36)	4 (52.51)
Dakar	8	36.99	7 (37.07)	6 (26.66)	8 (42.09)
Nairobi	9	35.03	6 (48.66)	3 (32.25)	11 (22.75)
Marrakesh	10	34.89	5 (52.87)	7 (21.9)	10 (23.41)
Tunis	11	34.14	2 (62.28)	10 (17.66)	12 (14.24)
Kinshasa	12	25.95	12 (21.18)	11 (13.5)	9 (36.95)

Source: Africa No Filter

Drilling down further by variables: Lagos is number one for venues and facilities, Marrakesh for participation in and attractiveness of the city for creative and cultural activities, Lagos for IP and innovation, Johannesburg for openness and trust as well as international connections, Accra for censorship, and Luanda for education and capacity. This data reflects the broad range of capabilities across African cities in the creative and cultural space.

UNESCO Creative Cities Network

The UESCO Creative Cities Network is based on the idea of sharing practices with and collaboration among leading creative cities around the world.

The network was created in 2004 to promote cooperation with and among cities that have identified creativity as a strategic factor for sustainable urban development, the organisation says.

“The 408 cities around the world which currently make up this network work together towards a common objective: placing creativity and cultural industries at the heart of their development plans at the local level and cooperating actively at the international level.”

Each year more cities are added, following a rigorous selection process. There are eight categories: Music, Media and Arts, Film, Crafts and Folk Arts, Gastronomy, Literature, Design, and Architecture.

There are 35 African cities in this global network out of 408 around the world. Morocco has the most cities represented with six, followed by South Africa with five and Nigeria with three. Among the creative talents, 13 cities are represented for crafts and folk arts, three for film, nine for music, two for media and arts, three for gastronomy, four for literature and one for design.

What is significant about this data is not only that Africa has a significant number of cities represented, building on its reputation, skills, projection of soft power, history and tradition, but that some perhaps lesser well- known cities are included, as shown in the following table.

Table 5: UNESCO Creative Cities Network

City	Country	Recognition
Casablanca	Morocco	Media, Arts
Ouarzazate	Morocco	Film
Howick	South Africa	Crafts and Folk Art
Nkongsamba	Cameroon	Gastronomy
Asaba	Nigeria	Film
Bissau	Guinea Bissau	Music
Buffalo City	South Africa	Literature
Port Louis	Mauritius	Music
Nakuru	Kenya	Crafts and Folk Art
Bida	Nigeria	Crafts and Folk Art
Bohicon	Benin	Gastronomy
Hermanus	South Africa	Gastronomy

Essaouira	Morocco	Music
Praia	Cabo Verde	Music
Sokode	Togo	Crafts and Folk Art
Cairo	Egypt	Crafts and Folk Art
Cape Town	South Africa	Design
Tunis	Tunisia	Crafts and Folk Art
Tetouan	Morocco	Crafts and Folk Art
Ouagadougou	Burkina Faso	Crafts and Folk Art
Durban	South Africa	Literature
Lubumbashi	DRC	Crafts and Folk Art
Kinshasa	DRC	Music
Dakar	Senegal	Media, Arts
Brazzaville	Congo	Music
Aswan	Egypt	Crafts and Folk Art
Abuja	Nigeria	Literature

Bobo-Dioulasso	Burkina Faso	Crafts and Folk Art
Giza	Egypt	Film
Kisumu	Kenya	Music
Korhogo	Cote d'Ivoire	Music
Lubango	Angola	Crafts and Folk Art
Safi	Morocco	Crafts and Folk Art
Tangier	Morocco	Literature

Source: UNESCO Creative Cities Network

Case studies from the Network

Asaba, in Nigeria, established the first Film Village nationwide, a key aspect of Nollywood, which generates more than 1,000 movies per year, with the population of actors and associated staff in Asaba of around 100,000. These films are exported on a global scale, projecting immense soft power.

The Film Village hosts film conferences and international Artist Residency programmes, as well as platforms to showcase local talent. The city also comprises many renowned film producers and actors, as well as hugely popular craft, folk and literary industries. This facility and other cultural assets across the city serve as an important element of sustainable urban development.

Bohicon, in Benin, is renowned for gastronomy. Its particular speciality is dishes from Afitin, drawn from a condiment comprising sumbala seeds, to Houawélio, which is a fermented corn paste. The city has been active in organising tasting events and platforms. There is a further positive impact in terms of the proliferation of hotels, cafes, restaurants, and bars.

Kinshasa, capital of the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), has a rich history of music. With 10 million inhabitants, it is regarded as the bastion of Congolese rumba, a popular dance music now inscribed on UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list. "Music is to Kinshasa a shared social practice and a key enabler of intercultural dialogue and social cohesion," says UNESCO.

"In addition, the city is home to multiple recording studios including the Olympia, Ngoma and Loningisa, where pioneer musicians and bands such as African Jazz and Ok Jazz made their débuts as part of Congolese rumba's second wave movement". Big festivals are held there such as the International Stars Festival, the Jazz Kif Festival and the Pan African Music Festival. There are also many successful exchange programmes with other African and European cities.

Kinshasa offers a powerful example of why cultural depth is a reason for structural optimism. Why is this the case?

First, music in Kinshasa represents a shared social practice that strengthens social cohesion in a country that has faced prolonged political and economic strain. Cultural participation links ethnic groups, neighbourhoods, and generations. In societies managing diversity and historical tension, shared cultural identity reduces fragmentation. That is foundational for long-term stability.

Second, music is economic development. The festivals mentioned above attract tourists, create job, generate revenue, and flag a positive profile of the country. Recording studios, event organisers, fashion designers, instrument makers, promoters, and digital distributors are vital components of this architecture. Cultural industries are also youth driven.

Third, exchange programmes with other African and European cities means Kinshasa is linked firmly into global creative circuits. Cultural diplomacy represents soft power, an important component of positive reinforcement.

Fourth, creative resilience signals adaptive capacity. Kinshasa's music scene thrived through many years of political and economic volatility. That speaks to endurance and resilience and reflects how deeply entrenched the culture is.

The optimism, therefore, is structural. A city that generates cultural exports, employment and overseas connections while harnessing social cohesion speaks to bountiful optimism.

Kinshasa's music is not only heritage. It is momentum.

How we got there

City and urban development do not happen in a vacuum. They require deliberate, ambitious and supportive policies at the national and local levels to build, harness and develop creative talents, and address urban challenges. To that end, policy makers in various African countries have been active in investments and policy development.

For example, a number of African cities are establishing creative districts and cultural infrastructure through repurposing industrial areas, funding cultural centres, providing and supporting co-working spaces for artists and designers, and implementing zoning laws to facilitate creative districts.

Examples of these include the Maboneng Precinct in Johannesburg, creative tech and media hubs in Nairobi and contemporary art and cultural infrastructure in Dakar.

Other key efforts include digital creative economy policies, which align technology ecosystems with creative industries; events and festivals; and creative arts schools and university courses, films and music training programmes, design and digital arts education and creative entrepreneurship support.

Creative industries and cities development are pivotal to, and are at the intersection of, overall economic development, human capital, environmental, tourism and land use planning policies.

Conclusion

This chapter has shown that there is much to be optimistic about when it comes to creative cities in Africa. There are many examples of urban areas leading the way in Africa in the development of creative and cultural industries, strengthening cultural identity and fostering investment, both at home and from abroad.

African cities are highly competitive by world standards. They raise the profile and promise of African nations on the world stage. They also represent the solutions to complex challenges that confront nations today and into the future.

Chapter 10: Growth and prosperity

Improving Economic Outcomes

The previous chapters have demonstrated that African nations possess strong foundations for prosperity and that there is much to be optimistic about in respect of capabilities across the continent, be they innovation, ICT, entrepreneurship or the vibrant youth population, among many others.

~~As the Funnel of Optimism shows, the foundations and capabilities strengthen each other in a positive, virtuous cycle, giving rise to strong growth outcomes.~~

The Funnel of Optimism illustrates a simple idea: when the right foundations are in place and capabilities continue to improve, growth follows.

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This chapter builds on the earlier ones by pointing out that the optimism in and about Africa is reflected in strong overall economic performance and prospects, and in a range of social parameters. This is a recognition that improved economic outcomes are, importantly, being translated into stronger social outcomes, and overall prosperity.

There is little point to economic growth in its own right if it is not translated into social benefits and tangible gains for citizens.

The following table demonstrates economic growth over the past few years up to 2030 (sorted in descending order by 2025). It demonstrates generally good performance in growth with some outstanding examples.

Stellar past economic growth rates, and into the future, are found in: Ethiopia; Guinea; Rwanda; Benin; and Niger. These and other African countries have exhibited consistently higher growth rates than for the World as a whole and compared to various benchmark nations, as shown in the table.

In fact, many African countries are growing at two to three times the rate of advanced countries' rates. Growth at 4% to 5% compounds dramatically over time. This is a sustained, substantial structural shift for African economies towards higher growth trajectories. African countries are becoming a central driver of global growth in the coming years.

What is also important to note is the post-COVID-era resilience. Some countries are nudging double-digit growth levels just a few years after the worst pandemic in global history. This highlights a resilience and robustness in those African countries.

Growth in GDP offers opportunity for individuals, households and communities through access to better and higher paying jobs, greater consumption possibilities and higher revenue for governments.

This is not always the case, particularly where countries' growth is driven by narrow sectoral gains, often the case with resources sectors such as mining and oil and gas.

This includes countries such as Guinea, a major producer of bauxite and iron ore, but still a relatively poor country. Similarly, Niger, also in West Africa, is experiencing very high growth, but off a low base, with revenues dominated by extractive industries and large infrastructure projects. Yet, it has one of the lowest incomes in the world.

However, while 20 years ago Africa's growth story was mostly about commodities, it has become much more diversified over time with some of the most successful countries lacking the resources that were key drivers in the past.

For example, Ethiopia, which has long been one of the fastest-growing countries in Africa, benefits from investment, infrastructure development, hydropower and energy resources, services and agriculture.

In fact, services are now one of the biggest growth drivers in Africa, driven by sectors such as ICT and mobile phones, financial services, logistics, transport and tourism.

Table 1: GDP growth – Annual Percentage Change (sorted by 2025)

Real GDP growth	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	2030
Ethiopia	6.4	7.2	8.1	7.2	7.1	7.7	8	7.8	7.5
Guinea	4	6.2	6.1	7.2	10.5	10.7	10.8	11.3	7.8
Rwanda	8.2	8.3	8.9	7.1	7.5	7.4	7	7	7
Benin	6.3	6.4	7.5	7	6.7	6.6	6.5	6	6
Niger	11.9	2.4	10.3	6.6	6.7	6.5	6	6	6
Côte d'Ivoire	6.4	6.5	6	6.4	6.4	6.5	6.6	7	6.8
Uganda	6.2	4.9	6.3	6.4	7.6	8.4	6.9	6.4	6.1
Djibouti	5.2	7.4	6.5	6	6	6	5.5	5.5	5.5
The Gambia	5.5	5	5.3	6	5.1	5	5	5	5
Senegal	4	4.3	6.4	6	3	3.3	3.8	4.1	4.6
Tanzania	4.7	5.1	5.5	6	6.3	6.5	6.5	6.4	6.2
Zimbabwe	6.1	5.3	1.7	6	4.6	3.6	3.5	3.5	3.5
Zambia	5.2	5.4	4	5.8	6.4	6.5	5.1	4.8	4.8
DRC	9.2	8.5	6.5	5.3	5.3	5.4	5.4	5.4	5.4
Cabo Verde	15.8	4.8	7.2	5.2	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.7	4.5
Togo	5.8	5.6	5.3	5.2	5.5	5.5	5.5	5.5	5.5
Guinea Bissau	4.6	5.2	4.8	5.1	5	5	4.5	4.5	4.2
Mali	3.5	4.7	4.7	5	5.4	5.2	5.1	5.1	5.1
Kenya	4.9	5.7	4.7	4.8	4.9	5	5	5	5

Real GDP growth	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029	2030
Liberia	4.8	4.6	4	4.6	5.4	5.6	5.9	5.5	5.5
Central African Republic	0.8	-0.1	1.9	3	3.3	3.6	3.8	3.7	3.9
Somalia	2.7	4.2	4.1	3	3.3	3.6	3.8	4	4.1
São Tomé and Príncipe	0.2	0.4	1.1	2.9	4.7	3.9	3.5	3.5	3.5
Africa (Region)	4.5	3.4	3.4	4.2	4.3	4.4	4.4	4.5	4.5
India	7.6	9.2	6.5	6.6	6.2	6.4	6.5	6.5	6.5
China	3.1	5.4	5	4.8	4.2	4.2	4	3.7	3.4
Emerging Market and Developing Economies	4.3	4.7	4.3	4.2	4	4.2	4.1	4.1	4
Emerging and Developing Asia	4.7	6.1	5.3	5.2	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.5
Major Advanced Economies (G7)	2.7	1.8	1.7	1.4	1.6	1.6	1.6	1.5	1.4
World	3.8	3.5	3.3	3.2	3.1	3.2	3.2	3.2	3.1

Source: IMF.

There is much to be optimistic about Africa in terms of foreign and domestic investment as an underpinning of growth.

Historically, the Big Five for FDI in Africa as measured by UNCTAD are Egypt, South Africa, Nigeria, Morocco, and Ethiopia although the numbers and ranking change, often driven by one or two very large investments.

While much of it still goes into resources, it has become more diversified covering sectors such as automotive, telecommunications, infrastructure, industrial parks and financial services, reflecting the changing economic trends on the continent.

These revenues are important additions to capacity, and transfers of knowledge, skills and technology, among other capabilities.

Strong economic growth should also be viewed through the lens of overall changes in living standards, as measured by GDP per capita. The following table, drawing on World Bank data, and adapted by the authors, demonstrates how living standards have shifted between 2000 and 2024. The IMF defines living standards by the categories of low (L), lower medium (LM), upper medium (UM) and high income (H).

We categorise *positive transformation* as countries that have improved their standard of living and held their position subsequently, *consistent* as those that have retained their standard of living over the long haul, *fluctuating* as those that have moved in and out of categories regularly and *negative transformation* as those whose living standards have declined.

As the chart below shows, 17 countries have experienced a positive transformation. These countries have principally transformed from low-income to lower-medium economies on the basis of GDP per capita. Namibia has moved into the upper medium category, while Seychelles has moved into the higher income ranks, a significant gain.

Thirty countries have maintained a consistent ranking, ranging from lower, lower-medium and upper-medium income levels. Six countries have fluctuated across various income levels over the years, while only one country, South Sudan, has experienced a negative transformation to a low-income country.

What the data is clearly showing is that nearly all African countries have either maintained or enhanced their living standards. These are long-run structural changes, not cyclical fluctuations.

Economic gains are not fleeting but are being consolidated over time. This is a compelling case to be optimistic about Africa. For countries perpetually cast as falling behind the rest of the world, the data shows a strong counter argument. This finding dispels the 'deficit' arguments about countries in Africa.

The presence of countries such as Seychelles, Mauritius, South Africa, Gabon and Namibia in higher income brackets demonstrates that upward mobility is achievable in the African context. This creates a powerful demonstration effect for other economies.

Table 2: Changes in Living standards between 2000 and 2024

Consistent
Botswana (UM)
Burkino Faso (L)
Burundi (L)
Cabo Verde (LM)
Central African Republic (CAR) L
Chad (L)
Democratic Republic of Congo (L)
Djibouti (LM)
Egypt (LM)
Eritrea (L)
Eswatini (L)
Ethiopia (L)
Gabon (UM)
Gambia (L)
Guinea Bissaau (L)
Liberia (L)
Libya (UM)
Madagascar (L)
Malawi (L)
Mali (L)
Mauritius (UM)
Morocco (LM)
Mozambique (L)
Niger (L)
Rwanda (L)
Sierra Leone (L)
Somalia (L)
South Africa (UM)
Togo (L)
Uganda (L)

Positive Transformation
Benin (L-LM)
Cameroon (L-LM)
Comoros (L-LM)
Republic of Congo (L-LM)
Cote Divorie (L-LM)
Ghana (L-LM)
Guinea (L-LM)
Kenya (L-LM)
Lesotho (L-LM)
Mauritania (L-LM)
Namibia (LM-UM)
Nigeria (L-LM)
Sao Tome (L-LM)
Seychelles (UM-H)
Tanzania (L-LM)
Zambia (L-LM)
Zimbabwe (L-LM)

Fluctuating
Algeria (Between LM and UM)
Angola (Between L-UM, LM)
Equatorial Guinea (across all categories)
Senegal (Between L and LM
Sudan (Between L and LM)
Tunisia (Between LM and UM)

Negative Transformation
South Sudan (LM down to L)

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Source: World Bank. Author adaptations.

Projecting into the future, estimates from the IMF, listed in Table 3, show that all countries in Africa are expected to exhibit improvements in GDP per capita by 2030.

Some distinct patterns and clusters of growth emerge, pointing to a multilayered nuance to the African experience.

Some countries (not shown), such as Ethiopia and Rwanda, are expected to achieve growth in GDP per capita up to 10 times on 2000 levels, while another group including Ghana, Mauritius, Djibouti and Seychelles, is expected to achieve growth of between four and five times 2000 levels.

Others again, such as Morocco and Namibia. are also expected to increase GDP per capita growth. All this indicates that growth is broad based: both low-income and middle-income countries are improving simultaneously.

Seychelles and Mauritius are expected to leap forward in terms of living standards, ahead of other benchmark groups, except for the major advanced economies, but they are likely to close the gap with these nations.

Thus, the data shows that for a number of African countries, living standards are on the rise, and the populations of these nations can most likely afford better lifestyles.

More particularly, this means rising consumption capacity, expanding middle classes, higher tax revenues for governments to provide services more effectively, and greater investment opportunities for businesses.

Table 3: GDP Per Capita Levels (purchasing power parity international dollars per capita) – Listed by 2030 projections

	2000	**2025**	**2030**
Seychelles	13,460.7	42,110.4	51,887.0
Mauritius	9,161.7	33,023.7	43,104.3
Gabon	12,644.7	24,738.8	27,801.3
Egypt	6,457.3	21,758.8	27,026.1
Botswana	8,341.8	19,053.1	23,875.4
North Africa	6,385.6	18,701.4	22,956.2
Algeria	7,447.5	18,509.4	21,459.3
Libya	15,686.3	17,930.6	21,024.1
Equatorial Guinea	9,515.1	20,493.8	20,967.1
South Africa	8,052.9	16,049.8	17,598.0

	2000	2025	2030
Cabo Verde	3,391.4	12,335.3	16,462.5
Eswatini	4,278.1	13,310.1	16,271.7
South Asia	1,997.3	11,254.2	15,761.4
Morocco	3,594.5	11,437.1	14,535.0
Namibia	5,290.2	12,341.5	14,378.9
Djibouti	2,299.6	9,407.7	12,798.7
Nigeria	2,808.4	9,488.2	11,357.6
Angola	3,753.8	10,216.6	10,715.4
Ghana	2,113.3	8,410.3	10,709.7
Mauritania	3,186.7	8,774.9	10,624.8
Côte d'Ivoire	3,199.0	8,112.7	10,605.2
Kenya	2,473.7	7,556.1	9,665.5
Africa (Region)	3,005.2	7,857.8	9,454.5
Sub-Saharan Africa (Region)	2,286.0	6,017.3	7,253.4
Asia and Pacific	4,201.7	21,663.2	28,199.1
Emerging and Developing Asia	2,599.2	19,305.1	25,901.9
Emerging market and developing economies	4,155.2	18,419.9	23,316.3
Major advanced economies (G7)	32,012.7	74,854.2	87,199.0
World	8,342.0	26,061.6	31,723.3
China	2,633.9	29,191.1	38,986.0
India	1,890.4	12,101.0	17,277.8
Brazil	8,333.6	23,309.6	28,037.5

Source: IMF. Sorted by 2030 statistics.

International poverty lines

Strong, and mostly sustainable, economic growth rates are bringing down poverty levels, slowly but surely. The preconditions for reducing poverty have and continue to be created.

Unfortunately, the COVID-19 pandemic effectively erased many years of poverty reduction, with the World Bank stating that it likely pushed between 20 and 40 million people into extreme poverty at its peak.

This highlights the precarious nature of addressing poverty. The improvements have also been partly obscured by high population growth rates in most African nations. But efforts to fight poverty are continuing in earnest.

International poverty lines are a stringent test for countries to meet. The data shows that the percentage of people below the international poverty line are shrinking, often dramatically, for many countries. These include Benin, Côte D'Ivoire, Senegal, Morocco, Egypt, Mauritania and Namibia.

These data show that literally, tens of millions of people have been lifted out of poverty and extreme deprivation as measured on a global scale. Even where poverty rates remain stubbornly high, they have been halved in one generation.

The decline in poverty rates across many African countries is one of the most significant development achievements of recent decades.

Five countries now have poverty rates less than Brazil, and six countries less than India, two key benchmark nations. For example, in 2000 Morocco had 16.8% of its population below the international poverty line. By 2024 this had shrunk to 3.7%.

Table 4: Percentage of Population below the International Poverty Line 2000 and 2024 (or latest available data) %

	2000	**2024**
Mauritius	1.1	0.5
Seychelles	0.6	0.7
Tunisia	10.5	0.7
Egypt	4.1	1.4
Morocco	16.8	3.7
Gabon	9.2	3.8
Sudan	13.1	10.1
Mauritania	30.7	10.2
Guinea	50.3	11.7
Sâo Tomé and Principe	17.3	13
Cabo Verde	37.1	14.6
Senegal	63.9	17.9

Côte D'Ivoire	44.7	20.9
Botswana	34.8	21.4
The Gambia	55.2	22
Namibia	47.6	22.9
Djibouti	32.3	25.4
Cameroon	30.8	26.7
Benin	70.5	27.2
South Africa	47.9	31.2
China	48.1	0
Brazil	17.5	3.8
India	46.4	5.3

Source: UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) indicators database. Sorted by 2024 data.

And poverty, especially extreme poverty, is very sensitive to small increases in incomes at low levels.

There are a variety of reasons both macro and microeconomic which together go a long way to explain the declining poverty. Apart from the macro narrative of stronger economic growth, there is the associated structural shift in a variety of African countries including:

- Improved governance; shifts out of subsistence farming and into urban areas, as well as greater levels of agricultural productivity
- Improved demographics and the young vibrant population (although the fertility rates remain high by standards of non-African countries, they are falling and population growth has slowed compared to previous decades)
- Expansion of social protection
- Regional trade and integration, which has helped improve job creation and investment opportunities
- Improvements in education and health outcomes; and
- Acceleration of technology.

Global Social Progress Index

In a holistic sense, the Social Progress Index captures the integrated range of social parameters across 171 countries, and comprises basic needs, foundations of well-being, and opportunity.

The data on the 2026 Index shows that out of 171 countries measured, seven African nations are ranked in the top 100 — Mauritius (56), Algeria (79), Tunisia (89), South Africa (91), Cabo Verde (94), Morocco (99) and Botswana (100).

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Mauritius leads Africa and performs strongly on basic human needs including access to clean water, sanitation, electricity and health care. Another group of countries, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, South Africa, Cabo Verde and Morocco, are strong regional performers, drawing on improvements in education, healthcare, and basic needs.

Yet a further group — Botswana, Namibia, and Ghana — demonstrate solid outcomes relative to peers despite having lower scores.

By pillar, the data confirms Mauritius, Algeria and Tunisia's strengths in providing basic human needs (clean water and sanitation, nutrition and basic medical care, shelter and personal safety). These results reflect growing investments in social service provision, and in meeting the needs of citizens.

Countries such as Mauritius, Algeria, Botswana, South Africa and Tunisia stand out for the pillar on Foundations of Wellbeing (education access, access to information, health and wellness and environment quality).

Even where progress is slower, primary education and literacy improvements are taking place in several countries. Improving the foundations of well-being, especially education and health, are important in societal engagement, resilience and can assist in reducing inequality over time.

On opportunity, which measures personal rights, freedom of choice, inclusion and access to advanced education, South Africa is a clear leader. Several African countries also score well on political stability and civic participation, demonstrating growing engagement by citizens in the political and governmental processes, as well as improved governance.

What is also noticeable for some countries such as Algeria, Cabo Verde, Senegal and South Africa, social progress rankings exceed the ranking for GDP per capita. What this means is that in these countries, there is a high efficiency in development in the delivery of programmes and services which are needed by citizens, and that social progress in a sense is stronger than capacity to pay.

When viewed over time, however, the gains become more noticeable. Some 30 countries have improved their ranking over 15 years, between 2011 and 2025.

It is, however, worth noting that the statistics can obscure other problems. In the case of South Africa, it is a dependency of a growing number of people on handouts. Grants reach more than 40% of the population in one form or another and more if family members who depend on grant recipients are included.

This is one reason that poverty has been held at bay for many, given the high levels of unemployment mentioned elsewhere, but it is a drain on the fiscus despite stimulating some economic activity. Commentators also point to the fact that this vast social grant network is supported by a limited number of people paying income tax relative to the population – just under eight million according to the 2025 budget.

Table 5: Global Social Progress Index 2026 (out of 171 countries) – Rank in Brackets

Country	Overall	Basic Needs	Foundations of Wellbeing	Opportunity	GDP Per Capita PPP	GDP Per Capita Rank
Mauritius	72.28 (56)	84.83 (59)	70.73 (61)	61.28 (54)	27,317.19	57
Algeria	67.62 (79)	85.37 (53)	65.36 (88)	52.12 (97)	15,442.12	87/165
Tunisia	66.53 (89)	79.64 (90)	63.51 (98)	56.44 (76)	12,713.55	96
South Africa	66.25 (91)	64.10 (120)	68.77 (74)	65.87 (46)	13,598.79	94
Cabo Verde	65.79 (94)	72.24 (110)	61.92 (102)	63.22 (52)	9,907.59	106
Morocco	63.19 (99)	81.30 (80)	58.46 (113)	49.80 (108)	9,065.91	110
Botswana	62.96 (100)	59.92 (129)	68.87 (72)	60.09 (61)	18,068.51	77
Libya	60.43 (104)	78.73 (94)	58.40 (114)	44.14 (127)	12,275.91	98
Namibia	60.06 (106)	56.18 (133)	66.84 (84)	57.17 (72)	10, 281.34	104
Ghana	59.35 (107)	62.02 (125)	60.25 (107)	55.79 (79)	7,093.61	115
Sâo Tomé and Principe	58.43 (110)	63.06 (123)	59.99 (110)	52.24 (96)	5,480.44	126
Kenya	57.43 (115)	54.81 (137)	67.61 (81)	49.87 (106)	5,823.41	123
Egypt	56.49 (119)	82.43 (70)	43.29 (162)	43.76 (128)	16,798.15	80
Gabon	56.00 (121)	60.32 (128)	58.62 (111)	49.08 (110)	18,923.09	74
Senegal	55.61 (122)	63.19 (122)	55.41 (122)	48.22 (113)	4,495.89	131
Tanzania	54.87 (123)	55.87 (136)	60.72 (106)	48.03 (114)	3,713.26	139
Côte D'Ivoire	51.44 (127)	56.11 (135)	53.50 (130)	44.73 (125)	6,733.15	119

Country	Overall	Basic Needs	Foundations of Wellbeing	Opportunity	GDP Per Capita PPP	GDP Per Capita Rank
The Gambia	51.43 (128)	52.16 (143)	53.61 (128)	48.53 (111)	3,030.97	144
Zambia	51.20 (129)	46.76 (158)	57.03 (118)	49.82 (107)	3,716.04	138
UK	85.54 (18)	89.04 (28)	87.11 (18)	80.48 (20)	52,517.98	26
France	85.07 (23)	89.26 (21)	86.99 (19)	78.95 (23)	54,464.98	23
US	81.76 (32)	85.95 (51)	81.59 (31)	77.75 (25)	75,491.61	7
Brazil	72.74 (51)	80.41 (84)	72.36 (55)	65.45 (47)	19,647.91	72
China	68.82 (73)	86.08 (50)	68.08 (80)	52.31 (95)	23,845.62	64
India	58.79 (109)	72.31 (109)	54.72 (125)	49.33 (109)	9,817.07	108
World	63.75 (96)	74.78 (103)	63.26 (99)	53.21 (82)	20,862.96	69

Source: Social Progress Imperative's Global Social Progress Index 2026. Scores out of 100 and table ordered according by rankings, highest to lowest.

Table 6: Global Social Progress Index - Score and Rank Change 2011-2025

Country	Score 2011	Score 2025	2011 (Rank)	2025 (Rank)
Algeria	60.12	67.62	88	79
Angola	38.24	45.26	158	150
Benin	46.78	50.64	127	132
Botswana	56.40	62.96	104	100
Burkina Faso	42.53	45.56	143	149
Burundi	36.85	39.43	162	165
Cabo Verde	61.40	65.79	83	94
Comoros	47.83	49.94	126	137

Commented [dg72]: We had thought to cut off country lists at 20 or 25. This covers all 54. Need an executive decision on this. Or list 20 and put the whole table in the Index at the bottom

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Country	Score 2011	Score 2025	2011 (Rank)	2025 (Rank)
Cameroon	41.16	46.44	148	147
Congo	38.50	42.63	156	160
DRC	34.63	39.44	166	164
Chad	26.06	29.60	171	169
CAR	29.61	28.78	169	170
Côte D'Ivoire	42.97	51.44	138	127
Djibouti	43.41	50.74	136	131
Egypt	52.65	56.49	113	119
Eswatini	39.95	49.59	153	139
Equatorial Guinea	38.18	43.22	159	157
Eritrea	36.57	39.12	164	166
Ethiopia	39.97	44.35	152	151
Gabon	49.64	56	119	121
The Gambia	41.44	51.43	147	128
Ghana	52.81	59.35	112	107
Guinea	34.51	40.94	167	163
Guinea Bissau	38.90	46.35	155	148
Kenya	49.46	57.43	120	115
Lesotho	44.32	50.42	132	133
Liberia	40.09	44.12	151	153
Libya	56.31	60.43	105	104
Madagascar	39.16	42.73	154	158
Malawi	43.74	48.44	134	143
Mali	42.81	43.91	141	154
Mauritania	41.66	44.20	146	152

Country	Score 2011	Score 2025	2011 (Rank)	2025 (Rank)
Mauritius	69.65	72.28	47	56
Morocco	56.46	63.19	103	99
Mozambique	42.80	47.01	142	146
Namibia	53.87	60.06	109	106
Niger	38.29	41.05	157	162
Nigeria	42.47	49.94	144	137
Rwanda	44.39	50.32	131	134
Sâo Tomé and Principe	51.18	58.43	116	110
Senegal	48.39	55.61	124	122
Sierra Leone	36.54	43.91	165	154
Seychelles	-	-	-	-
Tunisia	62.34	66.53	77	89
South Africa	59.51	66.25	92	91
Somalia	33.77	42.18	168	161
South Sudan	28.68	27.71	170	171
Sudan	37.73	43.68	160	156
Tanzania	45.60	54.87	128	123
Togo	40.72	47.36	149	145
Uganda	43.49	49.06	135	140
Zambia	42.23	51.20	145	129
Zimbabwe	42.92	50.23	140	135

Source: Social Progress Imperative's Social Progress Index 2026.

The data from the Social Progress Index in Table 6 demonstrates that long-term investments in people-focused services is delivering a significant dividend for many nations. Countries with legacy investments in health systems, schooling and universal services tend to be those with the strongest social progress outcomes.

Even modest improvements, when accumulated over time, lead to meaningful gains in well-being.

The data suggests that Africa's development is not episodic, but cumulative—each gain builds on the last.

The Social Progress Index for 2026 shows that some African countries rank in the top 10 in the world on certain indicators. For example, Algeria is number one in the world on a range of indictors canvassing food intake, household air pollution, mobile telephone users and access to electricity. Thus, while these countries' overall rankings may be either mid-lower tier, this table demonstrates some clear areas of strength, something to build on and a cause for optimism.

Botswana and South Africa are number one in the world for gender parity in secondary education attainment, while Libya is number one in the world for mobile telephone users, as are Morocco and Tunisia for access to electricity. Nigeria is third in the world for tacking health problems and Ghana ninth.

The data dispels the much-repeated narrative about two things: one that Africa is an amorphous whole; and that countries in the continent lack access to basic services, are beset by health concerns and subject to repressive politics.

Other indicators drawn from various sources point to the changing landscape among African countries.

First, data from the Global Hunger Index shows that nearly all African countries have improved their score on this index over a 25-year period from 2000 to 2025. The Global Hunger Index measures undernourishment, child wasting, child stunting and child mortality. This is testament to improvements in agriculture and food production and distribution, through productivity gains, modernisation of practices and application of technologies in such areas as precision farming.

In particular, Senegal, Algeria, Cameroon, Comoros, Togo, Tanzania, Rwanda, Djibouti, Malawi, Burkina Faso, Ethiopia, Sierra Leone, and Mozambique have either doubled or more than doubled scores over this period.

As it stands, four African countries are in the top 50 on the latest rankings data: Tunisia, Algeria, Morocco, and Cabo Verde.

Other data shows that nearly all countries have improved markedly on access to safely managed sanitation services, with particularly strong growth rates in Comoros, Côte D'Ivoire, Egypt, Ghana, Lesotho, and Mozambique. Further, in most African nations health worker density has been on the rise, another example of a key social metric improving.

In conclusion, the data in this chapter points to an optimistic outlook for countries in the region. ~~To be sure, in some cases, progress has been slow and halting, and uneven, but for~~In many countries, economic growth has been rapid, well over global levels, which has facilitated social improvement, although noting that in some cases social progress is ranked higher than economic parameters.

Long-term investments in basic community services, improved access to critical health and education, and growth driven by the foundational elements and capabilities discussed in previous chapters, point to an optimistic future.

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Commented [MM75]: What does this mean?

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~~Chapter 11:~~ Optimism Index

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~~Africa's Good News~~The Optimism Index

~~This final chapter~~This section brings together data to produce an Optimism Index for African countries. It measures the extent to which we can be optimistic about nations on the continent.

The index canvasses data according to the elements of the funnel as outlined in the introductory chapter. It draws on data in the text and incorporates both objective and subjective data. The index is important in terms of guiding investors: informing policy makers in their development of priorities; shaping narratives, offsetting the "deficit" approach so common in global discussions about Africa; and empowering youth and females.

More fundamentally, the innovation measures not just progress but a belief in better futures for Africans.

Higher scores indicate greater levels of innovation and entrepreneurship, peace, strong governance systems, solidarity, female empowerment, strength of creative outputs, ICT readiness and performance, youth inclusion, and the power of the diaspora.

Weaker scores indicate lesser performance across these issues.

This index sheds light on the future prospects of African nations. More specifically, it signals future opportunity and underscores the importance of youth to the future. A confidence in rules shapes investment and civic engagement, while technology and innovation are cornerstones of the "leapfrogging agenda".

Improved living standards are an important predictor of optimism, while cultural outputs shape identity, pride, and external perceptions. These are all important aspects of optimistic futures.

These data are critical because optimism precedes investment, entrepreneurship and economic transformation.

An optimistic outlook encourages businesses to take risks and is a positive signal for investors. It enables a greater willingness of people to expand horizons, promote innovation and engage more in civil life.

In preparing this index, a number of considerations have been taken into account.

Countries have been chosen according to whether they are lower-medium, upper-medium or high-income countries, along with various interesting cases.

For example, Rwanda has been included even though it does not technically make the definition of a medium-income country. However, it is moving rapidly ahead with development by putting in place robust economic policies and improved governance.

Some countries have been removed from the initial set of countries due to insufficient data points.

The Optimism Index is limited to 15 countries (chosen as described above) and can be considered a pilot for further extensive work and analysis on the topic.

The following table shows the Optimism Index Scores (out of 100) and rankings for the 15 countries. The metrics used and methodology is found in the appendix to this chapter. Note a simple approach is used as more complex statistical manipulations are outside the scope of this book.

Optimism Index 2026

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Country	Score (out of 100)	Rank – Top 15
Seychelles	69.87	1
Mauritius	67.41	2
Cabo Verde	61.65	3
South Africa	53.62	4

Tunisia	48.29	5
Kenya	48.16	6
Rwanda	46.76	7
Egypt	46.33	8
Morocco	45.00	9
Ghana	43.94	10
Nigeria	42.62	11
Gabon	42.42	12
Botswana	42.29	13
Namibia	42.05	14
Uganda	40.34	15

While the scores in themselves are not necessarily high for a number of countries, we isolate four main types:

- Leaders (60 and above)
- Solid optimism (50-59)
- Emerging (45-49)
- Nascent (40-44)

There are three countries for which strong leadership in optimism is found. These are Seychelles, Mauritius, and Cabo Verde, the former two being small island states lending credence to the idea that small size is not a constraint to development and that advantage can be gained by having open economies and being globally integrated.

The three countries stand out for their sound governance, entrepreneurship, development of innovation and ICT, and youth metrics — all essential elements of optimism. Generally, these countries score well on all or most of the metrics.

In particular, Seychelles is a standout nation, sitting in first place with a score of 69.87. It has strengths particularly in sound governance, mobile connectivity, business ownership by women, entrepreneurship enablers, living standards and its ranking on the UN Human Development Index.

Mauritius is a leader in innovation being the best of the African countries in the represented countries, as well as having very high rates of connectivity and in social progress indicators. Interestingly, Mauritius leads African countries in the table for Happiness as reflected in the World Happiness Report. Happiness and confidence are important elements of the subjective metrics that underpin optimism.

Cabo Verde is a striking example of being entrepreneurship driven. It is first in class for new business density and performs well on females with business ownership (as do Seychelles and Mauritius) and as top managers. Its entrepreneurial base is dynamic in adding jobs, and in being relatively unconstrained by financial barriers. Cabo Verde also benefits from having a robust diaspora.

Below the top three is South Africa with a solid score of 53.62, the only country with a score in the 50s. It is a large, diversified economy, with positives in satisfaction with life among its people, innovation, connectivity, and peace. The gender gap is closing, but there remain issues with women in ownership. There is also improvement needed in the small business sector in

terms of job growth and business dynamism, and the country also experiences high levels of inequality.

South Africa's GDP per capita is on the lower side compared to the top tier countries, as is its UN Human Development Index Rank. Despite its weaknesses, including low growth rates, South Africa is in striking distance of the top tier.

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The next group of countries are emerging. These are Tunisia, Kenya, Rwanda, Egypt, and Morocco. They are characterised by growing reforms to their governance and some strong sectoral strengths, in for example, services and manufacturing.

As these countries are tightly clustered, some movement between the ranks of the countries in this group can be expected with small shifts in scores.

There is considerable potential in this group. For example, Tunisia has favourable innovation and creative scores, on the back of the strength of its education system. However, the gender gap remains an issue to address.

Kenya performs well on ICT connectivity, reflecting its growing importance as an ICT hub, while it performs solidly in peace (despite sporadic and sometimes violent protests in Nairobi in recent years) and governance metrics. It is also very strong in solidarity as reflected in donations and volunteering within its population, and it is increasingly becoming the preferred country for multinational companies to locate their headquarters in Africa.

Rwanda is emerging as a result of its proactive governance systems and is assuming a leadership role in ICT and communications. It is also a strong performer in its entrepreneurial base, including job expansion and access to finance, and introduction of new products and services. However, its social progress is constrained, as reflected by the Social Progress Index.

Egypt performs well on innovation and connectivity, reflecting its traditional strengths in research and STEM, for example. It has the best performance of all countries in upper secondary completion rates and features strongly in the Commonwealth Youth Index.

However, governance is a major challenge in Egypt, due to the dominance of the state in economic ~~life~~ and high levels of public debt. Peace and closing the gender gap are also weaknesses.

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Morocco performs well in innovation, connectivity and youth data (Commonwealth Youth Index) and extremely well on creative outputs. However, like other North African nations, it has challenges in terms of the significant gender gap and peace issues.

Finally, the last tier of countries is nascent optimists with scores of between 40 and 44. These are a mix of resource-rich and diversified economies and include countries with high potential such as Nigeria and Ghana, which are among the biggest economies in the region.

Some of these countries have strengths, such as easy access to finance in Uganda and youth engagement in the labour market. But these are not as widespread or as sustained as the more highly ranked countries.

In conclusion, small states dominate the rankings, suggesting that governance is easier and less complex in countries with small geographical areas and low population numbers, and that

there are greater institutional coherence and strong engagement with the external economy in matters of trade and investment.

Large, diversified economies such as Nigeria, Egypt and South Africa are mid ranked, with scale bringing many issues, including governance challenges, population growth and inequality.

Most countries sit in the range of 42-49, suggesting a shared development trajectory, while ranks 5-10 are separated only by five points, suggesting a highly competitive environment in which smallish reforms produce significant outcomes.

Importantly, in the table, no country is below 40, suggesting that there is a strong base for improvement and latent potential.

Appendix 1

Funnel Data and Data Sources

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FUNNEL ELEMENT	METRIC
Peace	Global Peace Index
Solidarity	Donors as a % of population Donations as a % of income Volunteers as a % of population World Economic Forum Gender Gap
Governance	Mo Ibrahim Index World Bank Governance Indicators
Innovation	Global Innovation Index UN Global Knowledge Index % of firms that introduced a new product/service over the last three years
Entrepreneurship	New Business Density % Women in ownership % Women with top manager Firms that added jobs Rate of job expansion % of firms that are fully constrained by finance
ICT	GSMA Mobile Connectivity Index Network Readiness Index
Diaspora	Emigration Rate Remittances/GDP
Youth	Commonwealth Youth Index

	NEET Completion rates - lower secondary rate Completion rates - upper secondary rate
Creative cities	Urbanisation rate Creative Outputs (from Global Innovation Index) Cultural vibrancy Index
Growth	GDP per capita Social Progress Index UN HDI
Outlook for individuals and countries (not part of Filter)	Gallup World Poll Mood Survey World Happiness Report Afrobarometer Country Heading in the Right Direction

Methodological considerations

A simple index methodology is applied here. Individual metrics are scaled to 100 and averaged to produce overall scores out of 100. The countries are then ranked from best to least.

Choice of countries is based on middle- and upper-income status and one or two interesting countries. Only countries with at least 70% of available metrics are considered. In some cases, there are gaps in data.

Equal weightings are applied across all metrics. Data is for the latest year only not as a time series. Data is within the last three years across all metrics.

Appendix 2

World Governance Indicators 2024 (out of 100)

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	Voice and Accountability	Political Stability	Govt Effectiveness	Regulatory Quality	Rule of Law	Control of Corruption
Algeria	38.50	54.05	46.46	42.99	44.97	35.84
Angola	38.32	56.10	36.07	42.67	36.83	35.25
Benin	50.19	59.01	47.74	50.49	49.87	42.98
Botswana	62.02	83.53	59.45	61.20	62.34	60.63
Burkina Faso	39.97	33.33	34.33	46.57	41.75	42.74
Burundi	30.73	42.38	31.78	42.03	34.54	18.25
Cabo Verde	70.70	79.04	59.41	55.57	64.27	66.90

Cameroon	35.12	39.30	35.77	43.37	35.39	23.07
CAR	33.90	34.58	20.69	34.86	27.45	21.34
Chad	30.27	35.51	29.94	37.71	32.10	19.70
Comoros	35.18	62.11	27.84	35.17	37.50	24.76
DRC	35.61	29.70	18.41	34.60	28.97	17.18
Congo	33.84	61.48	29.75	36.70	36.68	19.04
Côte D'Ivoire	46.06	51.48	45.20	52.23	47.01	42.09
Djibouti	35.06	56.39	41.75	41.41	39.58	29.82
Egypt	28.83	49.19	49.45	46.99	44.03	31.12
Equatorial Guinea	26.65	63.49	28.35	32.80	30.45	18.04
Eritrea	16.77	53.79	23.03	22.76	25.94	14.80
Eswatini	33.27	53.38	36.15	44.80	42.17	31.96
Ethiopia	35.104	33.696	38.780	41.721	38.912	38.992
Gabon	38.98	61.16	40.31	43.45	37.07	28.89
Gambia	53.66	65.59	40.92	44.39	50.18	41.09
Ghana	60.43	66.09	52.50	53.45	57.89	43.94
Guinea	35.68	48.17	34.07	40.80	37.21	24.08
Guinea Bissau	43.22	55.33	24.75	36.09	35.71	20.61
Kenya	50.65	42.74	45.55	49.60	48.97	31.62
Lesotho	54.13	61.47	38.76	47.22	49.97	41.73
Liberia	54.89	61.99	27.11	41.59	42.03	26.65
Libya	33.47	33.50	23.74	27.43	27.74	16.85
Madagascar	44.15	57.69	34.56	43.06	41.77	27.41
Mali	35.48	23.34	26.31	42.84	38.13	28
Malawi	54.93	59.40	37.23	45.64	54.45	34.72
Mauritania	40.65	56.34	36.93	42.59	42.10	28.95

Mauritius	63.31	79.39	66.22	69.69	67.96	54.75
Morocco	44.13	58.36	54.77	54.44	50.63	37.36
Mozambique	39.25	35.86	37.42	42.82	36.40	26.36
Namibia	62.74	75.23	53.27	56.99	62.61	50.42
Niger	39.860	35.772	36.375	42.838	40.688	35.368
Nigeria	44.13	31.69	31.77	44.87	39.63	25.29
Rwanda	46.54	65.15	58.12	59.11	58.69	60.52
São Tomé and Principe	59.73	74.25	37.37	40.81	50.89	51.58
Senegal	57.13	61.99	55.90	51.05	53.44	50.14
Seychelles	67.95	81.55	63.53	61.01	67.24	72.77
Sierra Leone	47.87	58.21	32.54	38.16	42.53	33.64
South Africa	67.48	55.35	46.95	53.91	57.27	43.97
South Sudan	23.74	40.45	9.09	24.43	23.02	6.06
Sudan	23.88	31.32	16.46	28.64	26.44	16.33
Tanzania	45.56	59.24	45.65	46.42	48.03	41.90
Togo	39.84	52.07	35.76	48.43	46.07	34.43
Tunisia	44.883	50.097	46.687	48.710	50.692	43.399
Uganda	39.12	48.43	44.53	46.59	44.25	25.26
Zambia	49.72	64.17	40.98	48.23	47.31	38.61
Zimbabwe	34.80	48.52	32.14	36.28	36.12	22.52
UK	79.61	70.30	74.38	78.70	78.82	78.41
US	72.37	64.27	77.78	76.19	73.52	69.86
Brazil	62.39	57	46.98	50.22	49.28	39.58
China	27.91	63.28	68.76	53.74	46.99	49.65
India	55.47	52.47	59.21	53.35	56.29	41.88
France	76.95	61.77	74.69	72.94	73.81	72.51

Source: World Bank.